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Happening today

● **COMMERCE AND INDUSTRY**
Minister Piyush Goyal will lead a business delegation to Japan for a four-day visit to boost trade and investment ties. Japan last year set an investment target of 10 trillion yen (about Rs 60,000 cr) in India over a decade.

● **THE NATIONAL SECURITY**
Strategies Conference begins in New Delhi. More than 850 officers from various security and police forces are expected to deliberate on contemporary issues and challenges related to national security.

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNY
Is this the E20 Season? Govt seems too spirited on multiple fronts.



THE WORLD PAGE 12



U.S. MEMORANDUM BEST PATH OUT OF WAR, SAYS IRAN'S PEZESHKIAN

BANGLADESH OPEN TO JOINING SAUDI-PAK-TURKEY PACT, SAY MINISTERS

EXPLAINED PAGE 9

FIVE YEARS ON, HOW INDIA HAS WARMED UP TO THE TALIBAN

INCIDENT THAT LED TO INDIA-CANADA DIPLOMATIC FIRESTORM

3 years after Nijjar's killing, tape out: Terrorist Brar claims 'we had to do it'

Brar claims he and his associates killed separatist who used minors to push drugs

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 23

THREE YEARS after the killing of Khalistan separatist Hardeep Singh Nijjar triggered India's worst diplomatic row with Canada after Delhi rejected Ottawa's allegation of involvement, an audio clip has surfaced on social media in which fugitive gangster-turned-terrorist Goldy Brar has purportedly claimed responsibility for Nijjar's death.



Gangster-turned-terrorist Goldy Brar; (right) Hardeep Singh Nijjar was shot dead in Surrey, British Columbia, on June 18, 2023

Brar, whose real name is Satinderjeet Singh and who is from Faridkot in Punjab, is purportedly heard in the audio clip — its authenticity could not be independently verified — speaking to Khalistan terrorist Parmjit Singh Panna.



Gangster-turned-terrorist Goldy Brar; (right) Hardeep Singh Nijjar was shot dead in Surrey, British Columbia, on June 18, 2023

Brar claims that Nijjar was killed by him and his associates because he had been using young people to sell drugs. "Those who groomed and incited 16-to-17-year-olds to sell drugs... those who blackmailed

for his alleged links to the Lawrence Bishnoi organised crime group, which was targeted under Operation Hard Ball.

A Canadian citizen, Nijjar was shot dead outside a gurdwara in Surrey, British Columbia, on June 18, 2023. His killing triggered a diplomatic row after the then Canadian Prime Minister, Justin Trudeau, alleged that Canadian authorities had credible evidence linking Indian government officials to the killing.

Delhi rejected the allegation, calling it "absurd" and "motivated" and maintained it had no involvement in the case. **•CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**

Doval heads to Beijing, boundary talks with Wang Yi tomorrow

NSA visit comes ahead of BRICS summit in Delhi next month

Shubhrajit Roy
New Delhi, August 23

AHEAD OF a possible visit by Chinese President Xi Jinping to India for the summit of the BRICS leaders next month, National Security Advisor Ajit Doval is travelling to Beijing Monday for Special Representative-level talks on the boundary issue with his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi.

The 25th round of SR-level talks will be held Tuesday. Both Doval and Wang are the designated SRs for the boundary talks mechanism which was established in 2003 to comprehensively address the long-standing boundary dispute between the two countries.

In the last week of June, Wang visited India for a meeting of the BRICS NSAs and met



NSA Ajit Doval is India's Special Representative for boundary talks with China

Doval on the sidelines. Wang, who is also China's Foreign Minister, underlines it is "imperative" for India and China to respect each other's "core interests" and take concrete actions to implement the "important consensus" reached by both sides.

The two countries have been moving to repair ties that plummeted after the military standoff along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in eastern Ladakh. Since late 2024, both sides have taken steps to ease tensions.

After he met Wang in New Delhi last week, Doval said the India-China border had been **•CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**



Devdutt's back-to-back tons

Devdutt Padikkal celebrates his century on the first day of the second Test match between India and Sri Lanka, in Colombo, Sunday. In the first Test at Galle, Padikkal had slammed 167 in the first innings, followed by 44 in the second innings. **PAGE 11**

CONTINUING HIS SUBLIME
form, Padikkal brought up his ton in 168 deliveries in an innings which had 10 fours

DROPPED TWICE BY the Lankan fielders, he made them pay with an extraordinary 117, steadying India's innings

INDIA WERE 300 for five at stumps on the opening day of the second Test at the Sinhalese Sports Club Ground **PAGE 17**

NATIONAL HORTICULTURE BOARD

After Minister, Secy's kin availed of agri subsidy scheme, new rules bar them

Ministers, MPs, MLAs, officers no longer eligible; definition of family changed

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, August 23

ALMOST TWO months after an investigation by *The Indian Express* revealed a Union Minister and a serving Central government secretary's kin availing subsidy for their cucumber farms, the Centre has amended the 'Scheme Guidelines of Commercial Horticulture and Cold Storage Schemes' of the National Horticulture Board (NHB). It has revised the definition of 'family' — bringing within its ambit the subsidy applicant's spouse, father, mother, sons and daughters — and has made holders of constitutional posts, serving ministers, MPs, MLAs, mayors, district panchayat chiefs and government employees ineligible for financial assistance under NHB schemes.

The NHB, an autonomous body under the Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare, amended the scheme guidelines on August 21.

"With a view to rationalise **•CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**



The Express report on cucumber farm subsidies dated June 27

• The new guidelines

Family is now defined as applicant's spouse, father, mother, sons and daughters

Five categories not eligible:

1. Present holders of Constitutional posts;
2. Ministers, MoS, MPs, MLAs, MLCs, Mayors, chairpersons of district panchayats;
3. Serving employees of Central/State govt, ministries/departments, PSUs, autonomous bodies and local bodies, except MTS/Class-IV/Group-D staff;
4. Retired pensioners receiving monthly pension of Rs 10,000 or more, excluding MTS/Class-IV/Group-D employees;
5. Group of farmers

Subsidy reduced from 50% to 35% in general areas.

Maximum subsidy for cold storage **capped at Rs 2 crore**



IDEA EXCHANGE
Rise in inequality since labour is in surplus, capital in shortage. Need to democratise access to capital!
NEELKANTH MISHRA
EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR, WORLD BANK GROUP
PAGE 14

Ex-bureaucrat, former diplomat, BCG India chairman on RBI board

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, August 23

THE GOVERNMENT has appointed former Finance Ministry official Annie George Mathew, economist and management consultant Janmejay Kumar Sinha and former diplomat Syed Akbaruddin as part-time, non-official directors on Reserve Bank of India (RBI)'s Central Board.

According to an order issued Saturday by the Department of Personnel and Training, the appointments, approved by the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet, "will take effect from the date of notification and will continue for four years or until further

orders, whichever is earlier."

The appointments will add diverse expertise — from public finance to economics, corporate strategy and international diplomacy — to the RBI Board, which plays an important role in overseeing the central bank's functioning and advising on matters relating to monetary, financial, and economic policy.

Mathew, 62, is a former Special Secretary in the Department of Expenditure, Ministry of Finance, and is currently a full-time member of the Sixteenth Finance Commission. An officer of the Indian Audit and Accounts Service, she has more than three decades of experience in public finance. **•CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**

Licence to passport, VFS Global will soon introduce citizen services: CEO

George Mathew
Mumbai, August 23

STARTED IN Mumbai's Tirupati Apartments 25 years ago, VFS Global is now a world leader in visa outsourcing services. The \$1.2-billion company handles nearly 30 million visa applications a year across 168 countries. It navigates a world where mobility, security and technology are increasingly intertwined.

In an interview with *The Indian Express*, VFS Global founder and CEO Zubin Karkaria, who is also a Parsi priest,



ZUBIN KARKARIA
CEO OF VFS GLOBAL

spoke about the company's push into citizen services, AI

and also about its listing plans. Dubai-based Karkaria says technology can make the system more efficient and check frauds without replacing human decision-making. Excerpts:

In a new era of mass global travel, is the visa infrastructure equipped to handle the surge?
See, everybody is not travelling at the same time. Even if there is a huge demand, every country has its own consulate, its own visa offices and different seasons. They can manage. **•CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**

22 sailors of vessel that sank off Odisha still missing, search ops on

Two rescued crew Chinese nationals, says Coast Guard

Sujit Bisoiy
Bhubaneswar, August 23

THE INDIAN Coast Guard along with the Eastern Naval Command and other agencies have launched an intensive search and rescue operation to trace 22 crew members, who have been

missing since Saturday after a Panama-flagged cargo ship sank in the Bay of Bengal.

Meanwhile, the two crew members who were rescued were identified as Chinese nationals.

MV Ocean Winner sank around 230 nautical miles from the Paradip coast of Odisha late on Saturday. Coast Guard officials said at least three ships were conducting surface searches for 22 missing seafarers. The Eastern **•CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**

NATION PAGE 7



WEST BENGAL GETS RS 3,500-CRORE BOOST WITH FIVE DEFENCE PROJECTS

CBI BOOKS EX-DGCA OFFICIAL, FOUR AVIATION FIRMS IN CORRUPTION CASE

● PROTOTYPE HAS BEEN IN OPERATION FOR AROUND 4 MONTHS NOW

Railways rolls out waterless urinals for pilots of India's most powerful locomotives

Dheeraj Mishra
Patna, August 23

THE LACK of a urinal or toilet in locomotives is one of the biggest operational challenges for the country's loco pilots. This challenge has become even more pronounced given that the Railways is inducting women as loco pilots.

Now, India's most powerful 12000-horsepower locomotives promise to change that: These will come fitted with waterless urinals for train drivers. Discussions with the Railways are at an advanced stage for incorporating these urinals, a senior official of the Mad-

hepura Electric Locomotive Private Limited (MELPL) said. The MELPL is a joint venture between Indian Railways and French major Alstom, with Alstom holding a 74% majority stake. It manufactures 12,000 HP electric locomotives in Bihar's Madhepura to carry heavy load on the dedicated freight corridors.

Vivek Garg, Managing Director, MELPL, told *The Indian Express* that the company has rolled out a prototype after retrofitting a waterless urinal and it has been in operation for around 4 months. The unavailability of a urinal or toilet in locomotives is one of the big-

gest problems that a loco pilot faces. "This becomes even more important that now Indian Railways also have lady loco pilots. The original specifications of this locomotive called for a space to be kept but there was no requirement to integrate a waterless urinal. The discussion with Indian Railways is at an advanced stage and they want to integrate waterless urinals in all the locomotives that we are building. The prototype is performing well," Garg said.

The new locomotive from the Madhepura factory, he said, will have an inbuilt urinal and it will be retrofitted for the ones which have been rolled out. The company supplied its



The new locomotive from the Madhepura Electric Locomotive factory in Bihar will have an inbuilt urinal, which will be retrofitted for the ones that have been rolled out. **DHEERAJ MISHRA**

650th locomotive to the Railways on August 15. The first 12000 HP locomotive manufactured at the Madhepura facility was put into operation from Pandit Deen Dayal Upadhyay junction on May 18, 2020. It has a design speed of 120 kmph and can carry 6,000 tonnes of freight.

In 2015, the MELPL was awarded the contract to manufacture and supply 800 locomotives by March 2026. The initial cost of the project was Rs 28,000 crore, which was revised to over Rs 33,000 crore. With this project, India became the sixth country in the world to manufacture 12000 HP electric locomotives.

Asked why it had not been

done so far and whether it was due to a technical issue or lack of decision making, Garg said, "I would not say that there is a technical issue or a lack of decision making over here. Integrating a waterless urinal into a locomotive also has its own challenges. For example, it is a safety aspect. When a train or locomotive is moving, you would not like the driver to leave the desk and utilize a waterless urinal, unlike a plane. When it is stationary at some location, only then a driver should be using the urinal."

He said waterless urinals also require a rethink of water supply and design and this is an area which is evolving over a period of time.

"The specifications of this locomotive were framed around 2014-15, when such systems were not widely available or integrated into locomotive products. I think the Indian industry has matured, and waterless urinals are available now. We have been flexible and open to upgrading locomotives as technology evolves, and that is what we are doing today," he said.

The initiative is also part of India Railways' push to provide waterless urinals in all electric locomotives in a phased manner as per feasibility. According to the Railways, as of February 2026, more than 2800 locomotives have been provided with urinals.



'Watching every move': Fresh threat letter with details of Kashmiri Pandits surfaces in J&K

Arun Sharma
Jammu, August 23

A FRESH letter threatening Kashmiri Pandit migrants surfaced on Sunday, almost two weeks after a similar letter was posted online to warn those from the community working in the Kashmir Valley to "change their ways".

This is the first time in decades that the letters have been sent, down to the house number and street name.

Naming half a dozen Kashmiri Pandits, the letter gives out their residential locations in different parts of Jammu and describes them as "white collar terrorists" and "traitors" working for their "masters" in Delhi.

Officials said security agencies are looking into the authenticity of the two letters and trying to identify those behind them.

The letter seeks to draw a distinction between Kashmiri Pandits who did not migrate from the Valley, saying they are safe and no one is opposed to them, and those who did migrate. The latter are the subject of the threat, as are those "trying to implement RSS agenda" in Kashmir. "As already warned, wherever you are and wherever you go, we are watching your every move," the letter signed by one Ahmed Bilal states.

Purportedly issued by a group called the United Liberation Council, which security agencies say could be another front of the Lashkar-e-Toiba, these letters are being sent as an attempt to intimidate Kashmiri Pandits who, on being appointed by the government to various departments under the PM job package, have returned to the Valley for work.

Earlier this month, after the first threat letter emerged, the J&K government had instructed departments under it to send Kashmiri Pandit employees on leave. The government had also asked them to remain alert and move to safer places.

The previous letter had the names and phone numbers of some employees from the Revenue department. Police sources had said the letter attempted to link their work to the government seizing properties of terrorists. That letter came nearly a week after two migrant workers were killed by militants at a brick kiln in South Kashmir's Kulgam on July 31.

The ULC first made headlines in July when it released a poster on Hizbul Mujahideen commander Burhan Wani's death anniversary, officials said.

The latest threats come at a time when government initiatives for the return and rehabilitation of Kashmiri Pandits have gained momentum.

Vehicle overturns in Oman, 1 Indian killed, nine injured

Press Trust of India
Dubai, August 23

ONE INDIAN national was killed and nine others were injured after a vehicle veered off the road in Oman, police said.

The incident occurred on Saturday on Sultan Said bin Taymer Street after the vehicle veered off the road. The police Air Wing carried out an operation to transport two of the injured from Al Hema Governorate to Niwiza Hospital, the Royal

Oman Police said in a post on X.

"The incident resulted in one fatality and injuries to nine people of Indian nationality, who were subsequently transferred to Niwiza Hospital by ambulance vehicles to receive medical care," it said. The police did not provide further details about the cause of the accident.

Khaleef Times had earlier reported that authorities had warned of low visibility on the highway due to thunderstorms, heavy rain and blowing dust.

Phone theft claim sparks clash at Andhra nursing hostel; NE students shifted

Sreenivas Janyala
Hyderabad, August 23

A MINOR dispute over a missing mobile phone at a nursing college's hostel in Kakinada, Andhra Pradesh, escalated into a clash between local Telugu students and students from Nagaland and Manipur Saturday.

The situation at the girls' hostel of SK College of Nursing was brought under control after Collector M N Harendra Prasad and Superintendent of Police Bindu Madhav intervened Sunday morning, met with the students, and recovered the missing phone.

As a precautionary measure, the administration temporarily shifted students from Northeastern states to a nearby secure facility, while local students were moved to a separate location. "A minor dispute between two students has been fully resolved, and the situation is completely under control," Collector Prasad said.

He added that the misunderstanding stemmed from an allegation of theft, but the mobile phone has since been returned to its owner.

Local circle inspector, sub-inspectors from the women's police station, and district medical and health officer visited the site, spoke with students from both groups, and resolved the issue amicably.

Denying social media claims, Collector Prasad clarified that rumours regarding the theft of certificates, suspension of fee payments, or expulsion of students are baseless. The college management has been instructed to improve hostel facilities and foster a friendly campus environment.

Addressing safety concerns, SP Madhav urged the public not to share or believe exaggerated social media reports. The administration assured parents that all out-of-state students are completely safe and that their security remains a top priority.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

3 years after Nijjar killing, fugitive terrorist Goldy Brar claims he did it

killing. Last month, the Royal Canadian Mounted Police said authorities had found no evidence linking Indian government officials to Nijjar's killing.

The two countries are now trying to repair relations and move forward.

According to a US federal indictment unsealed in Los Angeles last month, jailed gangster Lawrence Bishnoi allegedly ordered the killing of Nijjar, referred to as HSN in court documents. The US has also charged Bishnoi and Brar in connection with the case.

Brar, who earlier lived in Canada after going there on a student visa in 2017, is wanted in India in several cases, including

the killing of Punjabi singer Sidhu Moosewala who was shot dead in Punjab's Mansa district on May 29, 2022. Brar had claimed responsibility for the killing.

The US Justice Department indictment had earlier linked the killing of Nijjar with an alleged plot to kill Khalistani separatist Gurbatwar Singh Pannun, citing intercepted communications and common targets. In February this year, Indian national Nikhil Gupta pleaded guilty in a US federal court to murder-for-hire and conspiracy charges in the Pannun case.

Indian agencies have said that Brar is associated with Babbar Khalsa International, a

listed terrorist organisation. A dossier prepared by Central agencies says Brar, backed by a cross-border agency, was involved in multiple killings, made threatening calls to nationalist leaders, demanded ransom, and used social media platforms to claim responsibility for killings.

The Interpol has issued a Red Corner Notice against Brar. In India, a non-bailable warrant was issued against him on December 12, 2022, and a Look Out Circular on June 15, 2022. The Centre later designated him a terrorist under the Fourth Schedule of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act.

Doval heads to Beijing, boundary talks with Wang Yi tomorrow

"quiet" and there had been an "upward trend" in bilateral ties.

Earlier this month, responding to a question on reports of some tension along the LAC, the Ministry of External Affairs said the state of the border with China will reflect on the state of the "larger bilateral ties" and that maintenance of peace and tranquillity along the LAC is of "utmost importance".

Randhir Jaishwal, spokesperson for the MEA, also rejected China's criticism of New Delhi identifying 27 places and features in Arunachal Pradesh by their standard names, maintaining that the state is an "inalienable and integral" part of India and nothing can change this "indisputable reality".

This was reiterated at a meeting of the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on India-China Border Affairs (WMCC). At this meeting, the two sides engaged

in frank discussions and reviewed the situation along the LAC," Jaishwal said.

On Saturday, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, speaking on the situation with China, said: "I think we went through a particularly bad patch between the summer of 2020 and the autumn of 2024, and that was primarily an outcome of the situation in the border areas."

"At the end of the day, peace and tranquillity in the border areas is a prerequisite for good relations, and the state of the border, to a very large measure, naturally would determine the state of the relations. Having said that, I think naturally, if assuming things are stable and the need is more cooperative, obviously, I mean we are both very big economies. In many ways, we are markets to each other. We are part of the supply chain. They industrialised much faster and much bigger and much earlier, largely be-

cause of many of the policies we advocate," he said.

"The world is competitive. We must build up our strengths. We have to do business with the entire world. That includes China too, but it is important we deal with them confidently. We stand our ground, as we have stood on the border. We develop our strengths, which unfortunately from the 1960s for half a century, we did not do. We have to make up for the shortcomings and the mistakes of the past, and that is really what we are hoping to do. So I think a stronger, more self-reliant India, a more industrialised India, a more manufacturing India will be able to actually compete with China as it will, with other major countries of the world," he said.

Jaishankar said the government had "taken up" with China the problem of business visas being faced by Indian applicants.

Ex-bureaucrat, former diplomat, BCG India chairman on RBI Board

financial management, government audit and accounts. She has also served on the boards of public sector financial institutions. Sinha, 66, a prominent economist and management consultant, is Chairman, MD and Senior Partner of Boston Consulting Group (BCG) India. He was earlier Chairman of BCG Asia-Pacific and has been associated with several government and

regulatory committees, including those relating to financial sector reforms.

Akbaruddin, 66, is a former Permanent Representative of India to the United Nations and a former spokesperson of the Ministry of External Affairs. He is currently associated with the Kauliyal School of Public Policy in Hyderabad.

The latest appointments take the RBI Board's strength to

14. As of August 22, there were 11 members on the RBI Board including Governor Sanjay Malhotra and four Deputy Governors. Last week, the government appointed former ISRO Chairman Somnath S and Mahindra Group chairman Anand Mahindra to the Board.

The other members include Ravathy Iyer, Sachin Chaturvedi, Anuradha Thakur, Sanjay Lohiya.

Agri subsidy scheme

financial assistance, ensure equitable distribution of benefits, prevent duplication of subsidy, and make the implementation of the Schemes more transparent and effective, following amendments in the Scheme Guidelines shall be applicable with immediate effect," read a circular issued by the NHB.

The scheme—Development of Commercial Horticulture through Production and Post-Harvest Management of Horticulture Crops—is aimed at promoting commercial farming (for profit) of horticultural crops on a large scale. The crops under the scheme are three types of vegetables—capsicum, cucumber and tomato; and eight varieties of flowers including rose, lillium and chrysanthemum. The scheme offered a maximum subsidy of 50 per cent, capped at Rs 1 crore per family, of the project cost.

Under the new guidelines, the government has made clear that five categories of people shall not be eligible for financial assistance under NHB Schemes. These comprise of:

- Present holders of constitution posts.
- Present ministers and ministers of state; members of Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha, members of State Legislative Assemblies/Councils, mayors of municipal corporations and chairpersons of district panchayats.
- Serving employees of Central/State Government ministries/departments, PSUs, autonomous bodies and local bodies (except MTS/Class-IV/Group D employees). Superannuated/retired pensioners receiving a monthly pension of Rs 10,000 or

more, excluding MTS/Class-IV/Group D employees.

● Group of Farmers. "Family members of persons falling in the above categories may, however, avail one-time assistance, subject to the applicable provisions of the revised definition of family," the new guidelines said.

The revised definition of 'family' is as follows: "For the purpose of determining eligibility under NHB Schemes, the term 'family' shall comprise the applicant's spouse, father, mother, sons and daughters."

As per the old guidelines, the term 'family' was defined as "the husband, wife, and dependent minor children."

On June 27, *The Indian Express* reported that Bhagirath Choudhary, Minister of State in the Union Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare, availed Rs 99 lakh subsidy for his farm in 2025 under the NHB's scheme 'Development of Commercial Horticulture through Production and Post-Harvest Management of Horticulture Crops'. A month later, Choudhary returned the subsidy amount to the government. The investment by *The Indian Express* also showed that the wife, son and mother of senior IAS officer Naresh Pal Gangwar, who is currently serving as the Secretary, Department of Animal Husbandry and Dairying (DAHD), were among the beneficiaries of the scheme. The government had appointed Gangwar as the Higher Education Secretary on July 23, but even before his joining, his appointment was cancelled (on August 10).

As per the new norms, "Only one member of a family shall be eligible to avail financial assis-

tance under NHB Schemes, whether individually or through HUF, partnership/proprietorship firm or as a director of a company, subject to the applicable provisions."

"Financial assistance availed by any member of a family shall be treated as financial assistance availed by the same family. Once financial assistance has been availed by any member of an applicant's family under any NHB Scheme/component, no further financial assistance shall be admissible to any other member of the same family under any NHB Scheme/component, irrespective of any unutilised portion of the maximum admissible ceiling," the new guidelines said.

"The restriction shall apply across all NHB Schemes/components and shall constitute the final entitlement of the family," the new guidelines added. "Suppression, misrepresentation or furnishing of incorrect information for obtaining financial assistance shall render the applicant liable for recovery of the assistance released along with applicable interest."

The Centre has also reduced the subsidy component from 50 per cent to 35 per cent for beneficiaries in general category states and 45 per cent in North Eastern or Himalayan states.

The new guidelines have also made a provision for voluntary refund/exit from the NHB Scheme.

"A beneficiary may, during the prescribed lock-in period, voluntarily opt out of the Scheme by refunding the entire subsidy amount along with applicable interest, if any, as prescribed under the Scheme or decided by the Competent Authority. Upon acceptance of the refund by NHB and fulfillment of the prescribed conditions, the beneficiary shall be discharged from the obligations and restrictions arising from the subsidy assistance," the guidelines said.

22 sailors

Naval Command has also deployed an aircraft — P8I — on surveillance sortie to help the Coast Guard.

Officials said rough sea conditions in Bay of Bengal were hampering the search operation.

Coast Guard spokesperson Commandant Amit Uniyal told *The Indian Express* the two Chinese crew members, rescued with the help of life rafts, have been brought to the Coast Guard ship and are under medical care. They are being brought to the mainland, he said.

"Initially, they were in shock when they were rescued but now their health condition is stable and they are under medical care." Their rank is being verified, he added. "All efforts are being made to trace others," Uniyal said.

Union Minister for Ports,

Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal said all agencies are coordinating closely and actively involved in search and rescue efforts.

"Deeply concerned by the unfortunate incident involving MV OCEAN WINNER off the coast of Odisha, The Panama-flagged vessel was carrying iron ore from Paradip Port to China. All agencies are coordinating closely and actively doing search and rescue efforts," Sonowal wrote on X. "27 survivors have been successfully rescued and are being given medical care... My prayers for the safety of the remaining crew," he said.

A Defence Ministry spokesperson said, "Sustained monitoring and focused aerial search by Indian Navy P8I led to the successful detection of two floating life rafts and oil slick near the reported position. Currently, two survivors have been safely rescued. Search efforts continue."

The cargo ship, carrying more than 72,000 tonnes of iron

ore from Odisha to China with a stop at Singapore, left Paradip Port on Friday early morning. It had 24 crew members aboard, two of whom were rescued by a commercial vessel in the vicinity on Saturday.

The reasons behind the mishap are yet to be ascertained. According to officials, 20 of the 24 crew members are Chinese nationals, three are from Myanmar and one is from Bangladesh.

The Maritime Rescue Coordination Centre (MRCC) at Sri Vijaya Puram (formerly Port Blair) initiated a swift search and rescue operation following a distress alert and loss of contact with MV OCEAN WINNER.

The Merchant vessel was built in 1998 and had a deadweight capacity of about 73,000 tonnes, according to available details.

Paradip is a major port that handles large volumes of cargo, including iron ore. The vessel, from Odisha, headed to far-off destinations.

'Licence to passport, VFS Global will soon introduce citizen services'

If there is like a ten-fold increase in one year suddenly then it becomes difficult. But year-on-year, if there is a 15-20% growth, I think it can be managed.

There were allegations in the Lighthouse Reports investigation about appointment slot irregularities and pressure to buy premium services. What steps have you taken to improve services and bring down complaints?

There was no EU investigation as was claimed. We have been working with so many governments for the last 20-25 years. The governments themselves do thousands of audits on the system around the world. We work in 168 countries. The level of SOPs, technology, security and GDPR (General Data Protection Regulation, the European Union's privacy and security law) that we have to put in is huge. We would not be the number one in the world in this business today if we had something that you are talking about. Now, when you handle 32 million visas, and another 30 million, say, citizen services, if you have four or five people complaining because something went wrong, that doesn't make any sense. The market can't handle that.

We have a very strict zero-tolerance policy. If we find out that something is wrong somewhere, or a guard outside is telling somebody that I can get you a visa or something, he is sacked on the spot. We have strong compliance and governance in our organisation. We have 20,000 people in 168 countries.

We don't compromise on security, we don't compromise on

customer centricity, we don't compromise on anything that is a regulation. We have 10,000 audits every year. Why? Because, for me, it is important that the governments that I work with trust me. They check, they do mystery audits, they do ISO audits, they do GDPR audits.

VFS handles extremely sensitive personal and biometric data for millions of people. Have you been able to tackle issues about data security and application processing. What concrete safeguards can applicants expect?

We don't keep any data. If somebody is saying data security, all my machines in the front line are called dumb terminals. Nobody can download it. Nobody can save or print. When I take your fingerprints, you put your fingers, you put your passport, and you put your face. And, there's a camera over there, where there's somebody from the embassy actually watching. They record everything. As soon as a person gives that, and everything is green, that means I have taken everything properly. Then with a press of a button, it's gone out of my system. No, I am not keeping biometrics.

We have so many security systems even on a van that carries passports. If they don't go by the same route, we will know on our system that this van is going in a different route. We will call the driver immediately. This we can do in five to ten minutes, somewhere, a flash will happen on the screen. This van, taking passports to a

visa centre or to a consulate, is stopped.

I don't have the data. I don't store any personal details. I only keep your name, telephone number and address till the time I return your passport. After that, automatically it's erased from the system.

How many centres do you have in India? Are you planning to open more centres?

In India, we have more than 200 centres. We opened one in Lucknow last year. We are planning to open one in Odisha. In Bhubaneswar, we opened. So, people from tier 2 cities are travelling more and more. (But) I cannot do anything without the permission of the embassy. Their officers come and check our premises. They approve the staff. Every staff in my office working for any country is approved by that country.

Do you think Artificial Intelligence will change the way the traditional visa centre model works?

It's not something new for us. We have been working on AI products for the last three years. We have already deployed AI products for eight governments across 1,200 routes. Before we started on AI, what we did was we tried with Responsible AI. This is an institute in America, which audits the way you do your AI. So that's the first certification. Second, we build guardrails. That means we can only do what the government created our own LLM, large language model.

AI helps to understand

forgery. AI helps to stop people using the wrong stamps to take appointment slots. Because agents or people who were taking appointments were putting their photographs with a different name and manipulating the system to block slots. We have a facial recognition system. If the person is not standing there and the passport face is not matching, you won't be able to block slots. AI helps us with these types of things, in detecting frauds.

When you are submitting your application, you get a lot of papers that are asked for in your visa. Now you can give 10 pages of a bank statement. AI will tell the visa officer whether the bank statement is genuine or there is an anomaly in the figures.

Will your workforce come down because of AI deployment?

As soon as we are continuously expanding. My business will grow. The workforce may remain the same. I would rather look at it that way.

If you want to change one thing about the global visa system, what would it be?

Anybody who is doing business with the governments to make it more efficient and increase the reach. But at the same time, keeping the security parameters, I would always push for biometrics to be taken before the person travels. The simple reason being when you take biometrics before the person travels, it ensures the person travelling is genuine.

If you want secured mobility,

if you want your borders to be secure, biometrics are very critical to be taken before the person flies to the country.

What are the VFS growth plans in the next 2-3 years? And do you have any specific plans for India? Making it bigger or a listing on the stock exchange?

We started with a Mumbai Visa Centre at Beach Road, at Trupti Apartments 25 years ago. We created VFS in 2001 with three visa centres, with 100,000 applicants. My first customer was the US State Department. Now we are at almost 30 million visa applicants a year. We have 71 governments we work with. We are physically present in 168 countries of the world with 4,400 visa centres across.

We invest over \$100 million a year in technology. We are focusing on mobility... making sure trade improves because when we increase mobility and people travel, automatically the trade improves because it's not only people going for tourism, people are going for business.

The visa and passports that we do, which is huge, will continue to grow. Sixty per cent of the visa business is still not outsourced. It's still done by the governments themselves. So, there is a huge upside over there, which is still there. We will soon introduce citizen services in India. Driver's licence, passports, national IDs, anything that you would go to again.

What about your plan to list on the stock exchange?

We were planning to list in 2019. Then Covid came. So, our listing plans didn't work out. We

were even looking at listing very early this year, but again, because of the crisis in the Gulf region, we are just holding on. We are very agnostic in terms of whether we list or we will look at a strategic partnership with somebody. But I think we always keep these things open.

You have been a Parsi priest. How does this influence decision-making in a corporate setting?

Being born into a middle-class Parsi priestly family in Dadar, Mumbai, had a profound influence on my outlook on life. At the heart of Zoroastrian philosophy is a simple but powerful principle: good thoughts, good words and good deeds.

My years as a priest taught me that success should never be measured purely by outcomes. Equally important is how those outcomes are achieved, and that means putting people first and treating them with full respect, dignity and respect. When situations become challenging, my instinct is to stay grounded, reflect and stay steady.

I believe in having what I call 'good paranoia' — not being overly paranoid but maintaining a healthy awareness of what could change around us. While I no longer actively perform priestly duties, spirituality remains an important part of my daily life.

My priestly background gave me an ethical compass, a sense of service, and the belief that long-term success comes from doing the right thing, treating people as equals, and valuing their contributions. That philosophy also shapes how I think about leadership and organisational growth.

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ICMR says no new strain as Capital reports over 2,000 swine flu cases

Tabshir Shams & Anonima Dutt
New Delhi, August 23

EVEN AS Delhi's swine flu caseload so far this year crossed the 2,000 mark on Sunday, the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) says the outbreak is being driven by a known strain already in circulation and that the numbers across the country are beginning to drop. There is no need to panic, the country's apex health research body underlined.

"No new strain of H1N1 has been identified and there is no cause for panic. The Influenza strains currently circulating are also well-matched with the vaccine strains recommended for the Northern Hemisphere," the ICMR said in a statement.

The strain predominantly in circulation across the country, according to the ICMR, at the moment is A/Missouri/11/2025 (H1N1) pdm09-like virus strain, part of clade 6B.1A.5a2a, subclade D.3.1.1—a lineage that has been in circulation since 2025.

A scientist from the ICMR told *The Indian Express*, "Data shows that around 70% of all respiratory infections in the last

week in the Capital were caused by H1N1 virus. It shows that H1N1 has been in circulation and causing a high number of infections over the last four to five weeks with the numbers slowly coming down in the last two weeks. The data for the current week is not yet available."

Seasonal influenza, including H1N1, is "mostly self-limiting", scientists said. "Common symptoms include fever, cough, headache and body ache, and most people recover with appropriate care and rest," said the ICMR scientist while also cautioning that "young children, elderly persons and individuals with underlying medical conditions" may be at greater risk of complications.

"The situation continues to be closely monitored through regular surveillance, and necessary public health measures are being undertaken," the scientist said.

Union Health Minister JP Nadda on Friday reviewed the situation in the Capital and the preparedness of healthcare facilities at a key meeting. Nadda emphasised the need for public awareness of preventive measures such as respiratory hygiene and hand hygiene.

The meeting was also attended by Delhi Health Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh, who reviewed surveillance data and trends in influenza-like illnesses and severe acute respiratory syndrome—cases where patients with flu-like symptoms require hospitalisation.

"We are prepared for any situation. There is no shortage of medicine, doctors, beds," Singh told reporters on Saturday, "Everyone will receive timely and appropriate treatment."

• AT GLANCE

STRAIN PREDOMINANTLY in circulation across the country is A/Missouri/11/2025 (H1N1) pdm09-like virus strain.

THE LINEAGE has been in circulation since 2025.

ICMR SAYS the cases are beginning to drop.

INFECTIONS ARE likely to be well-matched with a new strain starts circulating.

tended by Delhi Health Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh, who reviewed surveillance data and trends in influenza-like illnesses and severe acute respiratory syndrome—cases where patients with flu-like symptoms require hospitalisation.

"We are prepared for any situation. There is no shortage of medicine, doctors, beds," Singh told reporters on Saturday, "Everyone will receive timely and appropriate treatment."

What experts say

In response to the ICMR findings, Dr S Chatterjee, Internal Medicine Specialist, Apollo

Hospital, told *The Indian Express*, "That's good news for us. It's good to know that the mutation has not happened."

He added, "Pollution and environmental factors, among others, could have caused the rise. The air quality around Delhi has worsened over the years, the monsoon has been sporadic, weather has been extreme, dust pollution is also a big issue. Moreover, the defence mechanism of our body has also been weakened. In India, there are multiple factors that weaken our immune systems."

He added that although the government has taken preparedness measures, containing the spread was as much an individual responsibility. "It should then be the individual's responsibility also to control the spread and spread of the disease," he said. "Wear masks when you go out, wash your hands, avoid crowded spaces if you're symptomatic, and stay hydrated to help your body fight the infection."

On the other hand, Dr Rommel Tickoo said, "The clarification from ICMR is reassuring. An increase in H1N1 cases does not, by itself, mean that a new or more dangerous strain has emerged. H1N1 is now part of

the seasonal influenza spectrum, and most healthy individuals recover with appropriate rest and supportive care. The focus should be on vigilance rather than panic, especially given the medical attention for high-risk groups such as the elderly, young children, pregnant women and those with chronic illnesses or weakened immunity."

WHO's recommendations

Each year, the World Health Organisation comes up with recommendations for the influenza strains that should be included in the annual flu vaccines for the Northern and the Southern hemisphere. The recommendation usually includes two Influenza A strains—one of which is the A/Missouri/11/2025 this year pdm09-like virus this year—and one influenza B strain. These strains are determined using the data on circulation of the flu strains that are reported by its global network of laboratories.

Why does the strain matter? Infections are likely to be more severe when a new strain starts circulating and may affect even the vaccinated if it is not a part of the annual flu shot.

ANGRY RELATIVES ALLEGE NEGLIGENCE

In desperate bid to find missing son, man enters drain in Jasola

The 15-year-old boy fell into the drain while trying to catch a kite on Saturday

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 23

TWENTY-FOUR HOURS on, despite a search operation involving the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), Delhi Fire Services, Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) and several other agencies, there was no trace of 15-year-old Mithun who fell into a drain in Southeast Delhi's Jasola area on Saturday while trying to catch a kite. His helplessness father, Awadhesh, then entered the drain on Sunday in a desperate bid to find him.

Rescue personnel and officers were present at the spot as the distraught father stepped into the dirty, fast-flowing water, hoping to find Mithun.

The incident also triggered anger among the family and



Awadhesh searching for his son Mithun on Sunday.

local residents, who gathered on the road on Sunday and blocked traffic, demanding that the authorities intensify the search. They accused the administration of negligence and alleged that the agencies were relying on wooden poles to search the drain instead of conducting a more thorough operation.

Officials involved in the search said the strong current and dense vegetation around the drain were making the operation difficult. The NDRF team had reached the spot soon after receiving information on

Saturday and continued the search until around 9 pm. The operation resumed on Sunday morning and continued till late evening.

According to police, a PCR call was received at 12 pm on Saturday reporting that a boy, around 15, had fallen into a drain and was missing.

Police teams reached the spot and identified the boy as Mithun, who lived with his family in Jasola.

Police said preliminary investigation suggested that Mithun had fallen into the drain while trying to catch a kite.

Teams from the NDRF, Fire Services and DDMA, along with officials from UP Irrigation, Delhi Jal Board, Delhi Development Authority and the SDM's office, were involved in the search.

For Awadhesh, however, the wait has been unbearable. With every passing hour bringing no news of his son, he entered the drain himself—searching through the dirty waters in the hope of bringing Mithun home.

The search operation was on till last reports came in.

HUSBAND, IN-LAWS WOULD BEAT AND BELITTLE HER; MURDER STAGED AS SUICIDE, ALLEGES FAMILY

Pregnant defence ministry officer found dead, husband booked

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 23

THE JOURNEY to become an assistant section officer (ASO) with the Ministry of Defence was not easy for 30-year-old Nazia Khanam, a resident of Cham-

paran in Bihar, where her father works as a truck driver. Her father had shattered many glass ceilings to achieve her career goals.

On August 21, she was found hanging at a house in Sector 23 of West Delhi's Dwarka that she had rented with husband, Azam Ali Khan, after they got married in April. She was pregnant. Claiming that she was harassed and thrashed by her husband and her in-laws, her family has rejected the possibility that she may have died by suicide.

Nazia's body was reported to have been found by her husband at around 4 pm after a fight between them. In a statement to the police, Azam, an associate director at an e-commerce company in Gurgo-

nah, said that they had an argument after which she locked him in another room and hanged herself with a dupatta from a ceiling fan. He said he managed to unlock himself with the help of the house owner.

The couple got married on April 11 and moved to Bhetal Village in Dwarka's Sector 23 about a month ago. They had rented the house so that commuting to work was convenient for both of them.

DCP (Dwarka) Kushal Singh said that on August 21, Nazia's family members appeared before the Executive Magistrate and recorded their statements. However, they did not raise any suspicion or make allegations against members of Nazia's husband or his family. The following day, however, her parents appeared before the SDM again and submitted a false statement and allegations against her husband and other members of his family, Singh said.

Police say they have regis-



Deceased Nazia Khanam

tered a case under Sections 85 (cruelty by husband or relative) and 108 (abetment of suicide) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita at Dwarka Sector 23 police station and have started an investigation. Nazia's husband and his parents have been booked.

"She was the eldest among four siblings—two sisters and two brothers. They all looked up to her. She was the strength of her family. How can she die by suicide?" Nazia's cousin, Minhas Alam, a businessman currently staying in Madhya Pra-

desh, told *The Indian Express*. "Coming from a small village, she had overcome many obstacles in her professional journey. There is some foul play behind her death," Minhas said, adding that the family is taking Nazia's booking back to Bihar for the last rites after the post-mortem examination.

Her brother, Shadab Khan, an engineer posted in Kolkata, said, "My sister was very happy after she cleared the Staff Selection Commission Combined Graduate Level, a government exam, and was posted as an ASO in the Defence Ministry. Earlier, she was deployed as a tax assistant in the Income Tax department. She wanted to pursue the Bihar Public Service Commission exam next."

"She was murdered and the body was staged to look like a suicide by her husband," Shadab alleged. The family has made similar allegations in the statement to the SDM.

Shadab said he had reserva-

tions about Azam from the start when the families were arranging the marriage. The family had demanded dowry, but others convinced Azam to go ahead with the marriage. Shadab claimed.

"Today, we regret it. My sister complained about her husband and his family, they would belittle her for her job and compare her mother-in-law to her. They would say your husband will earn more," Shadab said, adding that they would often beat her when she tried to stand up to their comments.

He said Nazia also complained that her husband spent long hours on the phone and did not give her time despite her pregnancy.

Police said all necessary legal and procedural steps were initiated after the PCR call was received. Further investigation is underway, and an inquest will be taken on the basis of evidence and facts that emerge during the probe.

DELHI BJP SPOKESPERSON TELLS GOVT

'Ask private schools not to force parents to buy expensive uniforms'

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, August 23

CITING FINANCIAL burden on middle-class parents, Delhi BJP spokesperson Prashant Kapoor has requested the state government to direct private schools in the Capital to stop asking parents to buy multiple sets of uniforms, shoes and bags at "exorbitant prices" from the schools' in-house stores, from 2028 onwards.

Kapoor, who is also the Media Head of the party's Delhi unit, wrote a letter to Education Minister Ashish Sood and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday. Requesting the government to urge private schools to design similar and basic uniforms for students, he said the schools are putting an additional financial burden on middle-class families already grappling with high school fees.

When contacted, Sood's of-

fice refused to comment on the letter.

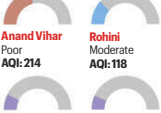
In the letter, he made two demands. He urged the government to stop school management from forcing parents to buy multiple and various sets of uniforms, shoes and bags effective from April 1, 2028—thereby giving schools time to clear their existing stock and parents time to purchase "simplified" uniforms. He has also requested a ban on the sale of school dresses, shoes, books, stationery and bags by school management to newly enrolled students—to be effective from the school session beginning April 1, 2027.

Claiming that he has received complaints from parents, the BJP leader stated that "in addition to normal summer & winterschool dresses, the school management forces the parents to buy special sports dresses apart from activities shoes along with at least 3 types of shoes".

• Skywatch

 **Forecast:** August 24, 2026
Generally cloudy sky. Very light to light or moderate rainfall.
MAX: 34-36
1.8°C above normal
MIN: 24-26
0.5°C below normal

• AQI Tracker


Anand Vihar
Poor
AQI: 214
Rohini
Moderate
AQI: 118
Pusa
Satisfactory
AQI: 75
Najafgarh
Satisfactory
AQI: 82
Good (0-50)
Satisfactory (51-100)
Moderate (101-200)
Poor (201-300)
Very Poor (301-400)
Severe (401-500)

Graffiti against Shah: Police arrest IYC man, court gives bail

Pragynesh
New Delhi, August 23

THE DELHI Police arrested an Indian Youth Congress worker for allegedly writing slogans against Union Home Minister Amit Shah on the walls of the office of the Deputy Commissioner of Police, New Delhi, sourced told *The Indian Express*.

The slogans were allegedly spray-painted in black near the entrance of the office, sources said. It was later covered with white paint.

The accused, identified as Karan (27) was arrested from Jharkhand on Friday. A senior officer said that Karan was booked under provisions of the Delhi Prevention of Defacement of Property Act. He was later granted bail and served a notice under the Act.

The alleged defacement took place on August 21 when Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi and Congress workers staged a sit-in at Parliament Street police station. Police said they are investigating if anyone else was involved in writing the slogans. Further investigation is underway.

Gandhi staged a seven-hour protest demanding the registration of an FIR over pellet injuries suffered by a 19-year-old during the Coochbehar Janta Party protests on August 20. Gandhi was accompanied by the injured teenager, Sahil Lochab, and his mother. Gandhi had refused to leave until an FIR was registered.

The Congress leader also alleged that the FIR was registered only after a "final permission" from Union Home Minister Anshu.

"You should understand who was stopping the FIR," he said.

• RELIES ON LOW-COST MODELS, FIELD VISITS TO TEACH STUDENTS

How a national awardee govt school teacher made a difference

Drishiti Jain
Ghaziabad, August 23

AT 63, Dr Renu Tripathi, who teaches science to students from classes 6 to 10 at a government school in Ghaziabad, has been defying stereotypes in more than one way. Quick to adopt new technologies, she runs two YouTube channels for students and has been constantly innovating with her teaching methods. Classroom, for her, is not limited to four walls and she often uses field visits and handmade model to break down complex concepts.

Author of 12 books and several research papers, Dr Tripathi's efforts during her two-decade-long teaching career were acknowledged this week as she got selected for the National Teachers Award 2026. She was informed about the selection on August 21—congratulatory messages from colleagues and students flooded her mobile phone. "My former students told me that they are proud of me... Once I used to tell them that," she shared with a smile.

A promise to her father

Dr Tripathi has been teaching science since 2006 at Government Balika Inter College in Ghaziabad's Vijay Nagar. She did not, however, start her career as a teacher. In 1987, she started working as a project officer at a government office—identifying school dropouts, counselling them and ensuring they go back to school. "I made sure no child was left behind," she recalled.

But her father, also a teacher and a school principal, wanted his daughter to take up teaching like him. "Three months into my first job, he died of a heart attack. I had made a



Dr Renu Tripathi with a student, EXPRESS

promise to him to become a teacher like him and take his principles forward," she recalled.

In 2003, she was finally able to keep the promise when she took up a job as a science teacher at a school in Bulandshahr. In 2006, she switched to the Ghaziabad school where she is presently teaching.

'Learning by doing'

For Tripathi, classes have never been confined by walls or timetables. Her contribution to education by using low-cost teaching models and innovative learning resources in accordance with National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 has been acknowledged in her latest recognition. She has earlier received accolades from the Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh governments previously.

"When NEP 2020 was implemented, I stepped up innovation as far as my teaching methods go, and I saw that my students improved a lot," she said.

Dr Tripathi added, "I no longer make my sit in the class, and rather spend time outside the four walls. On our recent trip to the Botanical Garden in Noida, I asked my

students to look out for different kinds of trees. They learn by doing."

She was able to realise the impact of this approach when one of her students, who she taught in class six, won a national award for a model on soil erosion in 2019. Tripathi recently learnt that she is now a Block Education Officer in the city.

"That made me realise that these activities hold power," she said, adding that many of her students—despite coming from economically challenged—have now become doctors, engineers, teachers and bank officers. "I have also made a choice to go beyond the traditional teacher-student relationship. When I studied in a government school, there were no smart-cases or phones. But they have allowed us to connect with students," she said, and added, "I can teach them remotely. We have WhatsApp groups for every class."

Tripathi, who uses multiple tools to spread information including online presentations on slideshare, wishes to continue teaching underprivileged students post retirement. For now, she is content that she can make a difference.

Delhi government plans to influence witnesses and disrupt trial proceedings. It can also help curb their criminal activities and reduce the size of the library and property of citizens

New Delhi: The Delhi government announced on Sunday that it plans to implement the Transfer of Prisoners (Punjab Amendment) Act, 2025, enabling the interstate transfer of underworld gangsters, organised criminals and other high-risk prisoners.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the move aims to enable the interstate transfer of prisoners in the interest of prison security, law and order and public interest, while strengthening cooperation among states in tackling organised crime. The Delhi government argues that shifting such hardened and notorious underlings to prisons outside the Capital can reduce their ability

छत्तीसगढ़ पर्यावरण संरक्षण मंडल

पर्यावरण अवरण, सेक्टर-19, नया रावपुर अटल पर, दिल्ली-रावपुर (छ.ग.)

// सर्व संबंधित को सूचना //

भारत सरकार, पर्यावरण एवं जलवायु परिवर्तन मंत्रालय, नई दिल्ली की अधिसूचना दिनांक 14.09.2006 (यथा संशोधित) के तहत सर्व संबंधित को सूचित किया जाता है कि मेसर्स की एच. एच. एच. प्रोडक्ट लिमिटेड, गान्धारी (होस्ट), जयपुर, तहसील-जयपुर, जिला-राजसूत (छ.ग.) में Establishment of Greenfield steel plant comprising of (1) Iron Pellet plant (Producer Gas) [2x15,000 M³/Hr- 30,000 M³/Hr], (3) Sponge Iron [DRI Kilns 4x650 TPD]; 8,58,000 TPA, (4) Induction Furnace with matching LRF, COM, AOD (Hot Billet/Billets/Ingots [8x30T]- 7,92,000 TPA, (5) Electric Arc Furnace (EAF) & BOF [2x50T]- 3,30,000 TPA, (6) Rolling Mills (TMT/ Wire/ Strip/ Plate/Structural Steel) (85% Hot charging with Hot Billets and remaining 15% through RHF with Producer gas as fuel) [3x800 TPD= 2400 TPD]; 7,92,000 TPA, (7) Coal Gasifier for Reheating Furnace (Producer gas) [2x20,000 M³/Hr- 40,000 M³/Hr], (8) Coal Washery [1x2.25 MTA]- 22,50,000 TPA, (9) Submerged Electric Arc Furnace (FeSi/FeMnSiMn/FeCr/Pig Iron) [4x24 MVA] (FeSi-85,000 TPA/ FeMn-2,40,000 TPA/ SiMn-1,60,000 TPA/ FeCr-1,80,000 TPA/ Pig Iron-2,80,000 TPA), (10) Sinter Plant [2x15 M³/ Hr- 30,000 TPA], (11) AOD (MC FeMn/LC FeMn/MC FeCr/LC FeCr) [2x25 TMT]-1,98,000 TPA, (12) Jigging Plant [2x20 TPH]-10,000 TPA, (13) Briquetting Unit [4x250 Kg/Hr- 1,000 Kg/Hr], (14) Argon Plant [60,000 M³/Day]-19.8 Mm³, (15) Oxygen Plant [3,00,000 M³/Day]-99 Mm³, (16) Nitrogen Plant [9,00,000 M³/Day]-297 Mm³, (17) Slag Crusher [2x25 TPH]-50 TPH, (18) Brick Manufacturing Unit-1,00,000 Bricks/Day, (19) Power Plant-200 MW (WHRB Power Plant) [2x50 MW]-100 MW and CFBC Power Plant [2x50 MW]-100 MW] के पर्यावरणीय स्थितिगत विवरण को सूचित किया जाता है। पर्यावरण संरक्षण मंडल में अधिसूचित किया गया है कि सर्व संबंधित को सूचित किया जाता है कि मेसर्स की एच. एच. एच. प्रोडक्ट लिमिटेड, गान्धारी (होस्ट), जयपुर, तहसील-जयपुर, जिला-राजसूत (छ.ग.) में निम्न की गई है। यह भी सूचित है कि लोक सुनवाई के दौरान भारत सरकार, पर्यावरण एवं जलवायु परिवर्तन मंत्रालय, नई दिल्ली की अधिसूचना दिनांक 14.09.2006 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AT A wedding reception in Gurgaon in February 2024, the man commanding the most attention was not the groom.

Aakash Baisoya, 28, stood on a stage beside his wife, while relatives and guests from Piliانji, a village in South Delhi, gathered beneath the chandeliers. There were businessmen, political figures and members of an extended clan that had lived in the area for generations. But the banquet hall kept orbiting around one man.

Aakash's father, Virender Singh Baisoya, known as Viru, was 50, tall and imposing. He had flown in from Dubai for his son's wedding, and he did not intend to stay long.

"After the celebrations, he left the country again," recalls a senior officer with the Special Cell of Delhi Police.

It would be the last time Delhi police investigators saw him in the national capital.

Eight months later, Baisoya's name surfaced in what became one of Delhi's biggest narcotics cases. Police alleged he was the kingpin of a cocaine network with links to South America and Thailand. The Special Cell seized more than Rs 7,000 crore worth of cocaine from a West Delhi godown — the largest drug haul in the Capital's history.

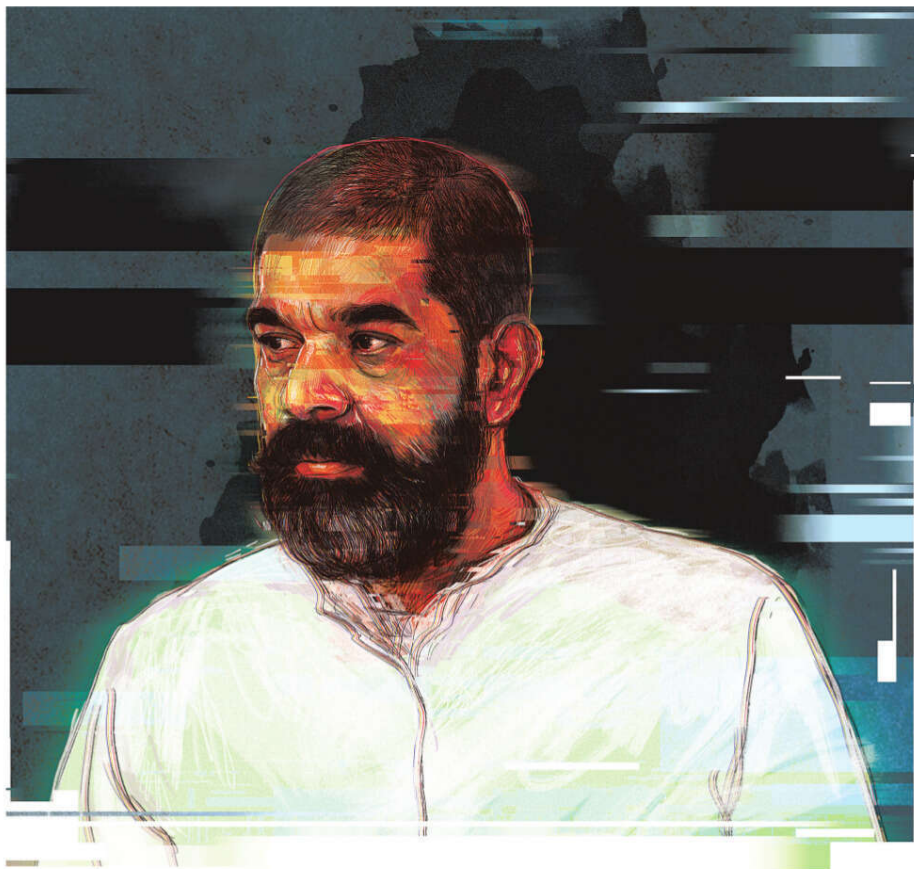
But the scale of the seizure was only part of what intrigued Delhi police.

Police said they had uncovered a sophisticated, layered network unlike those previously seen in Delhi, involving pharmaceutical professionals and intermediaries who kept its top operators out of sight.

For months, Baisoya remained one of them. "We have been waiting to arrest and question Baisoya. He remained beyond our reach," a senior official said.

Then, last week, that wait appeared to be coming to an end after Home Minister Amit Shah posted on X, "Creating a new milestone in the policy of zero tolerance against narcotics, the NCB secured the return of fugitive Virender Singh Baisoya from the UAE," his post read.

For the Delhi Police officers, who had nearly for two years been reconstructing what they believe was an industrial-scale supply chain, the announcement raised an immediate question: Would they finally get the chance to question the man they consider its most important missing link?



early suppliers, selling it for Rs 3,000-Rs 4,000 a gram.

As demand grew, smugglers from African countries took over much of the trade, a senior police official said. Couriers, some travelling on medical visas, rented homes in South Delhi neighbourhoods such as Chhatrapur, where cocaine was concealed, mixed and sold through local networks.

Social media later allowed suppliers and handlers to coordinate across borders without meeting in person.

"But the trade remained fragmented. It was never industrial scale," the officer said.

That changed in October 2024.

On October 1, the Special Cell raided a warehouse in Mahipalpur leased by Tushar Goel, the son of a publisher, and seized 562 kg of cocaine and 40 kg of hydroponic marijuana.

Nine days later, another 208 kg of cocaine was recovered from a shop in Ramesh Nagar. After this recovery, the probe revealed that the drug belonged to a Gujarat-based company named Pharma Solutions Services, an officer said.

The trail led investigators to Ankleshwar, in Gujarat. There, police recovered another 518 kg of cocaine, worth about Rs 5,000 crore, from a firm in the Ankleshwar GIDC, officers said.

The drugs, investigators said, had travelled a long way before reaching Gujarat. "Sourced from Colombia and Peru, the drugs reached Gujarat from Dubai, using multiple sea routes. They were sorted and mixed in the factory before being dispatched to Delhi-NCR," the officer said.

Inside the Avakar factory, police allegedly found an industrial-scale operation. "Machinery used to package medicines and syrups in bulk was allegedly being used to mix and pack cocaine," the official said.

The cocaine did not move through Delhi in gram-sized packets. "It travelled as cargo belonging to multinational companies as medical consignments. On paper, they were being transferred to a shell pharma company," the official said.

"The fake company hired employees on the pretext of working for a pharma brand — many of them MBA graduates — and used them to arrange storage in NCR. The company's name was also used to hire vehicles from transporters in Delhi to move the con-

While he remained out of reach, investigators say they went after the network around him. Through a series of arrests, police picked apart what they describe as the cartel's network of middlemen, employees and handlers.

DELHI'S COCAINE KINGPIN

Virender Singh Baisoya, the alleged 'kingpin' behind Delhi's largest drug haul, is back in India after nearly two years on the run. PRAGYNESH and ALOK SINGH report on why his return could be a breakthrough and shed new light on cocaine operations in the Capital

Fourteen people have been arrested in the Delhi case. Baisoya is not one of them — at least, not yet. "We have arrested the middlemen, employees and handlers. However, we still have not questioned the most crucial link — Virender Singh Baisoya," another senior police official said.

And that, for Delhi Police, is what makes Baisoya's return more consequential than the arrest of just another fugitive.

The Village: Piliانji

Piliانji is a village the city has slowly surrounded.

It is a Gujar settlement, home to one of the National Capital Region's prominent land-owning communities. Its lanes remain narrow. Cows and buffaloes move along the Royal Enfield and SUVs. On a humid August afternoon, hookahs still smoulder in the shade of the porches.

This was where Baisoya grew up. "His family was never short of money. Land and houses in and around Piliانji brought in a steady income," says an eighty-year-old neighbour of the family.

But Baisoya, they say, was not content to live on it. "He bought some land or flats. I don't exactly remember...around Noida, as well. He got rent from there also," the eighty-year-old says.

His family home still stands in Piliانji: a four-storey grey building that is more polished than many of the houses around it. Long balconies run along each floor, their railings made of glass. At the front are tall black iron gates.

Relatives say the house is occupied. "His mother, who is around 70-years-old, lives here, along with his wife, and his brother Ravinder's family. He also did some contractual work. I heard he got a contract to make a hospital in Jammu last year," says Ankit, Baisoya's nephew.

In Piliانji, there is no single account of the man Baisoya was before investigators began describing him as an alleged kingpin. Depending on whom you ask, he was a contractor, a property dealer, and a businessman. The Delhi Police have another chronology.

The first border

According to investigators, Baisoya's journey into alleged illicit trade began not with cocaine, but with cigarettes.

Delhi Police say he was allegedly involved in smuggling imported cigarettes from Dubai into India.

"The Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) registered two cases against him, and he was declared a proclaimed offender —

Who is Virender Baisoya

- Kingpin of a cocaine network with links to South America and Thailand
- Hails from Delhi's Piliانji village in Sarojini Nagar
- Journey into alleged illicit trade began not with cocaine, but with cigarettes
- Initially opened a courier company, later a handloom business; then lived in Jammu for some time and ran a construction business
- Due to losses in the construction business, he had to return to Delhi; then moved to UK
- From UK, he shifted to UAE from where he was extradited in NCB's Pune case

meaning an accused on the run," a senior police officer said.

Baisoya had studied through Class 12 and later enrolled in a Delhi University college, but did not complete his studies.

"He initially opened a courier company and later started a handloom business. He also ventured into the construction business, following which he lived in Jammu for some time. However, due to losses in the construction business, he had to return to Delhi," the police officer said.

Later, Baisoya moved to the UK, where he met Sandeep Dhunay, 42, a British national of Indian origin with roots in Patna. The relationship, according to police, marked a turn.

"The two allegedly started trafficking in narcotics," the police officer said.

For Indian-origin fugitives and

smugglers, investigators say, Britain has long offered an attractive place to settle and operate, particularly in and around London.

"The country's ability to provide creative money laundering schemes is revered. Indian-origin smugglers like Virender 'Dave' Sharma, Akbar Shamji, and even gangster Kapil Sangwan have prospered in the country," the senior officer said.

Baisoya's movements, meanwhile, were becoming increasingly difficult to follow. While he was in Gurgaon for his son's wedding, Pune City Police received a tip that a consignment of mephedrone was headed for the city, a senior police officer said.

"Soon, Baisoya left for the UAE, another favourite among drug traffickers of the highest ilk," the officer said. "Criminals or smugglers like Baisoya, who are aware that security agencies are searching for them,

prefer to remain underground once they arrive in foreign countries."

Back in India, the investigation was beginning to acquire a different scale.

Pune Police allegedly seized 500 grams of mephedrone during an operation in February 2024.

"They found Baisoya linked to it. The probe was expanded to trace the wider network, leading to follow-up recoveries of around 867 kg of mephedrone from Pune and 970 kg from Delhi," an officer said. The case was subsequently transferred to the NCB's Mumbai Zonal Unit.

Cocaine comes to Delhi

Delhi Police officials said cocaine first surfaced in Delhi around 1996 and gained a wider market in the early 2000s. Foreigners staying in Paharganj hotels were among the

Journey of cocaine

- Cocaine first surfaced in Delhi around 1996
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- Until October 2024, trade remained fragmented, was never on industrial scale
- OCTOBER 1:** Special Cell raided a warehouse in Mahipalpur, seized 562 kg of cocaine
- OCT 10:** In another seizure, 208 kg of cocaine was recovered from a shop in Ramesh Nagar
- The trail led investigators to Ankleshwar in Gujarat where police recovered 518 kg of cocaine, worth about Rs 5,000 crore

Delhi Police's Wait

For more than two years, Delhi Police had been unable to bring Baisoya back to India.

But while he remained out of reach, investigators say they went after the network around him. Through a series of arrests, police picked apart what they describe as the cartel's network of middlemen, employees and handlers. Officers point to seizure data as evidence that the crackdown disrupted its operations.

In 2024, authorities seized 1,293,298 kg of cocaine in cases registered under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act. In 2025, that figure fell to 12,64 kg. In the first six months of 2026, authorities seized 6.6 kg.

"The numbers clearly show that these arrests have made an impact and the network's operations have been disrupted," an officer said.

Baisoya, however, remained beyond their reach. Delhi Police first secured a non-bailable warrant against him and later sought an Interpol Red Corner Notice. The Special Cell also sent letters rogatory — formal requests for legal assistance — to authorities in Dubai.

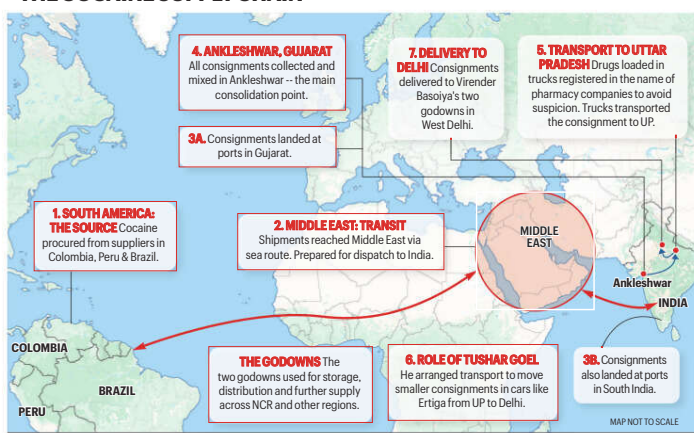
Still, tracking him proved difficult. "He was seen once in Dubai at that time, and then he just disappeared," said a police officer who was part of the team that tracked Baisoya. "We had information that he was travelling around the Middle East, but until June this year, we had very little information about his movements."

"For the last two years, we wanted to arrest him because we wanted to curb the sale of cocaine and other high-end drugs in Delhi," the officer said. "Now, after his arrest, questioning him is important because he was not simply an ordinary member of the network. He was like the executive head of this cartel."

"Although his handlers, including Sandeep Dhunay, were based in Dubai and Pakistan, Baisoya was their link to the capital's market," the officer said.

His strength, investigators believe, was his connection to Delhi. "His network and social connections in the city were very strong," the officers said. For Delhi Police, that is why his return matters.

THE COCAINE SUPPLY CHAIN





Chai pe Chat

UNION MINISTER for Ports, Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal earlier this week chose to launch Paradip Port's new Rs 20-crore piped natural gas (PNG) network not from the stage, but from an employee's kitchen. Sonowal lit the PNG stove and, in an impromptu gesture, prepared tea while chatting with port workers. Officials had planned a formal stage launch on Friday, but Sonowal, who represents Dibrugarh, known as the tea capital of India, opted for a more personal visit. The spontaneous act became an informal conversation about how the new PNG supply, initially covering 546 quarters, could make life easier for the port employees, and reduce their expenses. The minister also heard directly from the employees about life in the port town.

Seeking Feedback

UNION AGRICULTURE Minister Shweta Singh Choudhan on Sunday addressed sadhus at a Sant Samagam in Haridwar, explaining to them the benefits of one-nation, one-election, and seeking their views on it. He said that constant elections mean distraction from governance, and imply more deployment of money and resources. They may also deepen caste and religious divisions, he said.

On Menu

THE 'NAMO Cafe', set up in one corner of the BJP headquarters, was among the highlights of the two-day oration-led campaign featuring leaders from across the country over the weekend. Featuring an array of published work on Prime Minister Narendra Modi, and, according to party insiders, aimed at providing a breather from back-to-back meetings and workshops, the set-up also had more than just tea and coffee to offer. The menu included 'Wisdom Bowl', 'Main Character Meals', 'Zen Master Matcha', 'The Visionary Platter' and 'Brain Booster Fuel' covering, according to insiders, everything from soups and salads to quick healthy snacks and light meal combinations.

Stalin pushes for DMK reforms but TVK win signals deeper shift

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, August 23

FACED WITH defeat, more or less every political party undergoes a stage in which the numbers may have been accepted, but a struggle ensues to get to grips with their meaning. Three months after DMK was routed in Tamil Nadu, party president and former CM K Stalin, who himself lost his constituency, stood before his party's executive committee and attempted to explain failure to an organisation accustomed to thinking historically about its survival.

"There is no victory that we have not seen and there is no defeat that we have not seen," Stalin told the party's high-level executive committee, which adopted the proposals to revamp the party organisation. "A lamp that gives light to an entire town cannot see the darkness beneath itself."

A message meant to reassure the party also contained the central tension that defines DMK at the moment. While the party has accepted that it lost an election, it is less evident that it has understood the phenomenon that defeated it.

Stalin was unsparing about some of party's failures. "First, we must acknowledge our mistakes. We must acknowledge them openly," he said. A 38-member committee examined the defeat. Tens of thousands of sug-



DMK president and former Chief Minister M K Stalin leaves after party's meeting in Chennai on Saturday. ANI FILE

gestions arrived on a website. Stalin said he had read them. A restructuring committee headed by ex-minister Thangam Thennarasu considered organisational changes. Then came perhaps his finest metaphor. "A lamp that gives light to an entire town cannot see the darkness beneath itself."

The darkness, in his diagnosis, included inaccessible office-bearers, fake membership figures, entrenched local hierarchies, and leaders unwilling to let others grow. Stalin proposed special units and townships for some positions, genuine membership enrolment, organisational elections and more opportunities for newcomers. These are substantial admissions for a 75-year-old political movement.

But what if the problem is larger than the organisation?

DMK appears, at least from Stalin's prescription, to be treating an existential shock party as an organisational malfunction. The district secretary needs reform, membership needs verification, and younger people need promotion. In short, the machinery needs servicing, it believes.

While all of the above may be true, TVK did not defeat DMK because it had better district secretaries. CM C. Joseph Vijay arrived through an almost opposite political architecture: fandom, celebrity, digital culture, first-time political workers, enthusiasm with status quo, and voters willing to entrust the state to people without apprenticeship.

The elections saw voters challenge the political establishment's assumptions about political legitimacy. Against this backdrop comes Stalin's contented questioning of the new

forces in charge of the state.

"Look at the kind of people who have now come to power," said the DMK chief. "They have come to power without working for the people, without conducting struggles, without ideology and without an organisational structure."

In short, he tried to remind his colleagues that their movement possesses something the TVK does not: history.

However, as a senior leader said, that leads to a more pressing question. "If people without sufficient struggle, ideology or organisation defeated a party possessing all three, what exactly did voters choose?"

asked the leader. "To say that TVK lacked traditional qualifications for power may be perfectly defensible from within our own understanding of politics. But voters were evidently using another definition."

That, the senior leader said, remains part of the party's difficulty in coming to terms with the defeat, particularly Stalin's loss in Kolathur.

"For DMK, Vijay is not merely an opponent. His victory challenges its most basic belief about politics, that power must be earned through ideology, organisation and years of political work. He won without doing politics in the manner the party believes politics ought to be done," said a veteran academic from a Dravidian political family.

According to some, Stalin deserves credit as parties rarely

examine themselves gracefully after getting routed in elections. His criticism of local bosses was unusually specific. Stalin also appeared to suggest that the disruptive nature of the party in its nascent years — it disrupted the old order through its language, cinema, street politics, platform speakers, nationalism, and social-justice arguments — has morphed into an institution. And now it is facing another political insurgent.

"Institutions, like individuals, can become trapped by the world they already know. The familiar stops appearing as a choice and begins appearing as reality itself," said the academic. Half a dozen DMK fellow travellers — former ministers, longtime associates, and a leader who later joined TVK — whom *The Indian Express* spoke to emphasised one point repeatedly.

The party's challenge is not simply restructuring itself but understanding why somebody could inherit much of the world the Dravidian movement created and still decide that its principal political custodian no longer deserved his vote.

"Stalin has begun the first task. His speech proves that the DMK knows it must change," a former minister said.

As Stalin said, a lamp may indeed illuminate an entire town without seeing the darkness beneath itself. But after this election, DMK must consider another possibility. Perhaps the town itself has changed.

Punjab SIR: Former envoy Navdeep Suri issued notice, told to 'produce documents'

CEO says his name was part of the draft electoral roll published on August 13

Kamaldeep Singh Brar
Amritsar, August 23

FORMER DIPLOMAT Navdeep Suri on Sunday raised concerns over the process of establishing citizenship during the ongoing SIR in Punjab.

Taking to X, Suri detailed his experience navigating the SIR process and questioned what it meant for ordinary citizens if a former ambassador found the process difficult. He wrote that he was issued a notice by the Election Commission and asked to produce documents after discrepancies were flagged in his details from the 2003 electoral roll.

"I happen to have documents other than voter ID and Aadhaar card. But can't help asking: If I have trouble establishing my citizenship after representing India in three countries, what's the fate of the common citizen? Ease of Living, I presume!" Suri wrote.

"Spoke with BLO, was told that I should come and collect the notice. And then come again with unspecified documents that show I am an Indian citizen. I replied that I was not in India in 2003, so they have asked for passport as proof. Documents uploaded in 2026 don't match my details from 2003. Weird because I was at



Former diplomat Navdeep Suri

the Indian High Commission in London in 2003 and didn't participate in the SIR," he said.

Suri served in India's diplomatic missions in Cairo, Damascus, Washington, Dar es Salaam and London, and was India's Consul General in Johannesburg. He was also High Commissioner to Australia and Ambassador to Egypt and the UAE.

When contacted, Punjab CEO Anindita Mitra said Suri's name was never removed. "The name of former diplomat Navdeep Suri is part of the draft electoral roll published on August 13. It was never removed. His vote was registered in Amritsar and continues to be registered there. He received a notice and was asked to submit documents as he was not mapped in the 2003 SIR. After getting the documents, his name was published as part of electoral roll," Mitra said.

Cleanliness drive and blood donation camps to be part of BJP Sewa Sankalp campaign

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, August 23

BJP PRESIDENT Nitin Nabin on Sunday met the party's new political office-bearers to discuss preparations for the Sewa Sankalp Abhiyan, a month-long campaign which will kick off on September 17 to mark 25 years of Prime Minister Narendra Modi in power.

Sources said that apart from blood donation camps, a cleanliness drive would also be held as Gandhi Jayanti falls within the month-long span of the event. There would also be a campaign to take the welfare schemes of Modi government to the people, as the birth anniversary of Jana Sangh leader and ideologue Deen Dayal Upadhyaya on September 25 also falls within that month-long window.

"Since sewa or service has been synonymous with Modi

ji's stints in power as PM, and earlier as CM of Gujarat, it would be the theme of the Abhiyan," said a national office-bearer of the party.

On Sewa Sankalp Abhiyan, party general secretary Vinod Tawde had said it would coincide with "Seva Pakhwada" that BJP observes to mark the birthday of PM Modi on September 17. He had said that October 7 will mark the completion of 25 years since Modi first took the oath as Gujarat CM.

During the party's national office-bearers meeting Saturday, a resolution was passed to uphold the "honour, dignity, legacy and national status of the complete Vande Mataram", condemning Congress's decision to sing only its first two stanzas. BJP also announced it will launch a campaign to take the legacy of Vande Mataram across the country.

'Normalcy returning': BJP holds 1st organisational meeting in Srinagar

Naveed Iqbal
Srinagar, August 23

JAMMU & Kashmir unit of the BJP held a meeting of its office bearers for the first time in Srinagar on Sunday.

With a focus on further strengthening the organisation and expanding grassroots outreach, the party brought together its workers from across the Union Territory as it stressed on "continued ideological commitment" and a stronger presence at the booth level.

The party also announced a plan to gherao the Assembly next month to draw attention to alleged corruption and other issues in ruling NC government.

Party's J&K unit president Sat Sharma chaired the meeting while MoS PMO Jitendra Singh; Leader of Opposition in the J&K Assembly, Sunil Sharma; and BJP's general secretary (organisation) Ashok Koul, were among those present. The two-day meeting will conclude on Monday.

Addressing the workers'



Union MoS Jitendra Singh at the BJP meeting in Srinagar on Sunday.

meeting, Sat Sharma called for sustained engagement with the people and increased "pravas" (stay) by senior leaders and office bearers to strengthen direct contact across J&K. "BJP is not merely a political organisation but a movement rooted in nationalist ideology and dedicated to public service," he said.

While BJP has previously held its state unit meetings in Jammu, it is for the first time that party workers gathered for an organisational meeting in Srinagar.

Union Minister Singh said there has been a paradigm shift in the mindset of people in J&K

after PM Narendra Modi came to power at the Centre. "Since PM Modi's tenure began, the atmosphere here has changed. There is peace and normalcy is returning. Development works are going at a good pace," Singh said on the sidelines of the meeting.

At the event, BJP leadership also underlined the growing importance of social media and other platforms in taking the party's programmes and policies to a wider audience. LoP Sharma said that concerns of the people of J&K, "including issues to be raised in the Assembly session in September," were taken up.

Rahul's Pune event a political comedy show: BJP; Cong hits back

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 23

A DAY after LoP Rahul Gandhi targeted PM Narendra Modi over his remark that he was shocked to hear girls using abusive language during the Jantar Mantar protest, BJP dismissed his event as "political comedy show" with Congress countering that BJP's appeal among youth has rattled the ruling party.

CM Devendra Fadnis termed Gandhi and Congress's stance hypocritical while opposing the Women's Reservation Bill in Parliament. "Rahul Gandhi makes big statements about women empowerment on stage. But when it came to passing the Women's Reservation Bill, he and his party staunchly opposed it. This shows the double standard of Rahul Gandhi and Congress," he said.

"He does not want to give rights to women. I believe his words don't match his actions," he said.

At the 'Chhatron Ki Gooni'

event in Pune Saturday, Gandhi said even though both boys and girls used abusive language during the protest, the PM "felt a cultural shock because girls used such a language." "If boys abuse, there is no problem, but if a girl abuses, it is a cultural shock," he had said.

Maharashtra BJP media cell in-charge Navnath Ban charged Congress to name party MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra party chief. BJP Maharashtra vice-president Keshav Upadhye said Gandhi did not address genuine student concerns and described the event as "yet another political comedy show."

Hitting back, Maharashtra Congress chief Harshwardhan Sapkal said, "BJP has sensed the ground slipping under its feet. It is trying to hold on through a communal agenda, but it will backfire."

Congress national secretary Sachin Sawant claimed BJP had lost sleep over "unprecedented response" to Gandhi's interaction.

● SUKHU'S TENURE AS HIMACHAL CM HAS BEEN DEFINED BY A DILEMMA: HOW TO RUN A WELFARE-HEAVY STATE WITH AN INCREASINGLY EMPTY PURSE?

Sukhvinder Sukhu has survived rebellion, disaster and debt. Can he now win?



NORTHERN LIGHTS

BY MANRAJ GREWAL
SHARMA

A WEEKLY DISPATCH ON THE POLITICS AND IDEAS SHAPING NORTH INDIA

THIS WEEK, Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu, who has long championed *vyavastha parivartan* (systemic change), turned on the system itself, calling it too bulky and costly.

His government plans a 15-30% cut in the sanctioned strength of Indian Administrative Service, Indian Police Service, and Indian Forest Service officers — a move he says will save the cash-strapped state about Rs 200 crore and ensure more meaningful deployment

of personnel. It is a typical Sukhu response to the dilemma that has defined his tenure: how to run a welfare-heavy state with an increasingly empty purse.

Sukhu, who rose through the ranks to become the Congress's lone Chief Minister in the North, occupies a space once dominated by six-time CM Virbhadra Singh, the flamboyant erstwhile royal of the Rampur-Bushahr estate. After Virbhadra died in 2021 and Congress's 2022 victory, many expected the mantle to pass to his family.

Instead, the high command backed Sukhu, once at daggers drawn with the old royal. Sukhu was everything Virbhadra was not: the son of an Himachal Road Transport Corporation driver from the lower hills who worked his way up the party ladder. His family, by his own accounts, knew hardship. His mother, Sarda Devi, recalled how the family sometimes struggled to put enough food on the table.

As a student at Himachal Pradesh University, Sukhu ran a milk counter and sold newspapers in the mornings while cutting his teeth in student

politics. He bought his first car, a white Maruti Alto, after becoming an ML in 2003 and still drives it, taking it to the Assembly even after becoming CM.

"A man should never forget his past," said the CM who, by his own admission, spent years looking at Oukover, the official CM residence, thinking that one day he would live there.

The Congress's decision to choose him was not taken on a whim. As the party's campaign in-charge for the 2022 polls, Sukhu commanded the support of more than half the legislators.

A challenging run

But CM-Sukhu hasn't been all roses for Sukhu. He's had to fight to survive.

Barely six months after he took over, Himachal suffered one of its worst monsoon disasters in decades. Terrifying images of government vehicles being washed away, roads and homes dominated the news, with the state pegging the losses at more than Rs 10,000 crore.

Then came the political crisis. In the February 2024 Rajya Sabha election, six Congress



Himachal Pradesh CM Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu and Congress MLAs protest outside Vidhan Sabha in Shimla on Friday. ANI

MLAs crossed voted to help the BJP defeat Congress candidate Abhishek Manu Singhvi. For weeks, Sukhu's government teetered on the brink. But the rebels were disqualified, bypolls followed, and the Congress clawed back enough seats, including one won by Sukhu's wife Kamlesh, to restore its strength to 40 in the 68-member House.

But surviving a political crisis is one thing. Surviving a financial crisis is another.

The state was already drowning in debt when Sukhu inherited it from the Jai Ram Thakur government. The debt has since crossed Rs 1 lakh crore. Almost 70% of revenue goes towards salaries, pensions, interest payments and debt ser-

ving. The pressure is reflected in the state's 2026-27 budget, with expenditure estimates lower than the previous year.

Sukhu has repeatedly blamed the Centre for what he calls turning its back on the hill state. He has also argued that Himachal suffered heavily under the GST regime, claiming a loss of Rs 25,000 crore because the state is a manufacturing hub for pharma drugs, not a major consumer. The 16th Finance Commission's decision to discontinue the Revenue Deficit Grant of more than Rs 10,000 crore from 2026-27 has further strained the state's finances.

Sukhu's answer has been austerity: salary cuts for ministers, MLAs, and senior officers; rationalisation of MLA funds; curbs on vehicle purchases; and a squeeze on government expenditure. While the salary cut

has been widely welcomed, Sukhu continues to draw only 50% of his salary. Critics say penny-pinching is no substitute for raising revenue. Some of Sukhu's revenue-gateways have hit a wall. The High Court struck down his

water cess on hydropower, aimed at raising Rs 1,900 crore.

The political criticism has been equally persistent. Within Congress, Sukhu's critics call him arrogant, while admirers say he believes in straight talk.

The residual Virbhadra Singh camp has gripped about being sidelined. Leader of Opposition Jai Ram Thakur has kept up the pressure, dubbing the government a "mitron ki sarkar" (a government of its leaders' friends) and accusing Sukhu of rewarding friends with political appointments while pursuing a political vendetta against defectors.

Sukhu unfazed

Yet Sukhu remains unfazed. In late 2024, he became the first Himachal CM to spend a night in a local home in Dodra Kwar, the remote region often called Shimla district's "Kala Pani". His political pitch combines austerity with welfare, but with a twist: giving the vulnerable a source of income rather than merely a dole.

So, farmers get support

prices for organic produce and milk; orphans and vulnerable children are looked after by the state; English is now taught from Class I; young people can get a 50% subsidy for e-taxis, with government leases providing assured income.

On Independence Day, Sukhu announced measures to improve the economic condition of 1.8 lakh families over two years. He also extended doctors' retirement age, raised remuneration for health workers and announced 100 new CBSE schools.

The message is clear: cut *fizd ki kharchi* (unnecessary spending) at the top, while putting money into the hands of those at the bottom.

In a state where power has ping-ponged between the Congress and the BJP since 1990, incumbents rarely get a second chance. Sukhu has survived rebellion, disaster, and a fiscal squeeze. Now comes the harder part.

Can the survivor become a winner?

The author is National Editor (North), The Indian Express

Police say no plot, Badal attack was 'spur-of-the-moment' act

Mohamed Thaver
Mumbai, August 23

NEARLY 10 days after 63-year-old Jaspal Singh was arrested for allegedly attacking Shriromani Akali Dal (SAD) leader and former Punjab Deputy Chief Minister Sukhbir Singh Badal at Gurdwara Mata Sahib Devan Ji in Nanded, the police investigation has found no evidence of a wider conspiracy. Singh appears to have acted alone, with the attack being a spur-of-the-moment decision after a meditation session, according to police.

Singh told investigators that he felt morally compelled to attack Badal, whom he blamed for the worsening drug crisis in Punjab and, ever since he heard about Badal's visit to the gurdwara where he was serving, he felt he had to do something, "an officersaid."

Singh told police that during

a prayer session he felt a call from Waheguru to attack Badal, following which he decided to act, the officersaid.

"After going through technical evidence, his interrogation and recording statements of those around him, it appears that he was acting alone and that no one else was involved in the attack," the officersaid.

Singh is expected to be produced before a local court on Monday. Police said Singh had been a part of the police's investigation in Pune in 2023 and subsequently became a Nihang Sikh sevadar (volunteer) in Nanded. He was a lawyer by profession and had worked with a corporate firm in Mumbai, police said.

The attack took place when Badal was coming down the gurdwara's steps when he allegedly lunged at Badal with a kirpan (dagger). A Maharashtra Police officer from Badal's security detail intervened and stopped him suffering minor injuries.

Singh's stated motives come against the backdrop of sustained political attacks on the SAD leadership over the drug problem in Punjab.

Will speak on all issues soon: Revant on US trip controversy

MEA's malafide intentions, says
Telangana
Congress chief

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, August 23

TELANGANA CHIEF Minister A Revanth Reddy said on Sunday that he would "speak about all issues" regarding the cancelled trip to the US, once he returns to India.

The CM, who finished his UK leg of the trip on Sunday, wrote in a post on X that "instead of going to Boston as planned", he will now return to Hyderabad.

Telangana Congress president B Mahesh Kumar Goud said the MEA had malafide intentions to deny Reddy because the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government at the Centre was worried about Telangana getting direct access to universities in the US. "They were worried that the CM was slated to directly meet US Vice President JD Vance. Hence, with malafide intentions, the MEA

cancelled the CM's US trip," the Telangana Pradesh Congress Committee (TPCC) chief told *The Indian Express*.

Meanwhile, thanking the All India Congress Committee, Reddy wrote in his X post, "My deepest gratitude for the strong support from our leader and Congress party national president, Shri Mallikarjun Khargeji, on the issue of Centre denying me permission to travel to the USA." He said, "I am very thankful to my party, all the leaders and people across the country who supported (me) in this issue in national interest. I have concluded all my meetings and scheduled events in London and I am grateful for the overwhelming support that I have received in past three days."

He said, "In a few hours, I will be heading a flight back home to Hyderabad instead of proceeding to Boston as per original schedule, after the MEA (Central Govt) denied permission for my USA tour for 'political reasons'."

He said, "I will speak about all the related issues once I return to Hyderabad." When contacted, Reddy's team in the CM's office refused



Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy

to comment on the US trip. "The CM himself will explain what happened," an official in the CMO said. Reddy is expected to reach Hyderabad early on Monday morning, his team said.

The Indian Express had earlier reported that Reddy's visit to the US included possible meetings with Vice President Vance and New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani on August 26.

The Chief Minister's Office, when contacted, said the meeting with the NYC Mayor was "tentative." There are a lot of events which are added to the schedule. No official communi-

cation was exchanged between the Mayor of New York and the CM's office," the CMO said.

Government sources in New Delhi confirmed to *The Indian Express* that the CM was planning to meet Vice President Mamdani during his visit. Explaining the reasons for the Indian government denying clearance to Reddy's US visit, sources said that the MEA — while issuing political clearance — looked at two basic aspects: the "level" of meetings and the "purpose".

"The application for political clearance cited 'Rising Telangana' — an investment promotion programme by the state government led by Reddy, according to sources. This was the ostensible reason for his visit to the US."

On Saturday, Reddy's possible meeting with the NYC Mayor snowballed into a row in Telangana with Bharat Kashtha Samiti (BRS), the primary opposition, asking if the Centre denied permission to Reddy because he might have met Mamdani.

"The Centre and state government must explain the cancellation of the CM's US visit," BRS MLC Dr Dasoju Sravan said.



State Urban Development Minister Agnimitra Paul speaks to the homeless woman in the video. EXPRESS

On inspection drive, Bengal Minister Paul admonishes homeless woman, faces backlash

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, August 23

WEST BENGAL Minister Agnimitra Paul on Sunday faced strong backlash for admonishing a homeless woman for boiling milk for her child on a pavement in Kolkata.

Paul, who holds the twin portfolios of Urban Development and Municipal Affairs, was on an inspection drive on Saturday when he saw a woman boiling milk on the pavement. Seeing it a stove, Paul asked her why she was cooking on the street. "I am not cooking. I am only warming milk for the child," the woman replied as the child crawled nearby.

"Warming milk for a child on the pavement?" Paul thundered. "Who gave you the right to set up a household here?" the minister pulled up the elderly woman and asked her to remove her belongings.

Paul, the BJP MLA from Asansol Dakshin constituency, was seen instructing police officers accompanying him to clear the footpaths. "It is your duty to see that the footpaths are not encroached upon and stay clear of squatters. Why do I have to do this and be the bad one?" she said. After the video of the incident went viral, the Left-leaning women's front of All India Democratic Women's Association (AIDWA), condemned the behaviour, expressing their shock.

"Can a minister behave like this with a mother? She has been elected by the people. She is a public representative. Will she not have even this much empathy for the people? There is economic inequality in our society. As a result of the government policies, the disparity is increasing every day. That is why countless mothers like the elderly woman on Park Street have to raise their children on the pavement," a statement issued by the outfit said.

Demanding a public apology, the women's outfit said, "Instead of thinking about solving the problems of the marginalised people, the inhumane behaviour of the state minister — who is a woman herself — towards another woman is certainly condemnable."

In these 100 days (of the first BJP government), more than 50

incidents of violence against women have occurred. Women are representing across the state for not receiving money under the Annapurna scheme. A woman committed suicide in Gazole, Malda, after not receiving the Annapurna Bhandar money. There is no talk about all this. Yet another had to face harassment just for sitting on the pavement and heating milk for her child," the AIDWA added, referring to a string of protests across the state over non-receipt of funds under the cash transfer scheme.

TMC MLA and spokesperson of the party's Mamata Banerjee-led faction, Kumal Ghosh, also let out at the BJP minister. "Let the pavements be cleared out, but not by wiping away the human face... every drive must have a humane face. In our socio-economic structure, everything cannot be done with police and bulldozers. I have seen beggars even on the streets of advanced Western countries," the TMC MLA said, adding, "It does not take much effort to understand that the same government is anti-poor and inhuman."

Ghosh said that he met the affected woman, who told him that she hails from Punjab. "She is Hindu and her name is Sita. She married a Muslim man and is now known as Rashida. After her husband left, she was left helpless with one son and two daughters. Her son has died. One of her daughters has also been abandoned by her husband. They have no home. She lives by the roadside with her daughter and a small child. She cleans the streets and pavements and scavenges for waste. She has nowhere else to go," the TMC leader said.

"She has no disputes with the shopkeepers in the area. But after the minister's remarks, the police told her to move. She does not know where to go... In her words: 'For me, God and Allah are the same. But what do we do now? Where will we live? What will we eat?'" he said.

In a statement, Paul said, "Living like this (on the pavement) is not safe. Pavements are built for people to walk safely. But if people start encroaching upon pavements and living like this, gradually every street and pavement in Kolkata will be occupied."

कार्यालय अधिशासी अभियन्ता, केन्द्रीय भण्डार, उत्तराखण्ड जल संस्थान, जल भवन, 'बी' ब्लॉक, नेहरू कालोनी, देहरादून

Ref. No.: 536/EECSDDNE-Tender/U-Prepares/2026-27 Dated: 22/08/2026

NOTICE FOR REQUEST FOR BIDS

The Government of India has received financing from the World Bank towards the cost of the UPPREPARE and intends to apply part of the proceeds for following packages of Works. Bids are invited for the following Packages and a complete set of bidding documents in English may be downloaded by interested eligible bidders from the [website https://uktenders.gov.in](https://uktenders.gov.in) which will be available from 25/08/2026. Bids must be submitted online on the [website https://uktenders.gov.in](https://uktenders.gov.in)

S. N.	Package	Name of Package	Bill Security (Rs.)	Cost of Document (Rs.) Incl. GST	Period of Completion
1	IN-DRAINING WATER-551971-GO-RFB/US CSDON	Supply of Sewer Jetting Cum Machine of 8000 Ltr Capacity, Supply of Sewer Jetting Cum Machine of 1200 Ltr Capacity and Supply of Sewer Jetting Cum Machine of 4000 Ltr Capacity.	5.41 Lakhs	5900/-	06 Months
2	IN-DRAINING WATER-551976-GO-RFB/US CSDON	Supply of SS water Tanker 35 KL capacity with power pump assembly and sub frame assembly mounted on truck chassis with cabin for water works.	11.65 Lakhs	5900/-	06 Months
3	IN-DRAINING WATER-551974-GO-RFB/US CSDON	PROCUREMENT OF MOBILE WATER TESTING LABORATORIES FOR GARHWAL AND KUMAUN REGION IN UTTARAKHAND	1.91 Lakhs	4720/-	06 Months
4	IN-DRAINING WATER-551959-GO-RFB/US CSDON	Supply of 100-250 KVA 415 Volts "Silent" DG set outdoor type & KG set comprising Alternator mounted on common base frame, complete with STD control panel	9.91 Lakhs	5900/-	06 Months
5	IN-DRAINING WATER-551981-GO-RFB/US CSDON	Supply of Water Tanker Cum Sprinkler of 1250 Ltr capacity on 4 x 4 Chassis. A Centrifugal Pump driven by Petrol Engine for filling the tanks.	10.03 Lakhs	5900/-	06 Months

Note: - 1. The corresponding for the above packages will be uploaded on website [www.uktenders.gov.in](https://uktenders.gov.in) & www.u-prepare.com
2. Email id eeecs-up-uk@nic.in may be contacted for any information related to the bids.

Executive Engineer

CJP attack row: Cross FIRs, SC/ST case against Ranka & over 50 workers

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, August 23

FOLLOWING THE attack on a Cockerach Janta Party (CJP) delegation which was on its way to visit a school in Jaipur on August 21, cross FIRs were filed by both sides with CJP Co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka and "50-60" CJP workers booked under the SC/ST Act.

Meanwhile, 11 persons have been detained by Jodhpur police after they allegedly entered the Gandhi Shanti Prasththan where Ranka was addressing a seminar in Jodhpur on Sunday afternoon. Chanting "Jai Shri Ram" and "Cockerach Go Back", they allegedly hit one person briefly outside the building where Ranka was addressing before police and the others intervened.

In Jaipur, the FIR has been lodged on a complaint by Bhagwan Sanjay Dhanika, a resident of Rampura Kanwar Park, who said that on August 21, "at around 9:00 am, Ashutosh Ranka of CJP party came to our village with 50-60 people and they entered the village on the pretext of inspecting a school... when I and the villagers tried to reason with them, they started beating me and the villagers."

"They insulted me and other villagers by abusing us with casteist words..." Dhanki claimed, adding that he and other villagers have been injured.

The FIR against CJP workers has been lodged under BNS sections for voluntarily causing hurt, wrongful restraint, unlawful assembly and intentional insult with intent to provoke breach of peace, along with three sections of the SC/ST Act.

The other FIR has been lodged on a CJP worker Rekha Sharma's complaint.

"We are inspecting schools across country under CJP's School 'Thik Karo' campaign. We received information that in Rampura Kanwar Park, the government school is being run in a buffaloshed and decided to go there," she said.

"...villagers were stopped at the village border... We saw that at some distance, before the school, some anti-social elements were abusing... We repeatedly requested them to listen to us, that we have only come to inspect the school and have been called by the villagers themselves but our team was attacked from all sides with bricks, sticks, and tubes filled with stones. Four-five persons surrounded each of our workers and assaulted them brutally with the intent of fatality," the CJP complaint said.

Listing the injuries, it says Surendra alias Sanju Verma was brutally assaulted, leaving him with a fractured hand. Salman was surrounded and brutally beaten, leaving him with serious injuries. Dust was thrown into Rekha's eyes and she was attacked.

CJP has said that videos of the assault are available with the media and claimed the person who orchestrated the assault is Lalchand Sharma, who is also seen as assaulting on camera. "The villagers who came to rescue us claimed that Kamal Pradhan and Shankar Bagda had planned the assault," they said.

CJP demanded that several persons are "clearly visible" in the videos and legal action to be taken against them.

This FIR has been lodged under provisions of voluntarily causing hurt, wrongful restraint, unlawful assembly, mischief causing loss or damage to the amount of Rs 20,000 to 1 lakh, and intentional insult with intent to provoke breach of peace.

Bihar Police searches NDA MLA's home over demolition case

Himanshu Harsh
Kolkata, August 23

MUZAFFARPUR POLICE on Sunday searched the Bairyra residence of MLA Amit Kumar, also known as Amit Singh Ranu, in connection with a case registered over alleged demolition of construction on a piece of land in the Ahiyapur area, after investigators said they found evidence of the legislator's alleged involvement in the case.

Muzaffarpur Senior Superintendent of Police Kamal Kumar Mishra said search was conducted after the police obtained a warrant against the LJP(RV) MLA from Belsand (Samastipur), and his brother Sonu Singh alias Abhinav.

According to police, a case was registered on August 20 under sections of the BNS pertaining to a coordinated criminal conspiracy involving property grabbing, financial fraud, document forgery, theft, deliberate property damage, and extortion through severe threats of violence or death, on the complaint of Pralhad Kumar against one Sumit Srivastava and more than 50 unidentified persons.

Kumar alleged a group arrived with a bulldozer, a Scorpio and a Mahindra Thar, and demolished construction on his land and nearby properties. "Based on the complaint, two accused, Srivastava and Sunny Singh, were arrested. Subsequently, 12 others submitted complaints," SSP Mishra said.

Cong: LS not prorogued, is Shah still pushing delimitation Bill?

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, August 23

CONGRESS GENERAL secretary in-charge of communications Jai Ram Ramesh questioned Sunday why the Lok Sabha had not been prorogued after 10 days of its being adjourned sine die, wondering whether Union Home Minister Amit Shah was "still in search of 'two-thirds majority' to get the Constitutional Amendment

Bill on delimitation passed in a special session".

He was referring to the twin package of a Constitutional Amendment Bill to advance women's reservation to 2029 and a Delimitation Bill to increase the strength of the LS to up to 850 seats, for which a delimitation exercise would be required.

"The time gap between the adjournment of the LS sine die and its prorogation is generally

two to four days — although there may be many instances when adjournment and prorogation have taken place on the very same day. Ten days have passed... but still there is no information on its prorogation," Ramesh said.

"It is true that the gap for the Monsoon Session in 2015 was 26 days and in 2021 it was 20 days. But there were no diabolical moves after then."

"Is Union Home Minister still in search of his two-thirds majority to get the Constitutional Amendment Bill on De-

limitation passed in a Special Session," the Congress MP asked.

Former LS Secretary General P D Achary told *The Indian Express* there was no clear rule as to when Parliament should be prorogued after the House is adjourned sine die. He said that prorogation is a routine practice; that the President prorogues the House on the advice of the Council of Ministers. Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs Kiren Rijiju did not respond to a request for comment.

UJVN Ltd.
(An Uttarakhand Govt. Enterprise)
H.Q.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. ROAD, Dehradun-248006.
Phone : 0135-276368 & Fax : 0135-276368
CIN No. : U40101UR2001SG025866 Website : www.ujvn.com

RO No. 721

TENDER NOTICE Date: 22.08.2026

Office of the Executive Engineer (E&M K&KG-I SHP), UJVN Ltd., Guptkashi, invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below.

Tender No: 06/EE(E&M K&KG-I SHP)/Kailganga/1/2026-27
"Replacement of DG and Servicing of EOT Crane and LOS of Unit-I at Kailganga" SHP (2X20 MW+15%COL) located in Uttamathi Tehsil District Rudrapur.

Estimated cost: ₹ 15,52,297.00/- GST extra.

Date of availability of bid document on website: 24.08.2026, 17:00 hrs.
Last date for submission of tender: 18.09.2026 up to 11:00 hrs.

For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website: "www.ujvn.com"

Executive Engineer (E&M K&KG-I SHP)

"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

PUNE MUNICIPAL CORPORATION
CHIEF ENGINEER DEPARTMENT
NOTICE INVITING TENDERS (N.I.T) YEAR 2025-26
Tender Sale Date : 24-08-2026 14:30 PM to Date 18-09-2026 upto 14:30 PM
Bid Submission Start & End Date : 24-08-2026 14:30 PM to Date 18-09-2026 upto 14:30 PM
Technical Envelope Opening date : 21-09-2026 15:00 PM

Tender No.	Name of Department	Name of Work	Cost of Tender Document (Rs.)	Estimated Cost (Rs.)	EMD Amount Rs.	Work Period (Month)	Concern Contact Person
331/2026	Water Supply	Pune Manpachya Panipuravatha Khatyakadi Vividh Jakendrasathi Poly Aluminium Chloride Dravan (IS 15573:2005/2018) Nusal Puravine (Make-Grasim / GACI/ Arkl / M/s andhra Sugars Limited.)	Rs. 17879/-	Rs. 51512040/-	Rs. 257560/-	12	Sandeep Sapkal 9689931068

A) All details of Terms & Conditions of above works are incorporated in tender documents which is available on website www.mahatenders.gov.in Sale & acceptance is available by online system only. Tender needs to be submit in two envelope format.

B) If sales or submission not been available on last day also it is not been submitted will be sole responsibility of tenderer.

C) Online tender process information will be available at Water Supply, Pune Municipal Corporation.

D) As per office order No. 32, Dated 22/04/2016 EMD deposit amount will be acceptable through ECS/RTGS/NEFT Online Banking only.

जहित न्यायक : ३/६/१९
दिनांक : २१/०८/२०२६

Sd/- Abhijit Sathe
कांयकारी अधिकारी
कायविल (कायविलकार)
पुणे महानगरपालिका

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82(2)(ii) Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person namely **Ashraf Ali S/o Munawar Ali, R/o: H.No. D-7/64, Shop No. 68, DDA Market Machhi Chowk, Sultanpur, Delhi** (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 443/2020, U/s 394/411/34 IPC**, registered at P.S.: Prem Nagar, Delhi and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused **Ashraf Ali** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ashraf Ali** has absconded (or is concealing himself) to avoid the service of the said warrant, Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Ashraf Ali** accused **FIR No. 443/2020, U/s 394/411/34 IPC**, registered at P.S.: Prem Nagar, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.09.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Divyashree Raut
Judicial Magistrate First Class
Court No. 109
Rohini Colony, Delhi

DP/1808/RD/2026
(Court Matter)

Graft case: CBI books DGCA ex-official, 4 aviation firms

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, August 23

THE CBI has booked a former Director of Flying Training at the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), Captain Anil Gill, in relation to a corruption case.

The FIR, registered by CBI's Anti-Corruption Branch and naming four aviation-linked firms among others, is based on a complaint filed by Captain J S Dhillon, Managing Director, Global Avionautics Ltd.

The complaint alleged that Gill extended undue favours to select flying training organisations, causing loss and disadvantage to similarly placed operators, including Global Avionautics Ltd.

Gill, the FIR stated, also facilitated the purchase of training aircraft at nominal prices through companies controlled by his relatives and later arranged for the aircraft to be leased to favoured flying training organisations at high rates.

The alleged financial transactions have to do with the purchase and leasing of two Cessna aircraft by one of the companies. The FIR stated that the company acquired Cessna aircraft VT-EUC, a 1975 model, in 2020 for Rs 10 lakh, and VT-AAV, a 1981 model, in 2021 for Rs 37.5 lakh.

The agency has alleged that VT-AAV was acquired at a price significantly below its estimated market valuation of Rs 75 lakh to Rs 1 crore, despite being in operational condition with only 123 engine hours.

According to the FIR, between 2021 and October 2023, the firm allegedly generated more than Rs 2.16 crore in lease rentals from another such firm alone.

Five-year-old girl mauled by stray dog in Rajasthan

Press Trust of India
Kota, August 23

A 5-year-old girl was severely injured after being attacked by a stray dog in the Bengali Colony of the Chawani area in Rajasthan's Kota on Sunday.

Authorities from the Kota Municipal Corporation (KMC) stated that they are taking measures to address the stray dog problem in the city, including the construction of the state's first-ever dog shelter, specifically for strays.

The attack took place at around 7.15 pm when the victim, identified as Namra, was playing in a lane outside her house. The dog suddenly rushed toward her, knocked her to the ground, dragged her along the pavement, and bit her multiple times.

Hearing her desperate screams, a local woman and several nearby residents rushed to the scene and managed to chase the animal away.

Namra sustained deep wounds to her head, back, and wrists and was immediately taken to the hospital for treatment. The incident has raised significant concern among locals regarding public safety.

'Days of factory closures over': Bengal gets Rs 3,500-crore defence projects

Sweetey Kumari
Kolkata, August 23

DEFENCE MINISTER Rajnath Singh on Sunday laid the foundation stone for five brownfield projects worth Rs 3,500 crore in West Bengal, and said that the state was moving away from an era of industrial closures towards a new phase of manufacturing and investment.

The projects — three for Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers (GRSE) and two for Yantra India Limited (YIL) — are aimed at expanding defence manufacturing, shipbuilding and precision engineering capacity in the state.

"The state is now stepping towards a new development renaissance. The days of factory closures and padlocks in West Bengal are in the past; they have been replaced by the launch of new projects," Singh said while laying the stone virtually from Kolkata.

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvedu Adhikari and chief secretary Manoj Agarwal and senior officials from the Defence Ministry, GRSE and YIL attended the event.

GRSE signed lease agreements with Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port, Kolkata (SMPP) for two small shipyards on either banks of the Hooghly and a 32-acre riverside property at Raichak. The facilities are expected to expand the shipbuilder's capacity for warship construction and repair while creating opportunities for ancillary industries and MSMEs.

Singh also highlighted GRSE's record in indigenous defence production, saying the shipyard had constructed more than 800 vessels and that next generation offshore patrol vessels would have over 80% indigenous content. Congratulating GRSE's 'Navratna' status, he said, "This demonstrates that

we are rapidly reducing our dependence on foreign sources."

The two YIL projects will modernise facilities at the Metal and Steel Factory in Ishapore. Singh said YIL had invested over Rs 750 crore on the facility, replacing legacy systems dating back to 1978 with Industry 4.0-capable precision manufacturing systems.

The facilities are expected to produce specialised metals for heavy artillery, naval weapons and other defence equipment. "Self-reliance is not merely a policy; it is a force multiplier for battlefield capability. In this endeavour, the roles of GRSE and YIL will be crucial," he said.

He also said India had an opportunity to emerge as a major global shipbuilding hub as demand for naval and commercial vessels rises while capacity in several traditional shipbuilding nations declines.

"If we modernise our manufacturing capacity and adhere to global quality standards, India



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and West Bengal Chief Minister Suvedu Adhikari at the event in Kolkata on Sunday. PTI

can emerge as the world's next major shipbuilding hub," Singh said. Adding that as the nation advances on the path of self-reliance, Singh said there is a need to consider the emerging "Capacity Paradox" in the global shipbuilding sector. He identified Maintenance, Repair and Overhaul (MRO) as another area where India could expand its presence, particularly in the Indian Ocean region.

Singh said establishing India as an MRO hub, which he termed as a "low hanging fruit", would require comparatively lower capital investment while creating employment and reducing foreign exchange outgo.

Adhikari thanked Singh for bringing the projects to Bengal and described him as a "man of his word". Singh said the five projects would generate employment for thousands of people and provide a boost to MSMEs and allied industries.

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• BRIEFLY



The helicopter had four persons on board. No one was hurt. PTI

MAHARASHTRA

Bad weather forces helicopter to make emergency landing near lake

A HELICOPTER with four persons on board made an emergency landing near a lake after bad weather affected visibility in Maharashtra's Bhandara district on Sunday, officials said. Nobody was injured in the incident near the Mohgaon-Nilaj Road in Mohadi tehsil, they said. "A chopper belonging to a private company was on its way from Nagpur to Raipur when the pilot encountered inclement weather conditions around 11 am," an official said. It hovered over the Bhisari lake for some time before making an emergency landing near it. After staying put at the spot for an hour, it flew back to Nagpur when the weather conditions improved. PTI

Two prisoners escape from Srinagar jail

TWO PRISONERS escaped from the central jail in Srinagar on Sunday. Farman Kivori and Mukhtar Ahmad Gujar are under trial in separate cases under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act. Khan, a resident of Rajasthan, has been lodged in the central jail since June this year, while Gujar hails from Anantnag in South Kashmir and had been incarcerated since April this year. The J&K Police have issued a lookout notice for both accused and have announced a bounty for information from the public. ENS

Liquor transport 'scam': ED arrests ex-min in Andhra

The Enforcement Directorate on Sunday arrested former minister Kamururi Nagavenu Reddy in a money laundering case linked to alleged irregularities in transport of liquor during the previous YSRCP government in Andhra Pradesh, officials said. The probe pertains to an allegation that the accused caused the government to exchequer a loss of Rs 195.33 crore through irregularities. Former state beverages corporation managing director Dhanthreddy Vasudeva Reddy and Kasireddy Raja Sekhar Reddy were also arrested. PTI

Daughter of Rohit Pawar's PA found dead in Baramati

Express News Service
Pune, August 23

THE DAUGHTER OF NCP (SP) MLA Rohit Pawar's personal assistant — 14-year-old Avani Dashavtare — was found dead in a village in Baramati on Sunday morning, in a suspected case of suicide, Pune Rural Police said.

Avani had left her home Saturday night following an argument with her family after which she was reported missing, officials said.

Pune Rural police said the incident was reported from Sai Ganesh Nagar area in Rui village in Baramati taluka, which is around five kilometres from Baramati City in Pune district. Police said Avani was a student of Class 9 at a school in Baramati.

"Initial probe suggests that after an argument with her family members on Saturday night, Avani left her home. Late in the night, a missing person's case was registered at Baramati Taluka police station. Avani's body was found next to a building Sunday morning. The body was sent for post mortem," said an officer from Pune Rural police.

"After the incident came to light, several teams launched an investigation. CCTV cameras in the area were checked. We are in the process of reconstructing her movements from the time she left home until her body was found. CCTV footage showed her walking to a building near her house and then getting into the lift of this five storey building. We found her footwear on the terrace of the building. The post mortem's initial findings show injuries consistent with a fall from a height. There were no other signs of struggle on the terrace. All these leads point to a case of suicide," the officer said.

The police have registered an accidental death report, which is a preliminary registration for any "unnatural death". Speaking to the media in Baramati, Rohit Pawar said, "A very unfortunate incident has occurred involving the death of the daughter of my PA, Ajit Dashavtare, who has been associated with me since my tenure at the Zilla Parishad. The exact sequence of events, the circumstances leading to her death and what exactly happened will become clear only after the police investigation. This is an extremely difficult and painful time for Ajit and his family."

EXPRESS special

Sealed for 70 years, what BHU found inside 22 boxes from a Varanasi dig

Findings help researchers trace development of human settlement at Rajghat

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, August 23

FOR NEARLY 70 years, 22 boxes containing material excavated from one of Varanasi's most important archaeological sites lay unopened at Banaras Hindu University (BHU).

When the university finally opened them on August 20, it found more than 10,000 artefacts — including painted black pottery believed to be nearly 3,000 years old — along with thousands of photographs documenting archaeological sites and sculptures across India.

These were excavated from Rajghat in 1957, documented, and handed over to the museum of BHU's Department of Ancient Indian History, Culture and Archaeology (AIHC).

According to Professor Mahesh Prasad Ahirwar, head of the department, the boxes contain sculptures, ancient coins, tools, stamp seals and objects made of copper, ivory and bone. He said three specialised research teams have been formed to conserve and document the material.

Among the finds are several seals bearing inscriptions, including some written in the Brahmi script, Professor Ahirwar said.

He said researchers specialising in epigraphy at BHU will study them, while experts from other universities may be consulted where specialised expertise is required.

This, the professor said, can help researchers understand the scripts, systems of governance, trade and economic systems of the periods in which they were used.

The boxes contain other important discovery: around 3,000 glass slides and more than 5,000 photographic negatives documenting archaeological sites across India — Rajghat, Manjhi, Ratnagiri, Ajanta and Ellora.

The photographs offer a record of these sites before decades of weathering, restoration and modern development changed some of them. They also include rare images of idols of Lord Vishnu, Shiva and Buddha. These are being examined and will be restored as part of the department's conservation work.

Ahirwar said the trunks were found in an advanced state of deterioration, making the recovery and preservation of the material inside particularly significant.

BHU Vice-Chancellor Professor Ajit Kumar Chaturvedi said in a statement that "these boxes contain artefacts and ob-



(From left): Photographs of the Rajghat excavation site near Varanasi; utensils, and a jar from the Gupta period that were found in the boxes. BHU

jects that carry significant historical and heritage value... They were excavated at a time when advanced scientific techniques for archaeological research were not available in India."

He said scholars and excavators in the Department of Archaeology understood the "potential of this archaeological treasure and preserved these materials for future research."

He further stated, "The Department of AIHC has now taken the initiative to undertake advanced research on its archaeological collections, creating new opportunities for scholars to reassess historical chronologies and uncover new insights into ancient Indian civilisation. The opening of these boxes is an important part of this endeavour."

Rajghat, located on the north-eastern edge of Varanasi near the confluence of the Ganga and Varuna rivers, is one of the most important archaeological sites in the middle Ganga Valley.

According to Dr Subhash Chandra Yadav, Regional Ar-

chaeological Officer with the Uttar Pradesh State Archaeology Department, the area was part of ancient Varanasi, which served as the capital of the Kashi kingdom, also known as the Kashi Mahajanpada.

"Rajghat was an important settlement in the ancient Varanasi region. During excavations, seals and sealings bearing the name 'Varanasi' were found. These findings helped establish the site's connection with ancient Varanasi," he said.

He said the first archaeological remains at the site were discovered in 1939 during the expansion of the Kashi railway station and were subsequently sent to the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) for examination.

Excavations were carried out jointly by the ASI and BHU between 1957 and 1969, under the supervision of BHU Professor A K Narain and archaeologist T N Roy.

The excavations unearthed remains of ancient settlements, including structures believed to be houses, terracotta objects, seals and several

other artefacts. These findings helped researchers trace the development of human settlement at Rajghat over several centuries. Archaeologists have divided the history of the site into six cultural periods, beginning around 800 BC and continuing up to the medieval period.

Professor Narain had documented the excavations in four volumes, but a large part of the material recovered was not studied in detail.

The reopening of the 22 boxes comes weeks after another piece of Rajghat's archaeological record was brought out after decades.

Last month, experts opened a box containing a human skeleton recovered from the same site and which had remained sealed for around 70 years.

A team specialising in ancient DNA collected samples from the skeleton for genetic and bio-archaeological analysis.

Experts hope the analysis will provide clues about the people who lived in Varanasi around 1,000 years ago.

Excavations were carried out jointly by the ASI and BHU between 1957 and 1969, under the supervision of BHU Professor A K Narain and archaeologist T N Roy.

The excavations unearthed remains of ancient settlements, including structures believed to be houses, terracotta objects, seals and several

other artefacts. These findings helped researchers trace the development of human settlement at Rajghat over several centuries. Archaeologists have divided the history of the site into six cultural periods, beginning around 800 BC and continuing up to the medieval period.

Professor Narain had documented the excavations in four volumes, but a large part of the material recovered was not studied in detail.

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• ACCLAIMED DIRECTOR GURVINDER SINGH'S *REHMAT* ALSO HAS NASEERUDDIN SHAH IN THE CAST

At 60, Punjab Languages Dept Director makes debut, film premieres at Locarno

Divya Goyal Gopal
Ludhiana, August 23

ALONGSIDE NASEERUDDIN Shah and rising face Suvindev Vicky, National Award-winning director Gurminder Singh's latest film in Punjab has a debutant: Jaswant Singh Zafar, 60, the Director of the Punjab government's Languages Department, and a poet-writer.

Zafar, who retired as Deputy Chief Engineer in the Ludhiana Power Department in 2013, has held the post in the Languages Department for the past two years. Titled *Rehmat*, meaning compassion or God's blessing, Gurminder Singh's latest film delves into the past 100 years

of Punjab but with a strong reminder of its present. Earlier this month, it had its world debut at Locarno Film Festival, Switzerland, and was selected to compete for its highest honour, Pardo d'Oro or Golden Leopard award.

"Since the film was shot in Ludhiana's Kila Raipur and Gujjarwal villages, I spared weekends to shoot," says Zafar, an author of 12 books, who is based in Ludhiana but travels to Patiala for work.

Gurminder says he chose Kila Raipur and Gujjarwal as these villages still have some pre-Partition structures, along with symbols of modern life. "Spaces play an important part in a nar-

native. Every wall, window or a road, they matter," he says.

On choosing Zafar, Gurminder says: "I never saw him as a debutant or Naseer as a veteran... Naseer agreed even before reading the script. It's not just his skill but intellect that mattered for a role full of depth."

Rehmat is based on three short stories of Punjabi writer Ajeet Cour, 91, a Partition survivor. Gurminder, whose grandparents migrated from Lahore, says he felt an "instant affinity" with Cour.

The underlying message of the film, says Gurminder, is the compassion of Punjab and Punjabiyat — where none, a suspected militant to a Parti-



Jaswant Singh Zafar with Naseeruddin Shah. *Rehmat* is based on short stories of Punjabi writer Ajeet Cour, a Partition survivor. EXPRESS

tion survivor, is turned away, despite the deep trauma that the region has seen. It also deals with Punjab's recent crises, be it drugs, agriculture, unemployment or the migration of its youths abroad.

"Cinema has to ask questions, not give answers. A film should surprise even the filmmaker, not just the audience... With *Rehmat*, we have tried to walk Punjab's past 100 years, but in hand with its present," says Gurminder.

Happy about *Rehmat*'s reception abroad, Gurminder says he is, however, dispirited by the "lack of support" at home, from the Punjab film industry, government and authorities.

"This is likely my final work on Punjab... It feels like closure," says Gurminder, who won National Awards for both his 2011 directorial debut *Anne Ghore De Daan* (on oppression of Dalit labourers) and the 2015 *Chauthi Koot* (set during the militancy).

Rehmat is produced by Ajeet Cour's daughter Arpana Cour, and an independent French production company, Rev Films, that focuses on Indian cinema.

While he regrets that the Punjab film industry does not have an ecosystem that encourages "thoughtful Punjabi films", Gurminder, who has been based in Mohali since

2019, says he is more disappointed by the state government's "failure" to support such cinema. "Punjab doesn't even have a film policy. Even Haryana, Chhattisgarh have one. There is no film industry, no film festivals or any grants, nothing..."

Amit Dhaka, CEO Invest Punjab, Department of Industries and Commerce, told *The Indian Express* they have taken measures to boost this. "In March this year, we announced the Punjab Film Promotion Policy. Filmmakers can apply on our portal for shooting clearances and subsidies. We are trying to sensitize filmmakers about it."

EXPRESS special

Why 20 units threatened to move out of an auto hub near Pune, put govt on watch

Manoj More & Shubham Kurala
Chakan (Pune), August 23

AN AUGUST 31 deadline to fill potholes; a one-month deadline to clear roadside encroachments; a 10-month timeline to improve infrastructure and waste collection; 100 private security personnel to manage traffic; and long-term plans for a truck terminal, power sub-stations, and a well-equipped hospital.

The Maharashtra government is scrambling to put its vaunted "automobile hub", the Chakan MIDC (Maharashtra Industrial Development Corporation) in Pune district, in shape after an ultimatum by 20 industrial units to relocate elsewhere over their long-pending demand for basic amenities and infrastructure, while alleging "continued neglect" by the powers that be. The Chakan MIDC, part of the larger Pune-Chakan-Talegaon industrial belt, came up in 1985, with the government offering tax incentives and a 50% subsidy on investment to units who moved to the area.

While automobile giant Bajaj Auto was the first major industrial unit to come up in Chakan, followed by hundreds of ancillary units, at least 10-15 large firms have units here spread over a 4,000-hectare area now, including Bajaj Auto, Hyundai, Mercedes-Benz, Skoda, Mahindra and Volkswagen. Over 10 lakh workers are employed in these units. This monsoon, visitors to Chakan were greeted by potholes and craters across both

Set up in 1995, with a workforce of 10 lakh plus, Chakan MIDC area is fighting power, water, traffic, even waste issues



Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis has admitted that a severe infrastructure gap exists in the Chakan MIDC area. MANOJ MORE

the key roads leading to the MIDC area, as well as the arterial stretches. Traffic jams extended to kilometres, while waste lay rotting on the sides of roads, along with heavy vehicles, with few dedicated parking spaces.

Residents such as Santosh Yelwande, of Kharwad in Chakan, and Rupesh Jadhav of Nanekarwadi, talk of the situation worsening every monsoon. "A stretch that used to take us 20-25 minutes now takes two-three hours," says Jadhav.

Pointing out the jobs provided by Chakan's units and the revenue generated to the tune

of "Rs 6 lakh crore annually", Chakan Industrial Association president Shantanu Kulkarni says, "We contribute estimated Rs 1 lakh crore in GST per year, besides about Rs 13,000 crore in income tax annually. The SME turnover, from the share of total revenue, stands at Rs 2 lakh crore... Despite this, does Chakan matter or not? For years, it hasn't seemed so."

He talks of daily power cuts running "over four hours" hitting operating costs and delaying deliveries, and a mismatch in road planning. "An MIDC road that is 70 metres wide in

some stretches connects to an approach road just 8 metres wide, making commuting nearly impossible for the area's large workforce."

Dhananjay Shedbale, owner of Deeksha Export Pvt Ltd, which has been operating in Chakan for 19 years and was among the 20 units that threatened to move out, says: "We get water for just over one hour. Sometimes there is no supply, without any notice... Several companies depend on tankers and end up halting water-intensive production."

MIDC Executive Engineer Prakash Bhargade denies any water shortage. "We supply 30 MLD (million litres daily) water to Chakan MIDC. And this is sufficient," Bhargade insists.

On power cuts, Shedbale says, "Be it operation, maintenance or distribution, there is a problem on every front... The power system badly needs an upgrade."

Executive Engineer Sandhya Banerikar admits that the current installed capacity "falls short of expectations of industrialists". "Two new substations and as many additional transformers are planned to increase the capacity." The decision to want the government that they may relocate was not taken lightly, Shedbale says. "For over 14 months, we have been approaching several authorities, from the CM to Pune's Divisional Commissioner Office, with little response."

The ultimatum by Chakan firms was cited by the Opposition as evidence of the Maharashtra government's failures.

NCP (SP) national chief Sharad Pawar urged the state government to act immediately to "protect Maharashtra's industrial strength". "We have always been an industry-friendly state," Shiv Sena (UBT) spokesperson Sanjay Raut accused the Fadnis government of "failing" industrialists. "The Mahayuti government simply does not care for industries. It just wants to milk them," he said.

After CM Devendra Fadnis admitted "a severe infrastructure gap", Industries Minister Uday Samant visited the MIDC area on August 16. Soon after, the government announced a 14-member panel to tackle Chakan's issues, headed by the Pune District Collector as chairman and the Pimpri-Chinchwad Police Commissioner as co-chairman. On visit to Pune, Fadnis said that apart from fixing immediate issues, his government was working out a long-term plan to convert MIDC areas into full-fledged industrial townships.

Pune District Collector Jitendra Dudi said steps to improve facilities like roads, waste collection, power and water were on their way. "Only 10% of the Chakan MIDC area has streetlights. Besides, most roads have encroachments... Henceforth, things will be drastically improved." It was "poor coordination" between government agencies — from MIDC, road and water authorities, to municipal and panchayat bodies — that had hit Chakan's plans. "We take the blame upon ourselves..."

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

'Bihar has crossed phase of badlands... set to exceed target of Rs 5 lakh crore investment'

WITH THREE months to go before the November deadline to realise the Bihar government's investment goal of Rs 5 lakh crore, Industries Minister and Janmukh BJP MLA Shreyasi Singh said the state is on course to exceed the target. In an interview with **Santosh Singh**, Singh speaks about reducing bureaucratic red tape, ease of doing business, financial constraints and investors' inhibitions. Excerpts:



EXPRESS interview

SHREYASI SINGH
BIHAR INDUSTRIES MINISTER

With Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary setting a target of Rs 5 lakh crore in investments by this November, what steps has your department taken to fulfil this goal?

It is more a matter of being equal to the task than viewing it strictly as a challenge. While industry is the nodal sector, other key departments — such as renewable energy, food processing, health, education, social welfare and tourism — are also driving substantial investments. Although compiling divergent data across departments is complex, the overwhelming response from investors suggests we may even exceed the target, with capital flowing swiftly into both the private and public sectors.

The CM will reveal the final figures during Bihar Business Connect, tentatively scheduled for November. Broadly speaking, we are working across three themes: moving from control to facilitation (a governance shift); one family, one entrepreneur (a grassroots commitment); and an industrial area in every district (the infrastructure promise).

Has it been difficult to convince investors and get them to give up their inhibitions about Bihar?

It is true that Bihar has been treated as "badlands", more so during the 1990s. The state crossed that phase and made rapid progress during former CM Nitish Kumar's tenure. During my interactions with prospective investors in Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru or anywhere in the country, I tell them about Bihar's vast untapped potential, mainly in food processing, tourism and hospitality. Second, I assure them that there would be no bureaucratic hurdles.

Given the state's financial situation, how are you readying the land bank that requires a lot of money?

It is true that we have to purchase land from individual farmers, who are paid four times the circle rates in most instances. We have been flowing funds from the Centre by way of our share in Central taxes. The CM has reiterated there is no fund

shortage. We are also taking a Rs 25,000-crore loan to build infrastructure on acquired land to attract investment.

The general criticism of Bihar has been that the state does not have the required sources of raw materials to attract industry.

Industry and investment profile has changed over the years. We have received good investments in steel, cement and food processing sectors. There is immense potential in the electronics and IT sectors. But the real revelation has been garments and leather for Bihar.

Which sectors attract the most interest? How has investment grown over the last decade?

We have received significant investment in the renewable energy, steel, garment, food processing and leather sectors. It is deeply encouraging that we have begun exporting leather goods, makhanas, and garments to international markets. As per the state Department of Industries records, the State Investment Promotion Board (SIPB) report indicates that by September 2025, we had received proposed investments totalling Rs 1.1 lakh crore, including Rs 38,644 crore in renewable energy, Rs 30,748 crore (ethanol), and Rs 20,153 crore (food processing). However, the latest figures being compiled, are substantially higher. Between 2016 and 2022, it realised barely Rs 2,500 crore in investments.

There has been significant buzz around Jamui, once selected by MoEF activity, hosting Asia's largest ethanol plant.

It is poetic justice — for Jamui and Bihar. Ankur Biochem is establishing Asia's largest ethanol plant across 3,000 acres at Chakai, Jamui. It will produce 75 lakh litres of ethanol daily, requiring around 3,000 tons of broken rice and maize per day. Ethanol production is set to be one of Bihar's primary investment drivers, with the

state already hosting around a dozen plants that are either operational or under construction.

What is the state's plug-and-play policy?

Under the plug-and-play model, we lease ready-to-work sheds directly to investors. So far, we have leased out around 31 lakh square feet of space to garment, leather, electronics, food processing, and IT startups in Muzaffarpur, West Champaran, Patna, Madhubani, and Bhagalpur. We are expanding our land bank in every district. Through our ease of doing business framework, we established a single-window clearance system that processes all required approvals within 30 days.

CM Choudhary has reiterated that any proposal not explicitly addressed within 30 days stands automatically cleared. This policy has helped us cut through bureaucratic red tape, making it far easier to convince prospective investors.

What are some of the major business houses entering Bihar?

Alongside Ambani and Adani groups, major names working with us include Shyam Steel, Ankor Steel, Pearl Global, Global Renewable Advanced Clean Energy, Creative Group, Anubhav Apparels, Bharat Science and Innovation, Nirami Sugars, EPIC Agro, UltraTech Cement, Volt Solar, SLMG Beverages, Haldiram's and Mother Dairy. Notably, India's largest bag manufacturing unit is operational at Bela, Muzaffarpur.

How challenging is land acquisition, given that it is often cited as a major bottleneck for investment?

We dispelled that misconception long ago. Land acquisition for 14,600 acres is actively underway, with each district task force assigned specific targets. We will utilise 2,247 acres of Bettiah Raj forest land currently under state government control. Our plan to develop 12 satellite towns will drive a fresh wave of investment.

Patna HC sets 45-day deadline for disposing of 2nd appeal under RTI

Santosh Singh
Patna, August 23

STATING THAT a person seeking information should not be left "remediless", the Patna High Court has ruled that second appeals filed under the Right to Information (RTI) law must be decided within 30 days, extendable to a maximum of 45 days.

The order is significant because while the RTI Act, 2005, has a 45-day deadline for disposing of the first appeal, there is no such timeline for the second appeals. The court held that state authorities can't refuse information by citing missing, untrace-

able, or damaged public records. Justice Raj Kumar delivered the verdict on August 11 — the order was uploaded two days ago — in a 17-year-old Civil Writ Jurisdiction Case. Petitioner Md Rizwan had filed an RTI application in 2009, seeking certified copies of *barwada* (yearly rent payment document) and Register-II records from the Circle Office, Siwan Sadar, for a pending title suit.

The Public Information Officer-cum-Circle Officer turned down the request, citing contradictory reasons. After the petitioner filed a second appeal before the Bihar

State Information Commission on May 18, 2010, the matter languished for over a year before being disposed of on January 6, 2012. The petitioner then moved the HC.

While hearing the case, Justice Kumar addressed the absence of an explicit timeline for second appeals under Section 19(3) of the RTI Act. The court said: "This Court is of the view that second appeal must be decided within a period of 30 days or within such period not exceeding 45 days as decided through various judgments... so that the person seeking information is not left remediless."

Thane doctor 'attacked', son of patient booked

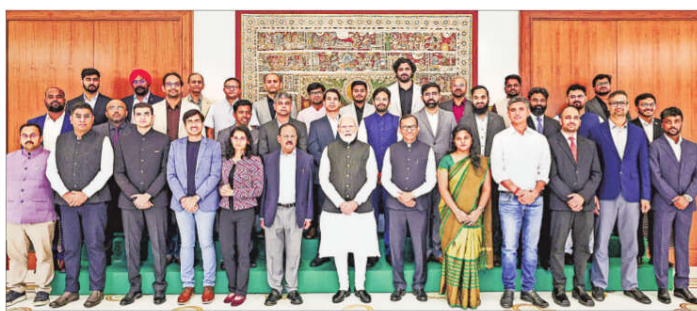
Purnima Sah
Mumbai, August 23

WEEKS AFTER an assault on doctors and nurses at a Dombivli civil hospital triggered state-wide protests by the medical fraternity, another doctor has allegedly been attacked at a private hospital in Kalyan East, Thane district, after an argument with a patient's son over treatment.

The Kolsawadi police has registered an FIR against Vinay Jaywant Deshmukh for allegedly assaulting Dr Yogendra Jaiswal, a 41-year-old orthopaedic consultant at Bhanujot Hospital, late Saturday night. As per Jaiswal's complaint, the patient, Jaywant Deshmukh, aged around 60-70, arrived with his son at around 10:45-11 pm with complaints of lower-back pain.

Jaiswal examined him, prescribed medicines and explained the dosage, dietary precautions and duration for which a bandage or support was to be used. "The doctor told him to use proper words while speaking to him. Following this, the relative became aggressive and assaulted the doctor," said Dr Jatin Harbada, Bhanujot Hospital owner and a consultant physician.

The patient's son allegedly punched Jaiswal twice in the face and struck him on other parts of the body before holding him by the neck. The alleged incident was captured on CCTV.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi and NSA Ajit Doval met CEOs and founders of space start-ups in New Delhi, Friday. ANI

Our private space ecosystem can become major force for India and the world, PM tells start-ups

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 23

LAUDING THEM for showing the courage to take up challenges in a new realm, Prime Minister Narendra Modi told a group of space entrepreneurs that they could become the strongest magnet for attracting global scientific and technological talent to India.

Ahead of the National Space Day on Sunday — the third anniversary of Chandrayaan-3 landing on the Moon in 2023 — Modi met founders and CEOs of over 20 space start-ups and, congratulated them for the successes they have had so far. "You have shown tremendous courage. It is great to see India's youth working in areas like this. It was difficult to imagine just a few years ago. Now, you can become the magnet that attracts a global talent pool in science and

technology to India... Our private space ecosystem can become a major force for India and for the world," Modi told the young entrepreneurs, according to transcripts and videos of the meeting released on Sunday.

"People working in this field anywhere in the world should think that if they have to make a career, and do something great, they should go to India, get connected to India's space ecosystem, start working with one of your companies. Believe very strongly that because of you we can attract a global talent pool to India. And that can become a strength for India," he said. India has opened up its space sector for domestic private players, offering favourable policies and incentives for companies wanting to work in this area. Over 400 space start-ups — like Agnikul, Skyroot and GalaxEye — have come up in the last few years.

GalaxEye co-founder Pranit Mehta told the Prime Minister that many Indians working in other countries were showing interest in coming back.

Antarbhish Parichha and Monika Ekal of the Bhubaneswar-based company Serendipity Space met Modi for the first time. Their start-up recently tested a satellite that can work as a space-based manufacturing facility for certain drugs. "It was a great opportunity for us to tell the Prime Minister about the work we are doing. He is extremely enthusiastic about the space sector, and very sharp in grasping things. He could immediately connect the technologies being built to the real value created on the ground for the people — which is the ultimate measure of the work we are trying to do," Parichha said.

"He (Modi) wanted to know the interest of pharmaceutical

companies in India in trying out the facility being created by Serendipity Space, and asked us about our plans to scale up. I think this meeting was very important for mature and emerging space start-ups... It was a huge boost for our morale," he said.

Modi promised the young entrepreneurs the government's support and a stable space policy. "I have always been of the opinion that whatever decision we take, we should be consistent with our policy. And I am happy that you have reposed trust in our effort. You are taking immense risks. It is possible that you would sometimes stumble, but you should have the confidence that you will continue to have government support," he said. Modi encouraged the space start-ups to explore new applications of their technologies and focus on how these can make people's lives easier.

E. EXPLAINED

Global South in focus

Besides strengthening ties between Liberia and India under the framework of South-South cooperation, the visit also comes at a time when India is pitching itself as the voice of Global South. Liberia has also supported India's bid for a non-permanent seat at the UN Security Council.



Delegation from Liberia visiting India for the IBISA funded peer-learning programme. XI GORISHANKAR

tion identified digital inclusion as a priority area for legislative attention and advocacy in Lib-

eria. The One Stop Centre model, under Mission Shakti (under Ministry of Women and

Child Development) offered learning for strengthening co-ordinated, survivor-centred

services in Liberia, they said.

Talking to *The Indian Express* during the visit, AH Monjurul Kabir, UN Women Country Representative, Liberia, said, "South-South cooperation works because countries learn from what others have actually built, through their own private and experiences."

He further said that the delegates engaged directly with India's experience in women-led development, political leadership, gender-responsive budgeting, economic empowerment, digitalisation and institutional responses to violence against women.

This knowledge-based mission has provided Liberian lawmakers with insights for

their legislative, oversight and advocacy roles, he added.

One of the delegates pointed out that India's vision of women-led development, where women shape development as leaders, entrepreneurs and decision-makers rather than passive recipients of support, gave Liberian legislators a powerful lens for their work on women's empowerment and gender-responsive governance.

Another, Francis Saidy Dophin II, a senator representing River Gee County, said, "We saw how digital systems, public services and protection for women can be connected. The lesson for Liberia is that policy must be supported by systems that people can actually access."

The delegation to India was facilitated by UN Women Liberia in partnership with the Women Legislative Caucus of Liberia, under the project "Women Legislators in Liberia: Promoting Voice, Leadership and Gender-Responsive Governance for Sustainable Development". The study is funded by the India, Brazil and South Africa (IBSA) Fund through the UN Office for South-South Cooperation.

In 2007, India deployed the first-ever all-female police unit in Liberia, which served till 2016. Besides making a mark for their professionalism and courage, they also inspired many young women in Liberia to get into uniformed services.

Liberia to take a leaf out of India's playbook on engaging, empowering women

Divya A
New Delhi, August 23

LAST WEEK, a delegation from Liberia arrived in New Delhi to glean a first-hand understanding of the political participation of women in India.

The first such interaction of the kind between the two countries comes on the back of a series of developments in the country that further facilitates women's involvement, namely the Women's Reservation Bill, gender-focused budgetary allowances, and women-led development.

During their five-day visit, the group that comprises 12 lawmakers met External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, Women

and Child Development Anna-purna Devi, representatives from Digital India, Delhi Metro, and even undertook a field visit to a government-run One Stop Centre, which offers shelter to women affected by violence.

Following his meeting with the delegation, Jaishankar said he "exchanged views on development programmes, sharing the experiences of Jan Dhan Yojana, Mudra Yojana, SVA-Nidhi, Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana, Jal Jeevan Mission, Beti Bachao Beti Padhao, and Mission Amrit Sarovar", adding that he "appreciated their interest and reaffirmed India's commitment towards deeper Global South partnership".

As per officials, the delega-



If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• ENVIRONMENT

Importance of elephant corridors in reducing conflict

Nikhil Ghanekar

New Delhi, August 23

A SUPREME COURT Bench led by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant last week directed the Centre to conduct a fresh survey of elephant corridors. It said these corridors cannot be blocked fearing crop damage as elephant herds, by nature, travel long distances.

The Bench was hearing a writ petition on managing human-elephant conflict. The petition, in the past, had sought to prevent the use of firebills, spikes and other such materials to drive away elephants. In its order, the Bench asked the Centre to indicate steps taken to prohibit the use of such methods or any other "coercive measure" to divert the natural movement of elephants.

Moving long distances

Asian elephants are highly mobile and social mammals. A male elephant's average home range — the area it typically uses for food, water and shelter — extends between 50 and 300 sq km. Elephants can move through their range in herds or individually. These home ranges can also extend depending on habitat type, food availability, water sources, population density and human disturbances.

Elephant corridors, or movement pathways connecting two natural habitats, are crucial to facilitating elephant movement. Disrupting them can not only spark human-elephant conflict but pose a threat to the animals. Elephant movements are strongly influenced by seasonal and spatial distribution of food, water and habitat, according to studies. For instance, seasonal migrations into Kerala are common during the dry months as elephants seek water and food in the relatively moist forests of the Western Ghats, said a recent Environment Ministry report.

Historically, climate change and drought, too, have played a role in forcing migration.

• 150 IN 15 STATES

Elephant corridors are movement pathways connecting two natural habitats. • The government's last major mapping exercise in 2023 documented 150 elephant corridors across 15 states.

Fragmented corridors

The directions given by the court panning to blocking or obstruction of elephant corridors passing through different states, and the related issues of human-elephant conflict it creates.

The major issues in recent disruptions of corridors are infrastructure construction, and industrial and mining activity. Highways, existing and new railway lines, canals and power lines can push elephants towards farmlands and human settlements, triggering conflict.

India has four principal elephant population landscapes: the Western Ghats; North-Eastern Hills and Brahmaputra floodplains; Shivakuli Hills and Gangetic plains; and Central India and Eastern Ghats. The habitat of the Western Ghats population is rapidly getting fragmented owing to changing land use, plantations and farmland fencing. This was noted in the last all-India elephant population estimation report released last year. Similar disruptions were recorded in the Shivakuli and Brahmaputra plains.

The biggest challenge, however, lies in Central India and Eastern Ghats. Chhattisgarh has seen elephants arriving from Jharkhand and Odisha over two decades owing to habitat loss and mining pressures. Elephants have also expanded their range into parts of Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra.

Corridor mapping

Corridors allow elephants genetic exchange or dispersal, which helps in maintaining diversity in their population pool. Well-conserved corridors also provide them access to food and water in natural habitats during seasonal changes, preventing them from entering crop lands.

• GEOPOLITICS

5 years on, how India has warmed up to the Taliban



SHUBHAJIT ROY

THE AFGHANISTAN embassy in New Delhi celebrated "victory day" on August 15, marking the Taliban's takeover of the country five years ago. Much has changed in these five years when it comes to the Indian position on the Taliban dispensation.

On August 17, 2021, New Delhi had hurriedly evacuated its entire embassy from Kabul. Now, it is conducting business with the Islamist regime, albeit without granting it official diplomatic recognition.

The "victory day" celebration, attended by Indian diplomats and about two dozen foreign diplomats, was the latest sign that the India-Taliban relationship is now increasingly moving away from the shadows. While Indian officials have called this a case of "cautious engagement", others have criticised it as "opportunistic".

Why India is deepening ties

India has stepped up diplomatic exchanges with the hardline Islamist group. Taliban Foreign Minister Amir Khan Muttaqi made a high-profile visit to New Delhi in October 2025. The Afghan embassy has been under the control of the Taliban since around that time. And the Taliban-appointed Charge d'affaires, Mufti Noor Ahmad Noor, has been part of multiple key events in Delhi — the Prime Minister's Independence Day address, the President's At Home reception, and even a diplomatic event at the Norwegian embassy. So, what's behind all this?

India invested for years in Afghanistan after the fall of the Taliban in 2001. In August 2021, the Ashraf Ghani-led government collapsed — ahead of the August 31 deadline set by President Joe Biden for withdrawal of US troops from the country.

In the months and years since, the Indian government came to the conclusion that it was time to upgrade the level of engagement without giving official recognition — or watch its or watch its USD 2.3-billion investment go down the drain. That was the fear for the people of Afghanistan, and to create some kind of leverage and influence in the country.

• ACKNOWLEDGEMENT TO ENGAGEMENT

AUGUST 31, 2021: Hours after the last US military aircraft flies out of Kabul to mark the end of its 20-year war in Afghanistan, India makes its first official contact with the Taliban. Its ambassador to Qatar, Deepak Mittal, meets head of the Taliban political office in Doha, Sher Mohammad Abbas Stanekzai, at the embassy.



SEPTEMBER 2021: India recognises the Taliban as "those in positions of power and authority across Afghanistan", the first clear acknowledgement of the group as a state actor.

DECEMBER 2021: India sends its first consignment of medicines to Afghanistan under the new Taliban regime.

JANUARY 2025: Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri holds a substantive meeting with Muttaqi in Dubai.

JANUARY 2024: Muttaqi (pictured to the left) meets diplomats from 11 regional nations. India is among them.

LATE JUNE 2022: In an incremental step, the Indian government sends a 'technical team' to the embassy in Kabul to coordinate delivery of humanitarian aid.



MAY 2025: External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar speaks to Muttaqi on the phone on May 15, days after India and Pakistan agree to stop military strikes. The Taliban condemned the Pahalgam terror attack that had triggered the conflict.

APRIL 2025: India sends M Anand Prakash, Joint Secretary in charge of Pakistan, Afghanistan and Iran division in the Ministry of External Affairs, to Kabul.

OCTOBER 2025: Muttaqi makes a high-profile visit to India. The two sides decide to upgrade their mutual level of embassies, and appoint charge d'affaires.

A key factor has been the fact that the Taliban's once-benefactor and ally, Pakistan, has turned into a deadly adversary. Both sides have seen multiple clashes along their contested border. For New Delhi, this has been a window of opportunity.

Another factor hastening India's engagement is China. Beijing has started building bridges with and eyeing natural resources in Afghanistan — filling the vacuum left behind by the West. Russia, too, has been engaging with the Taliban, and is the only country to have established diplomatic ties with them. Delhi has been working with Moscow on Taliban to keep track of the Chinese influence.

New Delhi started sending signals back in December 2021, when it sent a consignment of medicines to Afghanistan. The government was choosing to distinguish the Taliban regime from the Afghan people.

The security concerns

New Delhi has operated on the simple principle that Afghanistan's territory

Eroding rights

Since taking control, the Taliban has been eroding the rights of Afghanistan's 22 million women.

It barred access to school for girls over 12, curbed travel without a male chaperone and brought a law implying legal approval for child marriage.

should not be used for anti-India activities and support for terrorist groups.

An August 10 report by the UN Security Council's 1267 sanctions committee states: "The terrorist threat emanating from Afghanistan remained largely unchanged. The ability of numerous terrorist groups to operate in Afghanistan constituted an enduring threat to neighbouring countries and the Central Asian region. Despite efforts by the *de facto* authorities to combat Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan (ISIL-K) and contain other terrorist groups, the authorities were unable to suppress the terrorist problem." It also said that the Al-Qaeda's status and strength in Afghanistan remains unchanged.

New Delhi would be believed that the report contains no mention of anti-India terrorist groups, such as Lashkar-e-Taiba and Jaish-e-Mohammad, among others. But it is keeping its fingers crossed.

So far, New Delhi's engagement has been "limited" and the Taliban has indicated that it will be "reasonable" in the way it "handles"

• HEALTH

The personalised vaccine that could cut skin cancer death risk

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, August 23

A NEW personalised cancer vaccine, administered along with a popular immunotherapy drug Keytruda, has been shown to reduce the risk of death owing to recurrence and spread of skin cancer. Developed by pharmaceutical giant Merck and the mRNA vaccine company Moderna, Intismeran is the first such therapy to show meaningful clinical benefits.

"These Phase 3 findings represent a pivotal moment for the field of cancer research. For many years, the idea of creating an mRNA treatment designed specifically for an individual patient's cancer was aspirational," said Stéphane Bancel, CEO of Moderna, in a press release.

How does intismeran work?

The therapy is designed by identifying the mutations — called neoantigens — in a patient's tumour sample. Neoantigens are essentially proteins found only on the cancerous cells, which the body's immune system can be trained to recognise. These

neoantigens vary from person to person, meaning they become an identifier for the cancer, and also establish the need for personalised vaccines.

mRNA, or messenger RNA, is a single-stranded molecule that carries genetic instructions from DNA in the cell nucleus, telling the cell which proteins to make. The vaccine consists of synthetically developed mRNA that encodes for these proteins. Each treatment consists of mRNA coding for 34 such neoantigens. Once administered, the body generates these proteins and presents them to the immune system.

The idea behind the therapy is the same as any other vaccine: teach the immune system to recognise the cancer's fingerprint so that it can mount an effective response whenever it spots these mutated cells.

"Just as a vaccine for an infectious disease contains the antigen from a pathogen — the proteins or lipids that trains the body's immune system to recognise and fight off the pathogen — therapies such as this contain cancer neoantigens. While people have been working on this for a decade or so, this is the first clinical break-

Cancer identifiers

Neoantigens are essentially proteins that are found only on the cancerous cells, which the body's immune system can be trained to recognise.

These neoantigens vary from person to person, meaning they become an identifier for their cancer but also necessitating personalised vaccines.

through," Dr Gaurav Kharya, haematologist and co-founder of a startup developing blood cancer treatment Cellogen, told *The Indian Express*.

"The benefit is that this fingerprint of the cancer goes into the immune system's memory. So, if the cancer comes back, the body's immune system can immediately recognise it and mount a response, prolonging recurrence-free survival," he added.

What did the study find?

The study found that when the vaccine was given with the popular immunotherapy drug Keytruda, the risk of death owing to recurrence of skin cancer went down by 49% — and the risk of death owing to its spreading went down by 59%.

The results are in comparison with only Keytruda being used for treatment. Keytruda in itself has over the years shown to be much more effective in treatment of certain cancers than traditional chemotherapy.

The most common side effects noted in the study were fatigue, injection site pain, and chills.

Is this significant for India?

For the current treatment, the impact would be limited, say oncologists. This is mainly because of two reasons:

One, the current trial result is only meant for skin cancer, or melanoma. "While melanoma is one of the most common types of cancer in the caucasian population, it is not commonly seen among Indians. Melanoma is, in fact, rare here," Dr Abhishek Shankar, oncologist at AIIMS-New Delhi, said. Globocan — a short for Global Cancer Observatory, an online platform that maintains cancer statistics — shows that melanoma accounts for only 0.26% of all cancer cases in India and 0.17% of deaths.

Two, the cost factor. Most patients in India are unable to afford Keytruda, even with patient assistance programmes. A real-world study from Tata Memorial Hospital had shown that only 1.6% of the patients who need such immunotherapy are able to access them. "Cost is a very significant factor in India. How can they afford the combination therapy when they cannot afford the immunotherapy itself?" said Shankar.

• ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

AI is transforming cyber attacks as well as defences: What this means for India



ANUBHA GUPTA

RESEARCH ASSOCIATE, ICWA

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE (AI) has

reached mass adoption faster than any prior technology — the Internet took 15 years to reach a billion users, while ChatGPT did so in three.

This rapid adoption has major consequences for cybersecurity. AI is enabling cyber threats at unprecedented speed, scale and sophistication across the cyber kill chain, from automated vulnerability discovery to AI-generated deepfakes and AI-enabled social engineering (using AI to trick/persuade people to take harmful actions). More significantly, AI is leveling

the ability to act as an autonomous agent that can identify, plan, adapt and carry out offensive cyber operations.

Thus, countries with leading AI ecosystems gain a greater ability both to conduct sophisticated cyber campaigns and to defend against them.

But AI capabilities remain concentrated in a few very countries. This raises pressing questions for India: how prepared is it to address AI-enabled cyber threats? What should India do to build the AI capabilities needed to secure its cyberspace?

Always lopsided

Cybersecurity was already lopsided, with a few countries holding far superior capabilities than the rest. Advances in frontier AI systems have pushed this further.

Reconnaissance, once the domain of humans gathering information about a target, is now automated and faster; research shows ChatGPT models being used to mine social media for precise details to craft AI-generated phishing emails. It is also generating real-time deepfakes, deepening confusion about what is authentic online.

More dangerous capabilities have emerged at the weaponisation and command-and-control stage. One novel method is LLM-generated polymorphic malware — code that large language models can autonomously generate, modify and restructure to suit the situation, unlike traditional malware, which relies on fixed signatures and predictable patterns. In September 2025, Anthropic claimed that Chinese state-sponsored group, GTG-1002, had allegedly used Claude Code as an autonomous cyber agent across multiple stages of an attack — what Anthropic called the first reported case of an AI-orchestrated cyber-espionage campaign.

Perhaps most consequential is the emerging ability of frontier AI models to autonomously identify software vulnerabilities at scale. Anthropic's latest frontier model, Claude-Medusa Pro, has identified thousands of zero-day vulnerabilities — flaws previously unknown to developers — across major operating systems

and browsers, many of them critical, and developed related exploits largely without human intervention. It found a 27-year-old vulnerability in OpenBSD, an operating system reputed to be highly security-hardened and widely used to run firewalls and critical infrastructure.

Such vulnerabilities are especially dangerous for the Operational Control Systems and Industrial Control Systems that govern nuclear facilities, energy grids, pharmaceutical manufacturing, chemical processing, oil refineries and communication networks — infrastructure that grows more exposed as it integrates further with AI.

Old cyber defences will not hold against these new threats. Traditional antivirus, which looks for known malware fingerprints, and static security patches for known vulnerabilities are far less effective against malware that constantly changes and adapts. AI in cybersecurity, by contrast, enables real-time threat detection, automated re-

sponse and large-scale data analysis, mitigating risks faster. The real AI divide, then, is not about who uses AI but who builds it, and who controls its development.

Questions for India

Last month, the ransomware group World Leaks claimed to have stolen and posted data related to India's largest nuclear plant, Kudankulam, including blueprints of facility parts and supplier details. Cyber intelligence firm CloudSEK's 2024 report placed India as the second-most cyber-attacked nation after the US; its 2025 report placed India sixth.

During Operation Sindoor, Pakistan-backed threat actors such as APT36 targeted India's critical sectors, including the Ministry of Defence, Army, Navy and DRDO, and for the first time, Bharat Operating System Solutions (BOSS) Linux.

Yet India's indigenous AI ecosystem remains incremental, lagging well behind the US and China across the AI stack — foundational models, GPUs, chip design and large-scale data-centre infrastructure — leaving it heavily dependent on the US and

other technologically advanced countries.

Efforts made

Indian policymakers are aware of these stakes and have begun taking steps. Agencies like CERT-In have, since 2025, adopted AI-driven threat detection, cyber resilience measures, trusted AI frameworks and citizen-centric malware mitigation. In April, it issued an advisory for organisations to defend against AI-driver cyber risks. Some of the recommendations were about "removing unnecessary internet-facing services" and treating every newly discovered vulnerability as something that "could be exploited within hours, not weeks."

At the governance level, the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology is exploring a consent-based framework for synthetically generated content, placing curbs on agentic AI autonomy and clearer liability frameworks for AI models.

India can't build the AI stack overnight, but AI and cybersecurity can no longer be treated in silos — they must be seen as interconnected strands of policymaking: AI for cyber defence, and cybersecurity for AI.

The Editorial Page

The Indian EXPRESS
—FOUNDED BY—
RAMNATH GOENKA
—IN 1932—

BECAUSE THE TRUTH
INVOLVES US ALL

To build Delhi's future, learn from past missteps

ABOUT 25 years ago, when Delhi's third Master Plan came into effect, the city's population was about 14 million. Gurugram and Noida were fledgling suburbs, the lines of the capital's Metro network were being laid, and a CNG policy for public transport was being introduced as a pollution-control measure. Since then, another 10 million people have made the capital their home, civic infrastructure of its neighbouring cities has come under acute stress, and the improvement in air quality that Delhi experienced for much of the 2000s and early 2010s has given way to an almost intractable pollution crisis. Delhi's fourth Master Plan, notified last week, acknowledges these challenges. Its emphasis on expanding public transport, ecological restoration, redevelopment, affordable housing and mixed land use is welcome.

One of the plan's strengths is its recognition that Delhi cannot be built simply by expanding outward. With limited land available within the National Capital Territory, better utilisation of existing urban land will become more important. The proposed increase in housing supply, including an ambition of roughly 40 lakh additional homes by 2047 at affordable rates, and greater flexibility in development norms to permit higher densities is, therefore, significant. The plan also recognises the futility of rigidly demarcating residential areas. If implemented well, these measures could ease the city's longstanding traffic congestion and improve air quality. Mixed land use, environment-friendly transport, the redevelopment and nurturing of green spaces, and greater attention to the city's water bodies could all contribute to improving Delhi's ecological health and enhance the well-being of its residents.

None of these ideas will succeed, however, without confronting the national capital's most persistent governance problems: Municipal inertia and a lack of alignment with state agencies, Centre and Delhi government. These deficits were the biggest bottleneck in realising the previous Master Plan's vision of a more sustainable city. Over the past 25 years, research on pollution, Yamuna restoration, waste management, urban flooding and transport development has pointed to the need for concerted action among departments. Metro expansion, for instance, works best when bus routes, last-mile connectivity, parking rules and pedestrian facilities are designed around it. Land-use planning and infrastructure development cannot be divorced from the requirements of curbing logging, while building approvals, fire safety and emergency response require effective information-sharing among construction, fire and municipal authorities. Repeated fire incidents, building collapses and the strain placed on the city's infrastructure during heavy rainfall have exposed the risks of fragmented and overlapping responsibilities among its agencies. Delhi has been failures for improving livability. It needs to learn from past blunders.

Israel's West Bank push imperils long-term peace

WHILE GLOBAL attention has been fixed on Gaza, Israeli settlers have been intensifying violence against Palestinians in West Bank — under Israel's occupation since 1967 — the larger of the two territories that constitute Palestine. A UN briefing to the Security Council on August 11 said that "the West Bank is at the breaking point", with 76 Palestinians killed in 2026 by Israeli forces or settlers. In the same period, UN data reveal that about 3,800 Palestinians, nearly half of them children, have been displaced by settler violence, demolitions and evictions. Settlement expansion is widely seen as a state project, as underlined by the Benjamin Netanyahu government's plans to open tenders for the construction of 1,200 settlement homes. Against this backdrop, the joint statement by the UK, France, Germany, Italy and Canada calling the tenders "unacceptable" and urging Israel to "retract the plans immediately" is welcome. Eight Muslim-majority nations, too, have criticised the plans; the US has expressed opposition but stopped short of condemnation.

Successive Israeli governments have facilitated the growth of settlements in West Bank, but this has accelerated since Netanyahu returned to power in 2022, backed by far-right parties championing the settler cause. Of course, Israel's security concerns are not to be dismissed, particularly after the October 7 terror attack by Hamas. But the EI project would not only exacerbate the displacement of Palestinians, it would also defeat the prospects of a contiguous and viable Palestinian state. All this is consistent, however, with the public posturing by Netanyahu and his allies. Less than a year ago, during a visit to a West Bank settlement, the Israeli PM said: "There will never be a Palestinian state. This place is ours." With elections looming and the tender deadline falling just a week before polling day in late October, the timing of EI may not be incidental.

The events in West Bank are part of a systematic effort to alter its demography and geography. Announcements such as last year's recognition of the State of Palestine by multiple Western countries look ineffectual unless backed by pressure on Israel. That the US, which has the greatest leverage, continues to grant Israel cover points to the difficulty of course correction or change.

FREEZE FRAME

BY EP UNNY



What young want, and why creating good jobs is no longer optional

WHAT ARE the hopes and desires of young job seekers in urban India? In the summer of 2023, armed with a long list of questions, we set out to survey over 3,000 randomly sampled men and women, 24 years of age on average, and living in the middle-class residential areas of Delhi. Our interest lay in understanding their journey towards employment — whether they were currently working or looking for work, or were planning to start their job search soon. The answers we got opened a window into the aspirations of this generation.

Almost 70 per cent of respondents — more men than women — told us they were looking for a job opportunity that would put them on their ideal career path from the start, instead of settling for just any job. Their career goal was predominantly being in salaried or formal-sector employment. More women job seekers aspired to these salaried positions, while only 14 per cent of the women we interviewed preferred being self-employed. In contrast, more than a third of men wanted to start their own enterprises. Contrary to the dominant narrative of strong preference for public-sector salaried jobs, a comparable share of these men and women were looking for private-sector salaried jobs.

Let's compare the above statistics with the occupational data from the PLFS in 2023. Less than 50 per cent of India's urban workforce is in salaried jobs, a figure that is even

lower for our age group of respondents — merely one in every three employed 24-year-olds holds a salaried job. No more than 10 per cent of our urban workforce is in the public sector or government jobs, and only about 10 per cent are in the formal private sector. Of those working, 40 per cent are self-employed but an overwhelming majority of these are subsistence businesses that do not hire any worker and have an annual turnover of less than Rs 10 lakh. So what are the odds of one of our job seekers landing her preferred salaried job or establishing a unicorn? Undoubtedly, the odds are stacked against these aspirational men and women.

But even if the probability of getting their preferred job is low, could they obtain a job, even if not ideal, that could give them salaries they aspire to? We asked respondents about their salary expectations from a range of jobs — accounts keeper, teacher in primary school, data entry operator, hospital attendant or electrician. We estimate the deviation of these salary expectations from the actual earnings for these jobs in urban India in the PLFS. Our job seekers expect up to 40 per cent higher salary than actual earnings reported in the PLFS for the same occupation. Male job seekers, in particular, show greater over-optimism in salary expectations relative to women, expecting almost Rs 8,000 more per month than the actual average earnings for these jobs and Rs 5,000 more per month for salaried jobs.



FARZANA AFRIDI

These men and women continue to aim for formal-sector jobs or to become dynamic entrepreneurs a year after, because aspirations are long-term goals and not easily malleable. Our job seekers are willing to bide their time

Altogether, salary expectations diverge from reality by more than 30 per cent. When we assess the job aspirations and expectations of job seekers who are below 25 years of age in our sample, we find that expectations are even more skewed — again, more so for young men than young women.

Are the youth in our cities simply out of touch with labour-market realities? There can be several reasons for these misalignments and high expectations — lack of information or misinformation and inexperience with the job market, to name a couple of obvious explanations. We tested one hypothesis — can information about real-world job opportunities and salaries correct these job-market misperceptions? So we set out to inform and expose a random subset of our 3,000 job seekers to the real world and re-surveyed both the informed and the non-informed a year later. Twelve months after receiving information, we find that providing accurate information about job opportunities significantly dampened job seekers' labour-market expectations of landing their ideal job relative to those who were not informed. Men, in particular, were less likely to report that they were on their ideal career path. This disillusionment is accompanied by a decline in men's job-search intensity. Thus, as preferred job offers fail to materialise, job seekers adjust their expectations downwards and either remain in the

same jobs or drop out of the labour market and enrol at educational institutions.

Not surprisingly, correct information seems to have made the job seekers realise that their expectations were too high. But did it also change the aspirations of these job seekers? The answer is a clear "no". Perhaps it is not surprising that the aspirations did not change. These men and women continue to aim for formal-sector jobs or to become dynamic entrepreneurs a year after, because aspirations are long-term goals and not easily malleable. Our job seekers are willing to bide their time. Add to these aspirations the rising cost of good-quality education — more likely to be accessed through private educational institutions — then their job-market expectations are not just aspirational but necessary to recover the high cost of education.

Policy makers must reckon with the fact that this generation is demanding good career opportunities — and that realising their aspirations will require nothing short of a structural transformation of the economy. The challenge of formalising our labour markets by creating jobs with regular pay and benefits is a first-order concern. While the new labour codes are a step in the right direction, creating "good" jobs and genuine career paths — not just jobs — is no longer optional. Failure to do so risks squandering the potential of an entire generation.

The writer is professor of Economics, ISI (Delhi), and visiting professor, NCAER

Investment question has a political answer



ISHAN BAKSHI

AT THE heart of India's on-going economic travails is the question: Why are the big cash-rich corporates not investing in the country? Why are companies taking money out of the country rather than investing it here? Why are animal spirits caged?

The government can claim, and perhaps rightly so, to have taken several steps to facilitate investments. Yet private corporate investments remain considerably lower than the peak seen in the mid 2000s. India Inc appears to be more keen to deploy its funds in financial assets rather than utilise them in building physical assets such as factories. Several explanations ranging from subdued domestic demand to global uncertainty have been put forth. But does the answer lie more in the realm of the political economy? Of how the political power structures in the country impact investments?

Centralisation of political power has been unmistakable post-2014. This has been accompanied by a push towards greater fiscal centralisation and reconfiguration of federal structures. Attempts to restrict the powers of states, and, as a consequence, regional parties, can, for instance, be seen in legislation such as the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026.

Growing political and fiscal centralisation has been accompanied by increasing market concentration with the rise of a handful of large companies, often referred to as national champions, who, aided by policy, now command far greater sway over the economy than ever before. These forces, operating in tandem, appear to have made the larger corporate sector reluctant to invest and emerge as competition to the big groups in the following manner.

One, the concentration of political power and the decline in the relative power of regional parties has meant that the patronage and protection that was afforded to the smaller and regional firms, who could rise up and become national players, has dried up. Two, policy uncertainty, raising the barriers to entry and an uneven playing field in favour of these larger corporates, has made it more difficult for new players to emerge. Companies, both domestic and foreign, are unlikely to invest if they fear that the

rules of the game can be arbitrarily changed, or that they can be caught on the wrong side of policies. Policy credibility matters.

And third, the fear of being muscled out by the national champions — that business success will be met by a hostile takeover. These risks seem to be deterring both domestic and foreign investors from committing to big investments in the country. It's not a question of being allowed to operate, but whether investors have the confidence of being able to stay in business and remain competitive over the next 10-20 years.

Accepting these arguments would imply that for the larger corporate sector to ramp up investments, for competition to emerge, the strategy of relying on a few national champions needs to be rethought. This could, however, have far-reaching political ramifications.

After all, the rise of a larger number of big private players would mean that economic power gets dispersed, not concentrated. That could, in turn, increase the funding avenues available for Opposition parties, which would possibly weaken the concentration of political power. Greater economic competition could then lead to greater political ramifications.

This raises the questions: Does the current political structure create the space for new players to safely invest and emerge as competitors to the national champions? Or, is market concentration politically useful?

All this means that even if the ingredients for an investment boom — an undervalued exchange rate, depressed real wages, and sustained public sector investment in infrastructure, all of which, along with the demographic dividend, powered the rise of countries like China and South Korea — are present, firms are likely to remain hesitant. They will remain unsure about investing, without a change in the approach. After all, investment decisions are taken only when investors think that they have a fair chance of benefiting.

The consequent absence of competition only raises the possibility of the emergence of an uncompetitive, high-cost economy.

The writer is senior associate editor, The Indian Express
ishan.bakshi@expressindia.com



BLJETRI PATHAK

A second rosogolla revolt, minus the placards

THERE'S AN odd question hidden in the current sugar crisis in India, one that's not strictly about sugar: What happens to a culture when one of its lower-cost languages of affection becomes a costly one? Domestic sugar prices have jumped nearly 40 per cent in two months. The government has responded the way governments do — waiving import duty, extending duty-free imports of up to 10 lakh tonnes of raw sugar until October 31, and warning bulk buyers against hoarding more than 15 days' stock ahead of the festival season. Ordinarily this is a business-page story that dies with the news cycle. But sugar isn't ordinary anywhere the way it is in Bengal.

Think about what a box of sweets means in a Bengali household. It appears for a new job, a good exam result, a wedding, a birth, a puja, even an election win. It's a language — a cheap one, which is why it's so universal. So when sugar gets more expensive, the damage isn't confined to the kitchen. Most people just see a rosogolla priced at Rs 15, 20, or 25 — not the chhana, fuel, labour, and rent stacked against that number. The shock moves through the chain, right as mithai shops gear up for their busiest months. This isn't really a story about commodities anymore — it's about class. Almost nobody worries whether Bengalis can still afford a rosogolla; most can. The real question is whether everyone can still take part, equally, in the rituals that hold Bengali life together. A few extra rupees mean nothing to a well-off family. For someone with less, it might mean fewer boxes ordered for a wedding, or a neighbour quietly left out this year. We generally track inequality through income, housing, and healthcare. We're much worse at noticing who can still show up, sweet box in hand, in moments meant to signal belonging. Call it cultural inflation, or a tax on participation rather than income.

Bengal has been here before. In August 1965, facing a milk shortage, the West Bengal government banned production of rosogolla and other chhana-based sweets in then Calcutta, reasoning that milk should go to children and nursing mothers instead. Protests erupted, a chhana black market sprang up, and sweet makers who'd spent years honing their craft were suddenly treated as offenders. The Calcutta High Court eventually struck the order down, but it remains a lesson in how badly governments can mishandle something people care about.

Bengal has also fought to claim this sweet, not just preserve it. After a two-and-a-half-year dispute with Odisha, West Bengal secured the Geographical Indication tag for "Banglar Rosogolla" in 2017, tracing it to a 19th-century Calcutta confectioner. Odisha won its own GI two years later.

Set the episodes aside by side: In 1965, Bengal resisted its own state to keep making rosogolla; in 2017, it fought a neighbour to keep claiming it. Now the threat is a market making the same sweet less accessible, with no one to blame and no one to protest against — a second Rosogolla Revolt, minus the placards. Easy to forget in all this: The mithai, squeezed between rising costs and price-conscious customers, perhaps not wanting the next generation to inherit a business where the numbers no longer work. Bengal won't stop eating sweets. But whether they're still made by hand, in small batches, the way Nobin Chandra Das perfected in 19th-century Calcutta, is another matter.

The writer is assistant professor, Sikkim Manipal University

40 YEARS AGO

August 24, 1986



Clash at phone exchange

TROOPS WIELDING machine guns and dressed in battle fatigues took control of Kidwai Bhavan. Women staff present in the building in the evening were ordered to work or get out of the building. As the women continued to protest in groups, policemen and officials ordered the women staff out. There were no women constables as the women were being pushed out. Several males among the staff were beaten up by policemen when they sat inside shouting slogans against P.C. Sethi, Congress MP who allegedly threatened and humiliated a woman telephone operator inside the exchange. One woman operator said she was hit by a policeman inside the building.

Public sector losses

THE PRIME Minister, Rajiv Gandhi, voiced concern over the money being lost in meeting public sector losses and said this was an issue that merited a national debate. Inaugurating the first Congress Seva Dal training camp for young parliamentarians in Nainital, the PM, however, said that the government did not want workers to lose their wages. "This is a very large issue," Gandhi told a gathering of about 300 parliamentarians, Seva Dal volunteers and Congress workers.

Blast in Baroda

THREE PERSONS were injured, two of them seriously, when a powerful blast

ripped apart the basement of the multi-storied Suraj Plaza extension building in the Savajji Gani area of Baroda at around 10.45 a.m. The three were rushed to the Savajji Gani Hospital. A hospital source said that two of them had suffered "60-80 per cent burns."

Attack on political leader

WEST BENGAL Pradesh Congress (I) President Priya Ranjan Das Munshi on Saturday narrowly escaped death when he was killed at his office on Haji Mohammad Mohsin Square in Central Calcutta. A violent mob stormed the office room when his personal security guard fired three rounds in the air to scare away the miscreants.

The Ideas Page

MONDAY, AUGUST 24, 2026

Measuring manufacturing growth afresh: Three questions



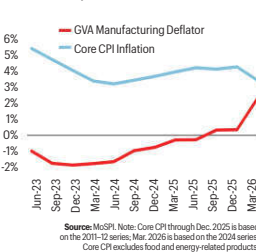
ABHISHEK ANAND,
JOSH FELMAN
AND ARVIND SUBRAMANIAN

THE CHINESE manufacturing export juggernaut once again moves menacingly across the world, threatening lower-skill manufacturing in poorer countries (the so-called China Squeeze). The government has set major ambitions for the manufacturing sector, starting with the flagship Make in India programme in 2014 and, following it up with the production-linked incentive (PLI) scheme several years later. The latter was, in part, a response to the opportunities opened up by the Chinese one but also to cope with the challenges of aggressive Chinese competition.

But answering the important question of how Indian manufacturing has performed in the wake of these developments and actions requires confidence in the underlying data. This is especially true now because the economy is sending conflicting signals and understanding the performance of the manufacturing sector may lift some of the confusion.

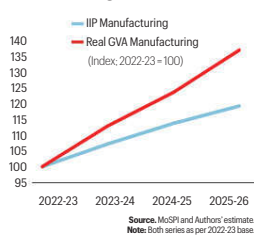
Problems in manufacturing sector data under the previous series were widely recognised and the Ministry of Statistics and Planning Implementation (MoSPI) made strenuous efforts to address them. When the new GDP series was announced, the Chief Economic Advisor and Secretary MoSPI stressed that the numbers were based on a new methodology, one that solved the measurement problems that had bedeviled the old series, including in manufacturing. Because MoSPI has not yet released the detailed standard document explaining the new calculations, we must examine the numbers themselves to assess their plausibility. When we do so, three questions arise about the manufacturing sector, the focus of much debate in the old series.

GVA Manufacturing Deflator and Core CPI Inflation, June 2023-March 2026



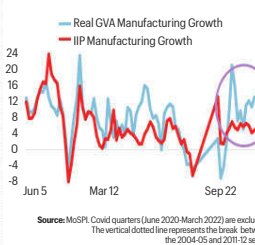
Source: MoSPI. Note: Core CPI through Dec. 2025 is based on the 2017-12 series. Mar. 2026 is based on the 2024 series. Core CPI excludes food and energy-related products.

Wedge Between IIP and real GVA in Manufacturing, FY2023-FY2026



Source: MoSPI and Authors' estimate. Note: Both series are per 2022-23 base.

Manufacturing Growth, IIP and real GVA, June 2005-March 2026



Source: MoSPI. Covid quarters (June 2020-March 2022) are excluded. The vertical dotted line represents the break between the 2004-05 and 2011-12 series.

Question 1: The manufacturing price deflator. In the new numbers, the manufacturing GVA deflator exhibits negative growth (falling price levels) for nine consecutive quarters between 2023 and 2025 (Figure 1). These numbers are difficult to understand, as there were no signs of deflation in the economy during this period, the core CPI index shows. It is true that the wholesale price index (WPI) was negative for some of this time—but not for nine consecutive quarters; and, in any case, the GVA deflator should not move in line with the WPI, which is overly driven by input prices.

So, what explains this negative growth of the manufacturing GVA deflator? Question 2: The divergence between real Gross Value-Added (GVA) and the index of Industrial Production (IIP). Figure 2 plots the two series for manufacturing in level terms. The difference is substantial. In 2025-26, the level of real GVA exceeded IIP by no less than 15 percentage points, implying that the annual average real growth of manufacturing between 2022-23 and 2025-26 as measured by GVA is about twice that measured by the IIP (11 per cent versus 6 per cent).

To be sure, the two series have somewhat different definitions. For example, real GVA includes the informal sector, while this sector is excluded from the IIP. So, if the informal sector had grown much more rapidly than the formal sector, GVA could outpace IIP. But this explanation is mechanically impossible, since for the most recent two years, informal sector performance has been probed by formal sector data. So, even if the informal sector has been booming (which seems implausible), this could not explain the divergence.

Problems in manufacturing sector data under the previous series were widely recognised and the Ministry of Statistics and Planning Implementation (MoSPI) made strenuous efforts to address them

It is also true that the IIP measures output volumes, rather than value added. And there is a widely held perception that real GVA can grow faster than real output when input prices fall. But this perception is misguided or at least plain wrong because real GVA is calculated at constant—not changing—prices. In fact, real value-added can grow faster than output volumes only if productivity improves, that is if firms become more efficient in using intermediate inputs.

So, the second question is: why is real GVA manufacturing growth almost twice that of IIP manufacturing growth? Question 3: Correlation between the growth rates of real GVA and IIP in manufacturing.

Before the 2011-12 methodology changes, GVA and IIP moved closely together, as one would expect and as Figure 3 shows. (The correlation was 0.8.) But afterwards they diverged and that divergence has, if anything, been exacerbated in the new series. Note that since September 2022 the two series move very differently and the real GVA series bounces around a lot while the IIP series is fairly stable (Figure 3, circled segment).

So, the third question is: Why has the correlation between IIP manufacturing and real GVA in manufacturing weakened so sharply, compared to the 2005-2012 period?

None of these three issues is dispositive about the quality of the new series. But having plausible explanations for them will not only engender confidence in the new GDP figures but also help assess the state of manufacturing in India and the impact of recent government actions to revive it. Not just on the border but also in the economy, whether and how India has stood up to China is a critical question that reliable data will help us answer.

Anand is affiliated to the Madras Institute for Development Studies. Felman is with JH Consulting, and Subramanian is former chief economic advisor to the Government of India

The making of the Republic of Abuse



SAKARIKA GHOSE

THERE IS more than one way to silence an opponent. You can censor or arrest her. Or, you can abuse, caricature and delegitimise her so relentlessly that her arguments seem worthless. When the BJP rejigged its national office-bearers this week, one of the headlines was the exit of the rather infamous T cell head—well known for weaponising disinformation, who in 2017 circulated a doctored collage of Jawaharlal Nehru, including a life inscription about Nehru and his sister, Vijayalakshmi Pandit.

The old BJP social media order has now given way to a team no less foul-mouthed. Several new appointees have lately been scrubbing their accounts—but deleting a feed does not delete a mindset. The internet has a long memory. One of the new appointees had, in the past, used derogatory profanity against former Congress president Sonia Gandhi.

For the BJP, the more coarse-tongued the better. The BJP uses violent language as a technique of power to shut down the Opposition. Words don't just describe politics, they are politics. Abusive language, particularly if used from the summit of state power, achieves exclusion and ostracism without physical force. Attacking words humiliate, exhaust and, in the end, silence. Physical violence incapacitates the body while violent language incapacitates the voice—and imposes enormous costs on speaking out.

The appointment of the BJP's new social media team came two days after PM Narendra Modi, in his Independence Day address, warned of "dinosaur Naxals"—people carrying a Maoist mindset who must be "identified and isolated". Not debated or defeated intellectually but isolated. Banned, delegitimised, not allowed to even participate in the national conversation.

"Dinag Naxal" joins a long lexicon. Modi has earlier used "urban Naxal", and "Khan Market gang". Label the arguer, and she stops being a participant in democratic debate and becomes instead an object of ridicule. A social-media army given unrestrained license makes the space around any dissenting argument so toxic that fewer people are willing to enter it. The Republic of Ideas dies and the Republic of Abuse takes its place.

The BJP's whataboutery is that its opponents started it. Mani Shankar Aiyar's sneering "chavala" jibe in 2014; before that Sonia Gandhi's "maut ka saudagar" in 2007. But these spoke to the public record: Modi's well publicised origin story and communal riots in Gujarat. Contrast that with what has been aimed back. Sonia Gandhi has been called a "bar dancer", "jersey cow", "pastablen", the latter two by Modi himself. Rahul Gandhi has been called a "hybrid calf". Modi has mocked Shashi Tharoor's late wife as a "50-core girlfriend". When Modi taunted Mamata Banerjee with the "Didi, o Didi" refrain, the idea was to not debate Mamata Banerjee but to diminish her and reduce a three-time chief minister to a figure of fun.

No other prime minister, not even Manmohan Singh who endured a decade of caricature, ever deployed such language. Sonia Gandhi never uses personalised insults.

When abuse migrates from anonymous handles to Parliament, its licensing power multiplies. In 2023, BJP MP Ramesh Bidnur, in the Lok Sabha, hurled the despicable slur "kavay" at a fellow MP. When a parliamentarian uses such language, he gives permission for it to be used on the street. When "rice bag" is repeatedly used for Christians, violent words are but a short step away from vandalism of a church.

TV news has created and normalised this vocabulary—"love jihad", "corona jihad", "UPSC jihad". These phrases run on tickers and debates until repetition makes the absurd acceptable and debatable. The dangerous element here is the asymmetry of consequence. Citizens who protest criticism of the government face take-downs and FIRs at lightning speed. The *Indian Express* has reported a social-media post taken down, on average, every minute between March and July 2026. Yet, every year on January 30—the day Mahatma Gandhi was assassinated—social media handles seen as close to the BJP extol Nathuram Godse, Gandhi's assassin. They face no censure. BJP-friendly accounts that dox women, leak private material, or hound critics off the internet operate with impunity. And let's not call these handles just "trolls". Many carry the BJP's weight and enjoy the protection of the state.

Dissent is treated as a national security matter. Vicious misogyny and hateful communalism in the government's defence is treated as the tolerable noise of a lively internet. The Modi regime's mantra is: My abuse is free expression, but your dissent is a threat to the nation. Democracy's essence isn't agreement—it's the opposite, the protection of disagreement. The Opposition must be free to question the government. Journalists must be free to be a thorn in the side of the ruling establishment. A government committed to democratic norms answers an opposing idea with a better idea. It does not declare the person holding a different viewpoint socially untouchable. Call someone a "dinag Naxal" often enough and you never have to engage with what she argues. Call journalists "prestututes" and their reporting goes dismissed and unread. This is how a Republic of Ideas slowly becomes a Republic of Abuse.

The writer is MP, Rajya Sabha, All India Trinamool Congress

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

UPI funding

UPI HAS transformed everyday payments by making transactions quick, hassle-free and accessible ("Keep UPI free. Fund it from the savings it generates", IE, August 22). Charging users directly could discourage small-value digital payments and push some people back towards cash. Since digital transactions also reduce handling and administrative costs, part of these savings could reasonably support the payment ecosystem. The government and banks should therefore devise a transparent funding mechanism without burdening users. Keeping UPI free would encourage wider adoption, particularly among small businesses and ordinary consumers.

Abharna Barathi, Chennai

Humane policies

MIGRANTS SHOULD be viewed primarily as citizens and human beings, not merely as numbers in political debates "What we lose when we stop seeing migrants as people", IE, August 22). They contribute to cities through essential work, often under difficult conditions, while remaining vulnerable to discrimination and insecurity. Governments should ensure access to basic services, legal protection and safe working conditions, irrespective of origin. Public discussion must also avoid language that stereotypes entire communities. Better registration, portable welfare benefits and accessible grievance mechanisms can improve administration without compromising security. A humane and orderly migration policy is possible.

K Sakanthala, Coimbatore

I APPRECIATE the article written by Saptarshi ("What we lose when we stop seeing migrants as people", IE, August 22). In a world where goods, capital and ideas cross borders more freely, why do we still restrict the movement of people? If globalisation has made the world borderless, perhaps it is time to rethink the borders that limit human mobility.

Harshal, via email



SHALINI NAIR

THE "SILLY season" in UK newsrooms is when Parliament and the courts are in summer recess, and journalists chase frivolous stories to fill a slow news period. So, when Jason Arday, 41, the young Black professor in the University of Cambridge's 800-year history, was accused of plagiarising his PhD thesis by White supremacist and now-suspended Ghent University professor, Nathan Cofnas, newsrooms saw in it a clickbait. On August 14, Arday was found dead in his home in south London.

"Cambridge's diversity poster boy in plagiarism row", said an article in the right-leaning *The Telegraph* in late July, months after Arday was cleared of these charges by the University that awarded him his 2015 PhD. This snowballed into a media frenzy that rode the politically expedient wave of White grievance directed at racially minoritised communities. Anti-Blackness, a particularly virulent strain of racism, fuelled the right-wing press's *schadenfreude* while the liberal and left media cloaked it as objectivity, going after Arday's work, life story, and autism. Just two days before his death, *The Guardian* sought out Arday's four primary school classmates for a multiple byline page-and-a-half story. "Questions raised over Jason Arday's claim he was non-verbal at primary school", a misleading headline, for half the respondents agreed.

Giving in to the media clamour, some senior Cambridge academics

demanding an independent investigation into the appointment of an "early career researcher" to the prestigious post. Arday had proven his worth as a University of Glasgow professor, though that did not shield him from the question of his deservedness to set foot on the hallowed grounds of Cambridge. The conservative media and academia targeted Arday to bolster their DEI-gone-too-far myth (Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion). Its ostensibly progressive counterparts subjected Arday to a disproportionate scrutiny that White academics with a proven record of malpractice have not had to contend with.

Unlike the US and India, with some semblance of affirmative action for marginalised races and castes, the UK has no comparable DEI policy. The Black Lives Matter movement, post-2020 Minneapolis police killing of George Floyd, forced elite UK universities into soul-searching. Built on the backs of the transatlantic slave trade and colonialism, they fleetingly took to tokenistic measures over addressing the systemic inequalities in curriculum, recruitment, and funding. Cambridge University going to great lengths to publicise Arday's appointment in early 2023 must be understood within such a context. As should the university's December 2025 defence of Cofnas's "right to freedom of speech"—following student protests over his blog post about how, in a meritocracy, there would be zero Black professors at Harvard.

As for all the talk of accountability and academic integrity, much remains to be sought from institutions rather than from racially minoritised individuals

As for all the talk of accountability and academic integrity, much remains to be sought from institutions rather than from racially minoritised individuals

ability and academic integrity, much remains to be sought from institutions rather than from racially minoritised individuals. Only 1 per cent of the 26,110 professors across UK universities are Black, according to Higher Education Statistics Agency data. UK Research and Innovation data show that White applicants had the highest award success rate (34 per cent), compared with 25 per cent for Asian and 13 per cent for Black applicants. Arday's scholarly work was on these structural barriers faced by racially minoritised, disabled people in UK universities.

In light of this, *The Indian Express* article, "Cambridge professor's death is a life lesson", (August 20) does a disservice by not even addressing race. This moment of reckoning is not merely for the UK media and academia. Individualising narratives on mental health and vulnerability serves to obfuscate the systemic violence of race and caste that underpins the institutional murder of Arday within UK academia and, in India, that of Rohith Vemula, Darshan Solanki, Anitha Shanmugam, Payal Tadi, and countless other Bahujan academics. The recent "general category" Savarna moral panic over the UGC Equity Regulations, 2026, and their virtual against reservation is, after all, no different from the West's DEI-gone-too-far gripe.

The writer is lecturer in Criminology & Leverhulme early research career fellow, Sociological & Cultural Studies, School of Social and Political Sciences, University of Glasgow

What India can learn from EU's AI reset



SAKTI PRASAD SRICHANDAN

THE EU AI Act was presented as a landmark effort to regulate AI through a risk-based framework. But the EU's AI Omnibus, which entered into force on July 27, changes parts of the AI Act. It extends some deadlines and simplifies some compliance requirements. It also gives regulators and companies more time to adapt to high-risk AI rules. This is not a retreat from regulation. It is an admission that AI is changing faster than laws can normally change.

For India, this offers an important lesson. The question is how to regulate AI without slowing innovation. The original EU AI Act was based on a risk-based approach. Some

AI practices were prohibited. High-risk systems faced strict obligations. General-purpose AI models also came under specific rules. But implementation has proved difficult. The EU's response shows that even carefully designed regulation must be capable of adjustment.

The first lesson for India is that good regulation is different from learning. Technology changes. Risks change. Regulators must have the ability to review and adjust rules. Regulation should be a continuing process.

It has focused on responsible AI, innovation and sector-specific governance rather than creating a comprehensive AI law. This flexibility can be useful but it should not become uncertainty. Businesses need clarity. Citizens need protection. Regulators need clear responsibilities. The regulatory burden should

depend on potential harm. The greater the risk to people and society, the stronger the safeguards should be.

The second lesson is that regulation needs an escape valve. Rules work only when regulators and companies have the capacity to implement them. India should consider regulatory sandboxes and regular reviews of AI rules. Sunset mechanisms could make regulation more responsive.

The third lesson concerns smaller com-

The EU has shown that even a major regulatory framework can be revised. Regulatory maturity means recognising when rules are not working and changing them

panies. Compliance can be expensive. Large technology companies can hire lawyers, engineers and auditors. Start-ups cannot always do so. Excessive compliance costs could unintentionally favour large companies and reduce competition.

The fourth lesson is that simplification must not mean deregulation. Reducing paperwork is different from reducing safeguards. AI can create serious risks involving privacy, discrimination, manipulation and opaque decision-making. India must ensure that AI regulation does not mean weaker protection.

The fifth lesson is institutional. The EU has shown that even a major regulatory framework can be revised. Regulatory maturity means recognising when rules are not working and changing them. India has its own strengths. It has a large

digital population; experience with digital public infrastructure. It has a growing technology sector and experience in deploying digital services at scale. These can support an adaptive Indian model of AI governance.

The India AI Mission can play an important role. So can regulatory sandboxes, sectoral regulators, research institutions and industry bodies. India should create a framework that protects citizens while allowing experimentation. Above all, it should be capable of changing as technology changes. The debate over AI is often presented as a choice between regulation and innovation. That is a false choice. The challenge is to design regulation that makes innovation safer and more trusted.

The writer is assistant professor, School of International Studies, JNU

Dhaka open to joining Saudi-Pak-Turkiye defence pact: Ministers

Press Trust of India
Dhaka, August 23

BANGLADESH is open to joining the recently formed defence alliance between Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Türkiye, two junior ministers have said, while stressing that any decision would be guided by the country's national interests.

Signed in Makkah on August 7, the pact establishes a framework for collective defence and stipulates that an armed attack on any one of the three countries would be considered an attack on all three.

"Bangladesh maintains a positive approach towards the possibility of joining an economic or defence framework involving Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Türkiye, taking into account its own interests and changing dynamics of global economy and trade," newly appointed state minister for foreign affairs Humayun Kobar said on Sunday.

In an interview with the Bangladesh service of state-run BSS television, Kobar said the government was pursuing a "Bangladesh First" policy and a balanced foreign policy with national interests at its core, which might lead Dhaka to join the defence pact.

He said Bangladesh would also strengthen bilateral ties

Bangladesh maintains a positive approach towards possibility of joining an economic or defence framework involving Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Türkiye...

HUMAYUN KOBAR,
STATE MINISTER FOR
FOREIGN AFFAIRS

with Pakistan through normal diplomatic engagement, focusing on trade and people-to-people connectivity.

Kobar, appointed as the second state minister for foreign affairs on Friday, said Prime Minister Tarique Rahman expected to visit Riyadh at Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman's invitation and the tour schedule is likely to be finalised after the summer.

Another state minister for foreign affairs, Shame Obaidullah, in a separate media interaction on Friday, supplemented Kobar's comments, saying that Bangladesh's national interest and the interests of its people would determine Dhaka's stance on joining the pact.

SUPREME LEADER SETS THE POLICIES, WE FOLLOW, SAYS IRAN PRESIDENT

US memorandum best path out of war, says Pezeshkian

Will target alternate shipping routes if neighbours join war: Security chief

Associated Press
Tehran, August 23

IRAN'S PRESIDENT defended a memorandum of understanding with the United States as the best way out of a stalled war.

Meanwhile, the new head of Islamic Republic's top security body warned, in a more forceful tone, of retaliation if neighbouring countries support US threats to further sanction Tehran.

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian defended a recent memorandum of understanding as the best way for the country to move beyond what he described as a situation of "neither war nor peace."

In a speech published by state-run IRNA early on Sunday, he said members of Iran's Supreme National Security Council believed the memorandum represented the best possible agreement based on what he described as dignity, wisdom and the national interest.

"There is not a single provision in this agreement that



Iran President Masoud Pezeshkian during a press meet in Ilam. FILE

amounts to capitulation," Pezeshkian said. "The supreme leader sets the policies, and we will follow that path."

The deal known as the Memorandum of Understanding that US President Donald Trump signed in June set an ambitious 60-day deadline for ending the war with Iran and reaching an accord on its nuclear program.

That period ended last week, but the two sides remain far apart, with no signs of compromise on the crucial issue of reopening the Strait of Hormuz, vital to global shipping.

Pezeshkian also linked the agreement to Iran's economic prospects, saying the country

could not attract investment in this stalled phase.

"Capital and money are extremely sensitive to risk," he said. "We have to remove this risk from the country."

Nearly six months into the war with the United States and Israel, the Iranian economy is suffering under sanctions and a naval blockade.

Meanwhile, the hard-line new leader of Iran's Supreme National Security Council warned Tehran's neighbours against joining the new US effort to hurt Iran's economy.

"If (Trump) wants to do something, we will retaliate in an seismic manner," Mohsen Re-

Pak army chief to visit Iran today

Cairo: Pakistan's army chief Asim Munir will visit Tehran on Monday to continue efforts to bring peace and security to the region, Iran's foreign ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said on Sunday, according to a statement by the ministry.

Two Pakistani government sources confirmed Munir's visit to Reuters. "He (Munir) will discuss peace under Islamabad's MoU, Trump's warning and the situation after the Pakistan-Turkey-Saudi Arab Agreement and Houthi issues with Iranian leaders," sources said. REUTERS

zaei said in an interview with that aired Saturday.

Rezaei was named this month as part of senior appointments widely seen as hardening Tehran's political and military stance. His interview with IRIR is his most extensive public statement since then.

Rezaei said Iran would target oil-shipping routes out of the Persian Gulf — alternatives to the Strait of Hormuz — if neighbors join what he described as the economic war against Iran.

Retired Hindu school teacher, wife, kids killed in Bangladesh; two detained

Press Trust of India
Dhaka, August 23

A RETIRED Hindu school teacher along with his wife and two children were allegedly killed in a house in Bangladesh's Rangpur city, according to a media report.

The deceased were identified as Ganapati Chakraborty, 65, Pratilata Chakraborty, 50, Agami Chakraborty Prarthi, 23, and Priyam Chakraborty, 12, the Daily Star newspaper reported.

The bodies of the four family members were recovered from their locked house in the Daspara area of Rangpur city around 11:30 pm on Friday.

The police have detained two men, identified as Mughdho and Siddhartha, for their involvement in the killings. They are cousins.

The duo allegedly entered the rooftop of Chakraborty's house through a neighbouring building and took the drug jackets to national flags, Christmas ornaments and 36 types of plywood, face new 50% US tariffs that took effect Saturday.

The tariffs followed PM Mark Carney's decision to end nearly a month of trade talks with Washington. "They asked too much and offered too little," Carney said. He has vowed "dollar for dollar" retaliation.

The new duties cover \$20 billion in Canadian exports, with forest products among the biggest targets. The 36 types of plywood listed have raised concerns among US homebuilders, who say limited domestic supplies could push up construction costs. Alcohol is also prominent, the Trump administration has been particularly vexed by the fact that eight of Canada's 10 provinces still restrict US wine and spirits from their government-owned liquor distribution system and stores.

Dairy products are another target. Canada uses production quotas and other tools to protect domestic dairy producers, who sell largely to Canadian market.

Clothing and textiles also take a hit. Like the US, much of Canada's clothing production

Putin wants to draft 3,00,000 new troops, says Zelenskyy

Reuters
Kyiv, August 23

UKRAINE THINKS Russia is planning to draft an additional 300,000 troops for its war effort after Russian parliamentary elections in mid-September, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said.

Moscow's forces are pressing ahead with an effort to capture rest of eastern Ukraine's industrialised Donbas region, where its troops have found forward at what Kyiv says is a great cost.

In comments to reporters released on Sunday, Zelenskyy said Russia could draft more troops in 2027 to reach an overall goal of 500,000, part of what he described as a "peripheral mobilisation" targeting Russia's far-flung regions.

"We believe it will not take



(From left) Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, Norway PM Jonas Gahr Støre, Lithuania's President Gitanas Nausėda and Denmark's PM Mette Frederiksen in Kyiv on Sunday. REUTERS

place in the central cities," he said. "But I don't think they will be able to do it very well."

As fighting rages around the strategic city of Kostiantynivka, Zelenskyy said Russia was losing a "maximum" amount of troops

in its bid to advance into Ukraine's so-called fortress belt of eastern cities. He also hailed recent gains by Kyiv's troops in southeastern Ukraine, adding the amount of territory occupied by Russia and liberated by

terceptors Ukraine is expecting to have received in 2026 represent a significant drop from 2025 adding that Russia was aiming to develop a capacity to produce up to 1,300 ballistic missiles per year.

'Wartime election will destroy Ukraine'

Kyiv: Holding a wartime election in Ukraine while active fighting with Russia continues would "destroy" the country by splitting Ukrainians, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said.

His comments, released to reporters on Sunday, were Zelenskyy's first on the subject since ousted former Defence Minister Mykhailo Fedorov called for a wartime poll in a bombshell address last week.

Ze-

"I believe that if we want to destroy the country, then we can move towards elections during this kind of war," Zelenskyy said. Echoing his previous comments on the matter, Zelenskyy said a wartime election might be possible if Kyiv's partners could guarantee security, but that no one has proposed such a plan.

"Elections right now are a tsunami for the state, which will split Ukraine," he said. REUTERS

• **BRIEFLY**

NIGERIA

President orders investigation into second fake government agency



Nigerian President Bola Tinubu during a press conference in Abuja. FILE

NIGERIA'S PRESIDENT Bola Tinubu ordered an investigation into a man accused of creating and running a fake government agency, the second such agency uncovered in recent weeks. Musa Adamu Aliyu, head of the country's corruption watchdog, announced the probe after briefing president in the capital, Abuja. The latest bogus agency, called the National Brands Development and Made in Nigeria Special Project Office, was operating illegally from a government office and was headed by George Buchi Nwabueze. AP

JAPAN

5.9-quake hits eastern Japan, 37 injured

A MODERATE earthquake rattled eastern Japan, including the Tokyo area, early Sunday, injuring more than 30 people, most of them lightly, officials said. There was no danger of a tsunami. According to the Japan Meteorological Agency, the quake had a preliminary magnitude of 5.9 and its epicentre was in the southern Ibaraki prefecture with a depth of 70 kilometres. AP

UNITED STATES

\$850mn payment planned toward \$5bn UN debt

The US government has notified Congress of its plans to pay \$850 million of the \$5 billion it owes to the United Nations. The State Department laid out its plans to transfer \$725 million as part of its dues to the regular UN budgetary agency, the United Nations Development Programme, toward UN peacekeeping operations in Haiti and the Democratic Republic of Congo, according to notifications sent to lawmakers. AP

• **NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH**

PAKISTAN

Gunmen kill security official at KPK province

A SECURITY official was killed on Sunday by unidentified gunmen in northwest Pakistan, police said. According to police, the incident occurred in the jurisdiction of Badaber Police Station on the outskirts of Peshawar, the capital city of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province. The two unidentified armed assailants opened fire at the Counter Terrorism Department official, killing him on the spot, police said, adding that the attackers fled the scene after the incident. PTI

SRILANKA

Referendum sought on judges' retirement age

SRILANKA'S main Tamil political party, the Ilankai Tamil Arasu Kachchi (ITAK), on Sunday called for holding a national referendum on a controversial constitutional amendment that seeks to increase the retirement age of judges. The proposed 22nd Constitution Amendment seeks to increase the retirement age of judges from 65 to 67 years and that of the Court of Appeal judges from 63 to 65. It proposes increasing the retirement age of judges of the HC, District Courts and Magistrates' Courts to 62. PTI

Beijing postpones Moon exploration mission launch

Associated Press
Haikou, August 23

CHINA SAID on Sunday it was postponing its planned ambitious Chang'e-7 lunar mission, which was set to carry out explorations including searching for water ice on the moon.

The Chang'e-7 spacecraft was originally set to lift off in the coming days from the Wenchang Space Launch Site on China's southern Hainan island.

The mission does not meet the launch conditions, said the China Manned Space Agency in a brief statement, and "cannot take place during the planned window this year."

The decision was made following a "comprehensive assessment," the agency added, and was based on the principles of "prudence, reliability and absolute mission success." It did not further elaborate on the reasons behind the decision.



China's Chang'e-7 lunar probe and Long March-5 rocket at the launch site in Hainan. FILE

Preparations have been carried out at the Wenchang launch site for the Chang'e-7 mission over the past weeks, the seventh in the Chang'e moon exploration program. It aimed at making breakthroughs in key technologies, the official Xinhua news agency previously reported.

The Chang'e-6 probe returned to Earth in 2024 with rock and soil samples from the far side of the moon in a world first.

Wigs to flags: Trump tariffs hit Canada hard

lan Austen
Ottawa, August 23

HUNDREDS of Canadian goods, from anoraks and suit jackets to national flags, Christmas ornaments and 36 types of plywood, face new 50% US tariffs that took effect Saturday.

The tariffs followed PM Mark Carney's decision to end nearly a month of trade talks with Washington. "They asked too much and offered too little," Carney said. He has vowed "dollar for dollar" retaliation.

The new duties cover \$20 billion in Canadian exports, with forest products among the biggest targets. The 36 types of plywood listed have raised concerns among US homebuilders, who say limited domestic supplies could push up construction costs. Alcohol is also prominent, the Trump administration has been particularly vexed by the fact that eight of Canada's 10 provinces still restrict US wine and spirits from their government-owned liquor distribution system and stores.

Dairy products are another target. Canada uses production quotas and other tools to protect domestic dairy producers, who sell largely to Canadian market.

Clothing and textiles also take a hit. Like the US, much of Canada's clothing production

• WHAT'S HIT BY NEW 50% TARIFFS?

From plywood and dairy to Christmas ornaments and dog collars, new 50% duties cover \$20 billion in Canadian exports, with Ottawa vowing dollar-for-dollar retaliation.

Woods: Plywood and other forest products

Alcohol: Wine, spirits and unusual beverage mixtures

Industrial: Egg graders, marine buoys, derricks and sandblasters

Clothing: Anoraks, jackets, T-shirts, dresses, gloves and more

Dairy: Canadian dairy products

Festive goods: Christmas ornaments, toys and carnival items

Household: Bedroom furniture, safes and sun blinds

Other: National flags, jewelry and honey

THE GOOD ONES

National flags, Christmas ornaments, Painting canvases, Dog muzzles, Hockey sticks, Bookbinding machines, Base metal statuettes, wigs (partial), false beards, eyebrows



target. Canada uses production quotas and other tools to protect domestic dairy producers, who sell largely to Canadian market.

Clothing and textiles also take a hit. Like the US, much of Canada's clothing production

moved overseas long ago, and some Canadian online retailers sell goods made abroad to US customers. Simply shipping things from Canada triggers the tariffs, regardless of where the products were made. NYT

4-year-old among two killed in Israeli airstrikes in Gaza

Cairo: Two Israeli airstrikes in the Gaza Strip on Sunday killed at least two people, including a 4-year-old boy, and wounded seven others, Palestinian health officials said.

One of the strikes hit a building in Zawayda town and followed a warning by the Israeli army for the owners of the property to leave, residents said.

Medics said flying debris and shrapnel that spread for dozens of metres around had wounded at least six people, including the 4-year-old, Mohammad Abdel-Salam, who was later pronounced dead at hospital.

The second airstrike took place in nearby Nuseirat refugee camp, the health officials said. Israel's military said it was looking into both strikes. REUTERS



In 2006, war with Iraq was the central issue in midterm campaign. NYT

sought to capitalize on economic concerns. In 2006, Bush's proposal to privatize Social Security became a key target,

though it never passed.

Now, Democrats are focusing on a Republican-backed law cutting Medicaid and other safety-

net programs to finance large tax cuts, as well as GOP's decision to let health care subsidies expire, drug premiums higher.

"We found an issue early," Schumer said, recalling 2006. "Rahm and I did Social Security. Now we found the costs issue, particularly led by health care."

Another theme from 2006 has a modern counterpart: allegations of Republican misconduct. Two decades ago, Democratic campaign targeted against a "culture of corruption," citing financial and sex scandals that led to resignations and prison terms for several senior Republicans.

In September 2006, Representative Mark Foley, Republican of Florida, was revealed to

have sent sexually suggestive messages to male House pages.

Republican leaders had been warned but failed to act, casting doubt over the party two months before the election.

This year, Republicans again face high-profile sexual misconduct accusations involving multiple House members, although Democrats have faced their own allegations.

Top Democrats have emphasized Republican conduct on Capitol Hill and scrutiny of an administration in which Trump, his family and allies have faced accusations of profiteering.

On NBC's "Meet the Press" earlier this month, Representative Hakeem Jeffries of New

York, the Democratic leader, said a central element of the Democratic agenda was "pushing back against the corruption unleashed over the party two months before the election."

Whether these issues will produce another 2006 remains unclear. But Nathan Gonzales, editor of nonpartisan Inside Elections, says: "... Ordinarily unrelated events get lumped together under one umbrella. Everything was Bush's fault: The Iraq war and Mark Foley really had nothing to do with each other, but it cultivated an appetite for change. I could see it happening again." NYT

• **WITH AN UNPOPULAR WAR, RISING COSTS AND REPUBLICAN SCANDALS, DEMOCRATS SEE ECHOES OF 2006, WHEN SIMILAR PRESSURES FUELLED SWEEPING GAINS IN MIDTERM ELECTIONS**

Bush to Trump, Iraq to Iran: 20 years later, US midterms throw up 'eerie similarities'

Carl Hulse
August 22

THE WAR in West Asia is increasingly unpopular. So is President Trump, whose approval numbers are dipping. Congressional Republicans are embroiled in scandals, Americans are paying more at the pump and economic anxiety is rising.

That grim backdrop has created a steep challenge for Republicans heading into November's midterm elections and an opportunity for Democrats that looks similar to 2006. Then, congressional Republicans faced voters midway through President George W Bush's second term, with public anger fuelled

by the Iraq war, high fuel prices and damaging accusations against members of majority.

"It is striking," said Senator Chuck Schumer of New York, the Democratic minority leader and chief architect of his party's Senate campaign strategy in 2006. "The analogy is amazing."

Politics have changed, but the comparison is instructive as both parties confront an election that will determine control of Congress for the remainder of Trump's term.

"This is 2006/20," said Rahm Emanuel, who in 2006 was a Democratic House member from Illinois and Schumer's counterpart across Capitol as head of the Democratic Congress-

ional Campaign Committee. "The similarities are eerie."

In 2006, Democrats gained six Senate seats and took control of the chamber. In the House, Democrats picked up 31 seats as the Republican majority appeared exhausted after 12 years in power. The Senate map is less favorable to Democrats this year.

In 2006, Iraq was the central campaign issue as Americans soured on Bush's handling of the war, after his main justification for the invasion, the claim Saddam Hussein had weapons of mass destruction, proved false.

Trump's conflict with Iran has lasted less time and produced fewer casualties.

Democrats then, as now,



In 2006, war with Iraq was the central issue in midterm campaign. NYT

sought to capitalize on economic concerns. In 2006, Bush's proposal to privatize Social Security became a key target,

though it never passed.

Now, Democrats are focusing on a Republican-backed law cutting Medicaid and other safety-

net programs to finance large tax cuts, as well as GOP's decision to let health care subsidies expire, drug premiums higher.

"We found an issue early," Schumer said, recalling 2006. "Rahm and I did Social Security. Now we found the costs issue, particularly led by health care."

Another theme from 2006 has a modern counterpart: allegations of Republican misconduct. Two decades ago, Democratic campaign targeted against a "culture of corruption," citing financial and sex scandals that led to resignations and prison terms for several senior Republicans.

In September 2006, Representative Mark Foley, Republican of Florida, was revealed to

have sent sexually suggestive messages to male House pages.

Republican leaders had been warned but failed to act, casting doubt over the party two months before the election.

This year, Republicans again face high-profile sexual misconduct accusations involving multiple House members, although Democrats have faced their own allegations.

Top Democrats have emphasized Republican conduct on Capitol Hill and scrutiny of an administration in which Trump, his family and allies have faced accusations of profiteering.

On NBC's "Meet the Press" earlier this month, Representative Hakeem Jeffries of New

York, the Democratic leader, said a central element of the Democratic agenda was "pushing back against the corruption unleashed over the party two months before the election."

Whether these issues will produce another 2006 remains unclear. But Nathan Gonzales, editor of nonpartisan Inside Elections, says: "... Ordinarily unrelated events get lumped together under one umbrella. Everything was Bush's fault: The Iraq war and Mark Foley really had nothing to do with each other, but it cultivated an appetite for change. I could see it happening again." NYT



FROM ACs TO SMARTPHONES, MEMORY CHIP SHORTAGES ARE PUSHING UP PRICES

Chipflation: Electronics see years of price hikes replicated in 6 mths

Consumers are increasingly looking out for promotional offers because of rising electronics prices, say analysts

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, August 23

THE GLOBAL artificial intelligence (AI) investment boom has created an acute shortage of the memory chips used in the manufacture of everyday consumer electronics.

This has led to manufacturers raising rates they charge to such an extent that years of price hikes that occurred in the past for products such as smartphones and TVs have taken place in just six months in 2026.

According to Consumer Price Index (CPI) data from the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI), prices of a variety of consumer electronics goods in July were up 3-5% compared to January.

The price movements were far more sedate in 2025.

Take mobile handsets. Compared to a 4% rise from January 2026 to July 2026, the same period in 2025 had seen its CPI price index decline by 0.7%.

Or take air conditioners. While they normally do see higher prices in the summer, the extent of the increase this year has been 4.8% compared to 1.1% between January-July 2025. Go back further and 2026's price hikes become even

more striking. Since January 2026, the CPI index of TVs is up 3.5%. If one counts back from December 2025, matching this magnitude of increase took 54 months, or four-and-a-half years. The numbers are similarly large for other consumer electronics: 46 for ACs, 45 for fridges, 41 for mobile phones, 32 for washing machines, and 31 for computers and laptops.

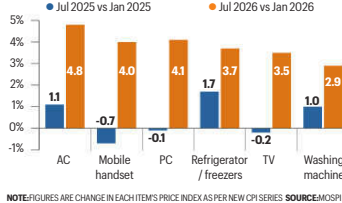
The increase in price indices over 2026 of the aforementioned six consumer electronics is calculated as per the new CPI series which has 2024 as the base year. For the period prior to 2026, price index changes are computed using the old CPI series which had 2012 as the base year. Only consumer electronic items present in both the old and new CPI baskets have been compared.

'Chipflation'

Back in June, analysts at American investment bank Morgan Stanley had coined the term 'chipflation' to describe how 'AI's appetite for memory chips is boosting the cost of everything from data centers to smartphones, with consequences that may reach far beyond the tech industry.'

The global AI boom has led to key chipmakers such as

•CHIPFLATION PUSHING UP PRICES OF CONSUMER ELECTRONICS



NOTE: FIGURES ARE CHANGE IN EACH ITEM'S PRICE INDEX AS PER NEW CPI SERIES SOURCE: MOSPI

TSMC, Samsung, and SK Hynix making the more in-demand and advanced chips used in data centres sprouting up all over the world.

What is being sacrificed are DRAM (Dynamic Random Access Memory) and other chips used in everyday electronics goods such as refrigerators, washing machines, ACs, smart-

phones, laptops, TVs, and earphones. The result of the supply shortage of the chips essential to consumer electronics is a massive rise in their prices, with JPMorgan Global Research estimating DRAM prices will have risen more than 400% from the start of 2024 to the end of 2026. This is in stark contrast to the Moore's Law driven cost reduc-

tion seen over the second half of the 20th century and the first 20 or so years of the 21st century. DRAM prices fell 90% every five years over this period. "New memory capacity takes years to build, qualify and ramp up. Supply relief is a process, not a switch. And that creates a two-tier market. Large AI and cloud buyers can sign long-term agreements, prepay and secure priority access. Traditional buyers, including PC makers, smartphone makers and industrial hardware companies, must compete for what remains," Shawn Kim, Head of Morgan Stanley's Europe and Asia Technology Team, said in a podcast in June.

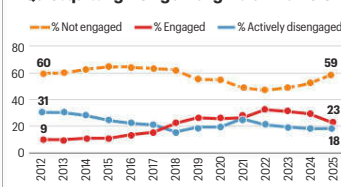
Eyes on promotions

According to Kim, the shortfall in memory chips in 2027 is equivalent to what is needed to make 134 million phones. Already, in the April-June quarter, global smartphone exports were down 1% - their second-lowest level since 2013 - as per Counterpoint Research.

In India, smartphone sales fell for three weeks in a row after online promotional events in July. "...rising device prices are making consumers increasingly value-conscious and more dependent on promotional offers," said Prachin Singh, Senior Analyst at Counterpoint Research, who added that this trend has become more visible over the past few months.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

•'Quiet quitting' rising among Indian workers



• The phrase 'quiet quitting' went viral in 2022. And new research by analytics and advisory company Gallup shows the share of Indian workers who are not engaged - sometimes described as 'quiet quitting' as they only meet the basic requirements and invest little discretionary effort - rose to 59% in 2025 from 46% in 2022.

18% The percentage of employees who are actively disengaged has flattened.

• According to Gallup, India's current level of disengagement costs \$351 billion in lost workplace productivity each year. This is equivalent to about 9% of GDP. "This figure should sound an alarm and make the country's declining engagement a national economic crisis," a Gallup report, released Saturday, said.

23% The share of engaged staff has declined.

SOURCE: GALLUP-INSTITUTE OF DIRECTORS REPORT

Top FMCG firms rejig brass amid growth challenges

New Delhi: The Indian fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) sector is witnessing a wave of leadership changes, with several leading companies appointing new chief executives and elevating senior executives as they seek to sharpen execution, drive growth and adapt to an evolving consumer landscape.

In the last 12 months or so, at least half a dozen major FMCG companies, including Hindustan Unilever Ltd (HUL), Godrej Consumer Products Ltd (GCP), Dabur India, Britannia Indus-

tries and Colgate-Palmolive India, have announced transitions at the top level, with Nestle India's own change of guard having taken place just before that window.

These leadership changes have come at a time when FMCG companies are grappling with a challenging operating environment marked by uneven consumer demand, rising competition from regional and local players, and pressure to deliver volume-led growth while protecting market share. PTI

When the bank had set a specific target for its platinum jubilee year, Setty said there was no formal milestone, but the bank's growth trajectory could take it to total business to Rs 170-180 lakh crore and potentially as high as Rs 200 lakh crore by 2030.

"We don't have any milestone, but if you take the current growth rate, I think we should be around Rs 170-180 lakh crore, or maybe reaching Rs 200 lakh crore. That would be another important milestone," he told PTI in an interview. PTI

How do satcom services work

Satellite communication services rely on an array of satellites in orbit to offer connectivity to homes and businesses on the ground.

For end-users, satellite-based communication and broadband services offer benefits on two key points: wider coverage, and a more resilient network. Even though the latency of satcom services can at times be higher than terrestrial broadband networks, they can cover vast swathes of areas with very little physical equipment needed to be installed.

So why the delay?

The Starlink Gen1 Constellation is a global constellation with 4,408 satellites orbiting earth in altitude varying between 540-570 km, capable of providing around 600 Gbps throughput over India.

However, despite the regulatory clearance, it is understood the government is yet to green light formal launch of these services over security concerns. The concern particularly stems from anxieties around foreign satcom operators potentially bypassing Indian gateways to offer their services, an event when the government might lose control

• INFORMATION HIGHWAYS

• Satellite communication services rely on an array of satellites in orbit to offer connectivity to homes and businesses on the ground.

• They are an alternative to ground-based communication, called terrestrial networks, such as cable and fibre, or digital subscriber line.



over the service. In satellite communication, Indian gateways refer to Satellite Earth Station Gateways (SESGs) physically located within Indian territory that interface between space-based satellite constellations and domestic terrestrial telecom networks.

NavIC based positioning systems in their user terminals on "best effort basis," along with a transition plan to implement NavIC in a time-bound manner by 2029.

NavIC, or Navigation with Indian Constellation, is India's regional satellite navigation system, similar to GPS, which is a global system developed by the US. Companies will have to provide real time monitoring to ensure that no user traffic originating from, or destined for India is being routed through any gateway outside Indian territory.

They will also have to submit an undertaking that they will not copy and decrypt Indian telecom data outside India. Operators would need to implement security restrictions to "any individual, group of subscribers or certain geographical areas" during "hostilities," the guidelines said. These companies will have to seek separate clearance "from security angle" for voice service and data service.

Satcom operators will also have to ensure that their data centres are based within the geographical boundary of India and shall make provision to provide Domain Name System (DNS) resolution within its territory.

DoT guidelines for satcom companies

In May, the DoT had released guidelines for satellite communication companies. The norms call for companies to set up local manufacturing, data localisation, use domestic navigation systems, implement a blocking mechanism, and cooperate with law enforcement agencies.

According to the guidelines, satcom companies will have to share with the government a year-wise phased manufacturing plan aiming at indigenisation to a level of at least 20% of their ground segment of the satellite network that is established at the end of 5 years after launching commercial operations. The companies should also ensure provisioning of

• BRIEFLY

'Rising costs may hit construction equipment growth in FY27'

New Delhi: Rising prices of steel and bitumen, geopolitical uncertainty, and continuing challenges in execution of infrastructure projects could moderate India's construction equipment industry growth in the current financial year, Shalabh Chaturvedi, Vice President of the Indian Construction Equipment Manufacturers' Association and Managing Director, India and SAARC, CASE Construction Equipment, has said. PTI

Sales bookings of 28 major listed realty firms fall 21% in Apr-Jun

New Delhi: India's 28 big listed real estate firms' collective sales bookings fell 21% to nearly Rs 40,000 crore in the latest June quarter due to lower volumes, as some big developers refrained from launching housing projects amid global economic uncertainties. According to data compiled from investor presentations, total

combined sales bookings, or pre-sales, of the 28 major listed real estate companies stood at Rs 39,964 crore in the first quarter of 2026-27 compared to Rs 50,900 crore in the year-ago period. The housing segment contributed the bulk of the sales booking numbers. Godrej Properties became the largest listed real estate developer in terms of sales bookings. It sold properties worth Rs 8,651 crore in the June quarter against Rs 7,082 crore in the year-ago period. PTI

Urban Company sues Kent RO purifier ads

New Delhi: Urban Company has filed a defamation and disparagement suit against Kent RO Systems before the Delhi High Court alleging it ran advertisements and social media content which had made false and misleading claims about its 'Native' water purifiers. In a regulatory filing on Sunday, Urban Company said Kent RO had launched a "concerted advertising campaign" featuring ads and social media content, based on what it called false and misleading claims. FE

• ON SATURDAY, TWO ROBOTS RAN FASTER THAN USAIN BOLT'S 9.58-SECOND WORLD RECORD IN THE 100-METER SPRINT

Robots can outrun humans, but can they do precision tasks like connecting cables?

Reuters
Beijing, August 23

CHINA'S HUMANOID robots have shown they can run quicker than the fastest humans. Now comes the real test: can they also handle packaging and warehouse operations while reliably performing precision tasks like connecting cables designed to evaluate their ability to work like humans in less flashy jobs?

The five-day World Humanoid Robot Games, which began Saturday in Beijing, combine events modelled on human sports with those designed to test the robots in

simulated factories, restaurants, offices and in emergency situations.

The games, heavily promoted in Chinese state media, feature 51 events, including 30 sports competitions and 21 scenario-based contests. More than 40% require robots to operate fully autonomously, according to Huawei, a tech partner of the games.

In addition to more than 100 robots, two robots ran faster than Usain Bolt's 9.58-second world record in the 100-meter sprint.

That was a sharp improvement from 2025, when the winning robot's time was more than 20 seconds. Braking was

an issue, as the machines slammed into a thick mat that organizers placed at several metres before the finish line. Another humanoid, the same model as the 100-meter champion, ran 400 metres in 39.7 seconds, faster than South African Wayne van Niekerk's world record of 43.03 seconds.

"The intensity is higher than last year, which places demands on the robot's battery management and thermal dissipation capabilities," said spectator and robotics investor Xu Qiaosheng. "It holds huge significance for the development of China's industrial sector."



The more revealing tests could come when robots encounter the small imperfections of the physical world. REUTERS

Robots will compete in tug-of-war and weightlifting, while Tai Chi and pitch-pot - in which contestants throw arrow-like sticks into a narrow-necked vase - will give tradi-

tional Chinese sports a futuristic twist.

Big tests in small imperfections

Beyond the spectacle, the more revealing tests could come when robots encounter the small imperfections of the physical world: a cable at the wrong angle, an object just out of reach, a shifting package or a closed step.

That tests whether robots can identify objects, accurately position their hands and bodies, apply controlled force and recover from errors without human intervention. Lumos Robotics Chief

Executive Yu Chao said the games could help improve hardware and provide a showcase for the industry.

But Yu said the longer-term value will depend on real-world problem solving.

"Only when it can work in those end scenarios does it have real value," Yu said.

"Simply running and jumping do not improve efficiency," he added. In more familiar events drawn from humansports, robots will compete in EV charging, restaurant work, emergency incident handling and hand-dexterity contests. There are also industrial assembly and material

loading events. A cable connection challenge is a test of vision, mechanical alignment and force control for the industry.

Beijing-based robotics startup Galbot said it would stage an autonomous humanoid tennis match, with robots attempting singles and doubles play, including ball tracking, serving and returning shots.

For Hua Kong, chief marketing officer at robot firm Zeroh, the real test will come in the demonstrations end. "The competition will be whether, after the product is sold, it can really solve users' problems," the chief marketing officer said.

WHY NEELKANTH MISHRA

Neelkanth Mishra is an Executive Director at the World Bank group, representing India, Bangladesh, Bhutan, and Sri Lanka. Bringing a wealth of experience from decades of work in financial markets and policy circles, he joins at a time of high global uncertainty. He was most recently Axis Bank's Chief Economist. Prior to that, he spent nearly 20 years at Credit Suisse, was a part-time member of the Economic Advisory Council to the PM of India and is the part-time chairperson of the Unique Identification Authority of India. His several public roles include associations with the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India and the India Semiconductor Mission, among others

Aanchal Magazine: You've recently been appointed Executive Director at the World Bank, making you one of India's youngest representatives at the institution. Coming from the private sector, what do you plan to do differently in your new role?

Private or public sector, there are three aspects to the role. First is the role of an ED at the World Bank: board-level deliberations and issues affecting World Bank policies. The Bank itself is in transition. Its role has to be rethought, and new president Ajay Banga is restructuring it.

The second role is that of a facilitator. The World Bank's engagement with India now needs to change. The Indian financial system is much larger — non-government financial credit is now \$3 trillion, growing 15 per cent a year. We're generating \$450 billion of credit. Add venture capital, private equity, IPO markets and retained corporate equity, and the World Bank's \$2.5 billion is far less significant than it was 20 years ago.

The cost of capital has also changed. There was a time when US government bonds yielded 2 per cent and India was at 8 per cent, making World Bank capital cheaper even after hedging. That's no longer the case. The US 10-year bonds are at 4.7 per cent and India at 6.7 per cent. After hedging, the risk-free rate in India in rupee terms is no longer viable.

The big opportunity is the World Bank's expertise. There are market failures in India — areas where we want to solve problems but need to bring demand and supply together — such as tourism and urbanisation. The World Bank's experience in developing tourist hubs and supporting urbanisation in large countries, including China, is something we can tap into. So, there is demand, supply can be brought into the pipeline, and trust and understanding can be built on both sides.

Third is to improve or work on India's image in Washington DC. So, from the limited time I have spent there, it seems the image of India is still of what India was 15-20 years ago. So, there is a lot of work that needs to be done in terms of just making people aware of what India has achieved in, say, semiconductors, digital public infrastructure, and urbanisation — where there is a long way to go. But there are many positive things happening in India. As a younger person, maybe I can bring in some more energy in driving all three.

Aanchal Magazine: As capital flows remain a concern, what is the India story we are trying to sell to global investors and where are we lagging?

I don't think it is that bad. This is a problem everyone is facing. Anyone dependent on foreign capital knows its cost has gone up because the cost of the global risk-free rate is now fiscally indiscipline and 10-year yields have risen.

In India, even though net FDI (Foreign Direct Investment) is slow, gross inbound FDI is still going up. India is reaching a stage where some companies are so large that the only way to grow is outside India. So, out-bound FDI is also picking up. When you put all this together, sustaining 1 per cent of GDP of current account deficit is also a strategic choice. Our choice used to be 2-3 per cent; that may be hard to execute now. Therefore, I think some of the amendments, ordinances, and the fact that we have now opened up a lot more to foreign bond funds are important. Maybe the area where a lot of investment needs to happen is urbanisation and private capital mobilisation, which is also a World Bank priority. We need to absorb the fact that the global environment has changed... We have to think like a proper power; everything is not about us and that people don't like us. It is a reality that this is how water flows; the gradient is not good enough, let's try to make it good enough.

Aanchal Magazine: There is a flip side to getting so much foreign money as Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposits?

This has many different aspects. The first is that if you are running a current account deficit, it means that you consume more than you produce and you are taking on liabilities, whether it is FDI or global bond investors buying Indian bonds — capital inflow is a liability, it will go back. It's the duration and the cost that matters. When you get a large amount of money through private equity and venture capital — which is great because it is very high-risk capital and we need that — if it is successful, the effective cost is 15 per cent. If you allow capital to come in at 6.7 per cent interest, if the FPIs (Foreign Portfolio Investors) are buying Indian sovereign bonds, or 6.5 per cent on FCNR(B), what's wrong with it? Now, will there be an outflow three-five years later? We will do another FCNR(B). So, it's a strategic choice; you need capital to fund growth.

The second aspect is the currency. Currencies usually have no anchor because in another security, whether bond or equity, you have earnings, coupons, or some collateral. But currencies can be viciously volatile. The rupee is at 95 per dollar; it may not be the ideal level; my view is that the USD to INR should be lower. But my view does not matter. If people see it stabilising at 95, then the importer will say, 'kyu hedge



ON CHANGING INDIA'S IMAGE IN DC

It seems India's image is still what it was 15-20 years ago. A lot of work needs to be done in just making people aware in Washington DC what India has achieved in, say, semiconductors, digital public infrastructure



ON INDIA'S GROWTH & JOBS CHALLENGE

I don't think we will be able to create all the jobs we need to. To create jobs for everyone, it will require us to grow at 10 per cent in real terms. Should we try to do that? We should. But is that realistic? I don't think so

'Rise in inequality since labour is in surplus, capital in shortage. Need to democratise access to capital'

Neelkanth Mishra, Executive Director, World Bank, on India's growth ambitions, the disruption AI could bring to education, private sector's investment appetite and the rupee's road ahead. The conversation was moderated by Aanchal Magazine, Deputy Associate Editor, *The Indian Express*



Neelkanth Mishra, Executive Director - World Bank (right) in a conversation with Aanchal Magazine, Deputy Associate Editor, *The Indian Express* RENUKA PURI

karein? Over time, the hedging demand goes down, and suddenly you start seeing the reverse, which is that surplus dollars are coming. Some of that has been hidden by the fact that RBI's forwards have been unwound. Once it starts becoming visible, the panic will subside and the rupee will find its own level. When you have a run on the currency, you have to give a shock to the market and say, look at this, we have \$100 billion. Then people back off.

Aanchal Magazine: Where do you see the rupee finding its level in the near future?

Now that the firepower is there, the rupee can stabilise. Remember, the West Asian conflict is actually at a precarious stage right now. Both sides are starting to get restless because there is a cost to be incurred. So, if it flares up before it comes down and oil prices go up significantly from here and if in that desperation someone damages some energy facility, then there are serious issues. So, that's my only worry. Otherwise, I think we are in reasonably safe territory.

My sense is that sometime in the next two-three years, the dollar has to depreciate significantly... and people will be hunting for other assets. And this is a deep vulnerability we have: when the dollar starts to fall, gold prices will skyrocket. Indians are now wealthy enough to start speculating in that. So, demand for gold imports will skyrocket at that time; we need to be prepared for that, we need to have the investment products which do not pressure the balance of payments.

P Vaidyanathan Iyer: The jobs problem is becoming more pronounced. India is growing at 6-8 per cent but a large number of young people are entering the workforce.

There is a continuing debate over whether services or manufacturing can create enough jobs. How do you see this challenge being addressed, particularly over the long term?

The post-COVID recovery is not yet complete. We can debate it, but we are about 10 per cent below our pre-pandemic path. Only the US is, I think, on its pre-pandemic path or slightly higher because of fiscal discipline. The assumption that we are not creating jobs is wrong; are we creating sufficient jobs is the question. If 7 per cent growth is happening, it's not that labour demand growth is zero and everyone is becoming 7 per cent more productive. So, jobs have been created. Real estate sales are doing very well. So clearly construction is happening.

But there is slack. And as the slack happens, pricing power goes down, inequality goes up. The bigger question is: will we be able to create sufficient jobs in the next 10, 15, 20 years? Because that's a period of demographic dividend. I don't think we will be able to create all the jobs that we need to. So, if you add the hidden unemployment in agriculture and the underemployment in the female labour force, we can't find jobs for them. So, if you want to create jobs for everyone, that will require us to grow at 10 per cent in real terms. Should we try to do that? We should. But is that realistic? I don't think so.



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Aanchal Magazine: How do you think India's education system needs to evolve?

ON INDIA'S ENERGY VULNERABILITY

We are deeply vulnerable to global energy market volatility. We have to solve this. Some technology shifts are helping. But that vulnerability will remain for the next 10-12 years. I am hopeful that it will not become a constraint



My slightly controversial take on education is that it is more a signalling tool than a skill-development tool. On skilling and education, AI will revolutionise access to skills and education. You don't need a good teacher. I remember taking the JEE 33 years back; we never got some of the books in Bokaro, and I used to envy people in Mumbai and Delhi who could get them easily. Today, PDF copies circulate everywhere. You can ask Gemini. My son is doing mathematical Olympiad problems and when he can't solve them, he asks Gemini. This is a huge democratisation; you don't need a good tutor; if you are enterprising enough, you can solve these problems.

That's what we need in India, where state governments struggle with teacher attendance and quality of pedagogy. You also have the low-income trap, where the poorest states have the least money to spend on education. The World Bank has argued that AI can significantly enhance state capacity, and education is a primary element. Which is why I think education will get disrupted. How exactly, I don't know, but I am very hopeful that this will help solve many of the problems we have been stuck with.

Sandeep Singh: What is the one fault line in the economy's growth?

It's energy prices and availability. No large economy in the world, in history, has grown to prosperity without controlling its own sources of energy. And we are deeply vulnerable to global energy market volatility. We have to solve this. Some of the technology shifts are helping in that direction. But that vulnerability will remain with us for the next 10-12 years. I am hopeful that vulnerability will not become a constraint.

There are other things, like political consensus on growth. Right now, everyone wants to grow and that's a very welcome trend. I see that within the government

and the economy: social acceptability of wealth creation. That consensus is generally very fragile and we need to actively monitor it, because the moment that consensus breaks, it shifts to what New York is seeing now.

Siddharth Upasani: The Chief Economic Advisor has said that wage growth has not kept pace with private sector profit growth. A new paper by the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister has said firm level investments have not kept pace with profits. Why is the private sector sitting on cash?

There was a period when people were selling stakes in their own companies because stock prices were so high, and depleting it back into the stock market. They were diversifying. That's not entrepreneurship. These family offices were doing what I call lazy investments. Now, that easy money is gone. So, you are seeing Indian businesses diversifying into businesses with high return on capital, like paints, glue or jewellery. Everyone has their own risk appetite. Once the data centre business model became slightly more attractive, everyone made a bet for it.

Let the surpluses accumulate. India's entrepreneurs will not invest because we ask them to; they will invest when they see the opportunity. One reason cash has been accumulating is that companies were deleveraging because of the scarring of 2016 and the policy shift that happened. The Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code of 2016 was a transformative event where large companies found that they could lose assets and control of their businesses. It affected their willingness to take on debt. Once you've repaid the debt and are sitting on cash, you're not just going to issue dividends; if you have entrepreneurship left, you will set up new business lines. So, I don't see it as a structural problem. It takes time and we have to stay patient.

Sandeep Singh: What about the long-term stock market investor who has seen his money not move at all for the last three years?

On some measures, the equity premium got negative in 2023. The market was so expensive that it seemed stocks were less risky than government bonds — that's absolutely unsustainable. So, I had said (back then) that there's going to be a significant period of time correction where earnings keep going up, but the stock market still stays there, the PE multiple drifts down, and then it becomes suitable because equities are a risky asset class. I think we are still going through that.

Will it continue for a very large period? I don't think so. My view is that the economy is doing very well. Profit-to-GDP ratios don't move around beyond a certain band; right now, they're a bit elevated, but even if they come down, I think earnings growth will be high single-digit or low double-digit. In which case, the stock markets over a five-year period will give decent returns. That's how I invest my own money.

Deeptiman Tiwari: In an atmosphere of stagnating income and rising cost of living, consumption is being sustained by debt. Is consumption going to be sustained by a critical mass of people who have created enough wealth to sustain demand in the long run?

I don't agree with the assertion that consumption is being boosted by credit. Yes, there is clearly some boost that has come from that. But if you look at retail credit growth and then look at consumption growth, you'll find that it's like a rounding error. So, I don't think consumption is being boosted by credit.

At this stage of development, labour is in surplus, capital is in shortage. So, there is an inevitable rise in inequality at this stage. There are ways to address it, if we can democratise access to capital.

Aanchal Magazine: What are the next reforms being planned for Aadhaar 2.0?

We have done a number of things and some of them are still under way. The first is the Aadhaar app. Over the last three years, we have completely redesigned it. We now have more than four crore downloads. We are trying to get the flywheel moving so that people don't need to carry the Aadhaar card. There are a lot of services we have made available: address change, phone number change, face authentication — you can do all of that. Second, we were seeing a lot of discomfort with the Aadhaar Seva Kendras and the service quality. So, like Passport Seva Kendras, we are ramping up private sector-run (Aadhaar Kendras). We had an RFP; we identified the vendors, and 700 of these private Aadhaar Seva Kendras have started now. We also started a process of diligent monthly reviews on operating parameters. There was a point at which the pending backlog was one crore. Now, courtesy of the previous CEO, we have managed to bring it down to 5 lakh.

We have brought in agile computing, so that visibility of the organisation, the time it takes to drive projects, the ease with which the authority can review and see operating metrics, all of those things are happening.

{ WEEKLY CAPSULE }

Coffee drinkers have less fat

COFFEE DRINKERS may be getting more than an energy boost. A Finnish study found that people who drank more coffee tended to have less total and abdominal fat, more muscle, and healthier metabolic markers despite having similar BMI (body mass index). Higher coffee intake was also linked to lower levels of certain amino acids associated with insulin resistance and type 2 diabetes risk. The findings raise the possibility that hormonal pathways could help explain some of the previously-observed relationship between coffee consumption and metabolic health.



Tastiest cheese also good for gut

SCIENTISTS STUDYING three artisanal British cheeses found that the microbes responsible for their distinctive flavours may also offer surprising benefits for gut health. As the cheeses matured, helpful bacteria transformed their aroma and textures while potentially producing compounds linked to reduced inflammation, cholesterol regulation and appetite control. The study by the University of Reading included a soft white rind cheese aged for a little more than a week, a washed rind semi-soft cheese that matures over several weeks, and a semi-hard cheese aged in hay for about nine months.



Why walking is harder with age

AS WE age, the body appears to sacrifice walking efficiency in exchange for stability. Older adults stiffen the ankle more with each step, which may help prevent falls but also force the muscles to work harder while producing less forward motion. This leads to shorter strides, slower walking and faster fatigue. Exercises targeting balance, coordination and lower-leg strength could help preserve mobility. Led by researchers at Flinders University and the University of Canberra, the study found that aging is associated with a "safety-first" walking strategy.



A nerve link to breast cancer

RESearchers at the University of Oklahoma have uncovered a surprising way triple-negative breast cancer may turn the body against itself. Tumours appear to recruit macrophages—immune cells normally involved in healing and fighting infection—and use them to release a protein called BDNF that draws nerves into the tumour. Those nerves may then help the cancer grow, resist treatment and potentially spread. Instead of focussing only on destroying cancer cells, future therapies might interrupt the signalling between macrophages and the nerves that appear to support tumour growth.



Stress hormone repairs the brain

A SURPRISING stress-related signal may help the brain repair itself after injury. Researchers at the Max Planck Institute of Psychiatry found that myelin-producing precursor cells rapidly release the stress hormone CRH near damaged brain tissue, helping control how those cells mature and rebuild nerve insulation. The same system also influences brain development and the thickness of myelin later in life. The findings could offer new clues about how early-life stress contributes to psychiatric disorders. The CRH response can be detected within a few hours after injury, but shuts down after three days.



When the inspector leaves: Can food safety become a daily habit?

The challenge is making hygiene, training and safe food handling routine rather than something businesses scramble to fix when inspections intensify

Anuradha Mascarenhas

AT THE 90-year-old Poona Guest House, known for its authentic Maharashtrian cuisine, food safety is not left to chance. Third-generation owner Kishore Sarpotdar ensures pest control is carried out twice a month. He checks refrigerator temperatures, cooking oil registers and staff training and makes sure hand-wash stations have soap and water. Exhaust systems, insect-proof doors and windows are also part of his checklist. Sarpotdar, who is also president of the Pune Restaurants and Catering Association, regularly checks with members to ensure that restaurants comply with the requirements of the Food and Drug Administration (FDA) and the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI). It is a routine that has been followed for years but there's a reason why Sarpotdar is checking again. Since Tukaram Mundhe took charge as Maharashtra FDA Commissioner in May, inspection drives have intensified. The association has been sending reminders to restaurant owners to ensure that compliance requirements are being followed. "By and large, owners of food outlets and restaurants have adhered to compliance requirements. Still, I double-check to ensure our members are fully compliant," says Sarpotdar.

That perhaps captures the larger problem with India's food safety regime. The country does not lack rules, it lacks the ability to ensure that rules consistently translate into everyday practice. Between May 25 and July 31, FDA records show that more than 3,000 inspections were conducted across the state, resulting in 165 licence suspensions and 750 improvement notices. Pune recorded the highest number of complaints. Between May 25 and August 19, the Pune division alone saw 691 inspections, with 53 licences suspended and 408 improvement notices issued. The fundamental question is why should food safety compliance improve sharply when inspections intensify, instead of being embedded in the way food businesses operate every day? Mundhe, who has been transferred 25 times over 21 years of service, told *The Indian Express* that preventive health must be linked to food safety. "Our health is paramount. A significant portion of disease burden comes from non-communicable diseases, and the food we consume plays an important role in our overall well-being. Our goal is to ensure safe, standardised food for a healthier future," he explains. But enforcement cannot remain permanently dependent on the intensity of a particular inspection drive. A food safety system must make compliance routine, not reactive.

Rules are changing but awareness is still catching up
Effective April 1 this year, FSSAI revised its turnover-based licensing categories.



Food businesses with an annual turnover of up to Rs 1.5 crore must obtain FSSAI registration; those with a turnover between Rs 1.5 crore and Rs 50 crore require a State FSSAI licence; and businesses with turnover above Rs 50 crore require a Central FSSAI licence. The distinction is important because India's food sector ranges from small local vendors and retailers to large restaurants, manufacturers, importers and exporters. FSSAI has issued around 26,000 licences across Maharashtra, Gujarat, Goa and Madhya Pradesh, covering five-star restaurants as well as importers and exporters dealing with essential commodities entering through various ports. Yet, even among larger licensed businesses, inspections in the western region identified around 2,300 improvement notices last year. A licence establishes that a business is within the regulatory system. It does not necessarily establish that safe practices are being consistently followed.

For Prithvi Chaudhary, regional director at FSSAI (Western Region), the major cause of non-compliance is lack of awareness and education. Over the past three to four years, FSSAI has trained street vendors, students and other groups to detect adulteration and promote food safety practices. Farmer-connect programmes have also been launched to connect food businesses and farmers. "In Mumbai, we've trained around 10,000 street food vendors and held over 60 officer-led training programmes focused on street hygiene. Personal hygiene is vital for food safety. We are witnessing improved food preparation and serving practices, with vendors using headgear, steel chopping boards and smarter waste disposal methods," he says.

Training cannot become another box to tick

That is why Akash Chakor, founder of Foodkida, a food auditing and consultancy firm, argues that food safety training and certification, or FoSTac, should be mandatory before a food licence is issued. "Many food operators lack awareness of food safety laws and do not even know about FoSTac.



Completing basic food safety training before starting operations helps them understand their responsibilities and maintain safe, hygienic practices," Chakor says. His larger point is that training cannot end with certification. "Businesses must actually understand and implement what they have been taught. Otherwise, training risks becoming another compliance document rather than a mechanism for changing behaviour." A refrigerator may have to be maintained at a prescribed temperature to ensure food does not go bad; an employee may have to follow a particular hygiene protocol; a food outlet may have to maintain a register. The existence of a checklist does not guarantee that any of these things are happening consistently when an inspector is not present.

Enforcement should not be a numbers game

India's regulatory framework is extensive. The more difficult question is how enforcement resources are deployed. Pawan Agarwal, former CEO of FSSAI, believes the system needs to move beyond intensive inspection. "Visible and credible action, as seen in Maharashtra, can change behaviour. However, long delays between violation detection and final accountability weaken deterrence. Not all violations pose the same health risk, so regulatory efforts should prioritise foods, establishments and supply chains with the highest risk, including microbial and chemical hazards that are not always visible during inspections," he explains. He calls for faster case adjudication, credible evidence, proportionate penalties and transparency about outcomes, including when allegations do not hold.

Sarpotdar, in discussions with FDA officials, has urged a "rational" approach to enforcement. If minor compliance issues persist, businesses should be given time to correct them without public shaming, especially iconic brands whose reputation could be harmed unnecessarily. A regulator has to distinguish between a minor deficiency that can be corrected and a serious violation that poses public health risk. "The real challenge is sustained compliance without making the system dependent on periodic crackdowns," says Sarpotdar.

The gaps go beyond kitchens and restaurants

The implementation problem is larger

than restaurant hygiene. Dr Arun Gupta, convener of Nutrition Advocacy in Public Interest (NAPI), believes immediate action is needed to assess risks and generate data about consumption of ultra-processed foods. "Food safety means protection from deceptive practices by food manufacturers. Much remains to be done. Pending consumer protections like Front-of-Pack Labeling (FOP) and tighter restrictions on marketing ultra-processed and high-fat/sugar/salt (HFSS) foods, major regulatory gaps will defeat the purpose of normalising clean dining," he says.

His argument expands the definition of what food regulation has to accomplish. Food safety is not merely about clean kitchens, pest control or properly stored ingredients. It also concerns what consumers are told about food, how products are marketed and whether the regulatory system keeps pace with changes in what Indians eat. The complexity is only increasing as the food industry expands into nutraceuticals and functional foods.

The laboratory infrastructure matters too

Dr Minal Jain, director of Adhrysa Life Science Pvt Ltd, an NABL-accredited food testing lab, points to another weak link between regulation and implementation: the capacity to detect and establish violations. India's food safety regulations, she says, are elaborate. "But implementation is often weakened by poor enforcement, manpower shortages, inspection capacity limits, delayed test results and lack of coordination among agencies. We need to shift from a reactive, routine approach toward a risk-based system focused on high-risk foods, supply chains and repeat violators," she says.

She also calls for robust laboratory infrastructure, advanced analytical capacity, and speedy access to test results—especially important given the growing complexity of the food industry with nutraceuticals and functional foods.

A regulator can inspect a food business, but if laboratory results are delayed or enforcement action takes too long, the deterrent effect is weakened. Equally, if inspection teams do not have the manpower to identify the highest-risk businesses and supply chains, the existence of detailed rules matters little.

Can hip-hop make children choose healthier food?

A Columbia University-inspired pilot project is trying to make nutrition fun

Purnima Sah

"HEALTHY FOOD, Happy Moves, Healthy You," a group of children chant, holding up placards with the slogan thought of by them, featuring fruits, vegetables and wholesome bread. Music starts and the students follow a sequence of dance steps. Between the moves, they are asked to identify healthy and unhealthy foods, the ones that make them ill and the ones that keep them smiling.

It looks more like a dance class than a conventional nutrition lesson. But at a school in Nalopara in Mumbai's northern outskirts, this is part of a larger experiment: can music and culture make healthy eating more appealing to children—and, crucially, change what they choose to eat? For Class VI student Aarna G, the dance routine has built a memory of foods she eats. "A certain song and move reminds me of the chant after it. 'Eat paneer, you will get calcium and protein.' When we are told something through music, it stays with us for a longer period," she says. The demonstration is part of Hip Hop Nutrition India, a programme being culturally adapted by Columbia University and the Mumbai-based Society for Nutrition, Education and Health Action (SNEHA). The Nalopara school is currently in the pilot stage. The experiment comes as Maharashtra takes a more direct approach to children's food environment. The state Food and Drug Administration has issued a statewide order enforcing the Food Safety and Standards (Safe Food and Balanced Diets for Children in School) Regulations, 2020, which prohibit the sale, advertising and free distribution of high-fat, high-sugar and high-salt foods and beverages on school premises and within a 50-metre radius.

Is changing the food environment enough if children themselves do not change their choices? "The focus groups with students, teachers and parents were aimed at understanding the daily lives of children—what they eat, where they eat, what they bring in their tiffins, whether they use the school canteen and what nutritional choices are available to them," says Willibord George, founder of St Willibord Schools, the pilot site. Researchers are examining more than nutrition knowledge. They are looking at food availability at home and school, parental purchasing decisions, children's habits and the social and economic factors that make some foods easier to choose than others.

For Dr Olajide Williams, Professor of Neurology and Co-Director of the Columbia Center for Community Health at Columbia University Irving Medical Center, this distinction is the pivot. "The overarching goal is to make healthy eating culturally irresistible," he says. His experience in New York suggests that simply providing more information is unlikely to produce lasting change. "An information deficit alone is not driving the problem," he says. The larger challenge, according to him, lies in the forces that shape children's everyday decisions: access, cost and culture, alongside what he calls an "attentional imbalance." Ultra-processed foods, he observes, are supported by enormous marketing budgets that associate them with modernity, pleasure, celebrity and aspiration, while healthier foods receive far less attention. The programme cannot compete with the food industry on advertising spending. Its proposition is different: "Perhaps we can out-culture it" by giving healthy food the emotional appeal that commercial marketing has long given less healthy products—through music, celebrity, aspiration and cultural resonance.

That idea is being tested in an adapted form in India rather than being simply imported from the US. Earlier research cited by the project found improvements in children's ability to interpret calorie information and a reduction in the calorie content of foods they purchased. Researchers not only want to know whether children's knowledge and food choices change but whether they carry those lessons home and influence what families buy or prepare. The project describes this as a potential "ripple effect," with children acting as change agents within their households. That matters in a country facing multiple nutrition challenges. The NFHS (National Family Health Survey) -6 data show a decline in childhood stunting and severe wasting, even as obesity among adults has increased.

● Improving food safety in restaurants can contribute to better community health by reducing exposure to foodborne pathogens. Restaurants are an important point of transmission because food is prepared in large quantities and served to many people.

● A population-level study was conducted in Los Angeles County, USA, following the introduction of a publicly displayed restaurant hygiene grading system in 1998.

Researchers compared foodborne-disease hospitalisations in Los Angeles County with trends elsewhere in California. After adjustment for baseline temporal and geographic trends, implementation of the grading programme was associated with a 13.1% reduction in foodborne-disease hospitalisations in the first year. The reduction was sustained over two years, providing relatively strong



Studies show how food outlet safety reduces pathogens

evidence that restaurant-focused food-safety regulation can translate into measurable improvements in community health.

● A 2022 systematic review and meta-analysis of food safety interventions in catering establishments found that interventions were associated with a 28.6% reduction in microbial contamination. The review included interventions involving food-

handler training and food safety systems.

● Food safety at restaurants has been effective in reducing pathogens such as norovirus, salmonella typhi (causes typhoid fever), Shiga Toxin-Producing E. coli (affects kidney), shigella (infection of the intestinal lining), hepatitis A (impacts the liver) listeria monocytogenes and campylobacter (trigger gut infection).

WHEN FOOD SAFETY MEANT BETTER HEALTH

Ex-captains write to Pakistan government again for Imran

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 23

TWENTY-ONE former international captains from around the world have written to Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, renewing their appeal for medical treatment for former skipper Imran Khan. The signatories include former India captains Sunil Gavaskar, Kapil Dev and Dilip Vengsarkar. The latest letter marks the former captain's second appeal in six months. In February, 14 former captains had written to Sharif expressing concern over Khan's health after reports of an eye condition that his family said had left him almost completely blind in one eye, amid allegations of medical neglect in prison.

"Dear Prime Minister, six months ago, fourteen former international cricket captains wrote to you and the Pakistani government appealing for humane treatment and proper medical care for Imran Khan. We wrote then not as politicians, but as concerned citizens and rivals who share a bond forged on the cricket field, one that transcends the borders and disputes that too often divide countries. We write again now, joined by seven further former captains, because of what has reportedly just occurred," the letter reads.

"Pakistan's Supreme Court ordered that Imran Khan be transferred to a hospital for examination by a medical board to be made up to include his own personal physicians and his sister, Dr Uzma Khan. The Court also reinstated weekly family visits."

"Concerningly, Mr Khan's hospital stay lasted only a few hours. He was examined by a state-appointed team rather than the board the Court had directed, declared 'medically fit,' and returned to Adiala Jail before that board could complete its work," the letter added.

"The medical board directed by the Supreme Court — including Mr Khan's own doctors — be permitted to complete a full and independent assessment of his health, particularly the reported loss of vision in his right eye."

"That the weekly family visits reinstated by the Court be honoured without interruption or administrative delay."

"That whatever the outcome of that medical assessment, the treatment recommended by it be provided without delay."

"Whatever the legal and political arguments surrounding his case, the basic decency of ensuring a court-ordered medical process is actually completed is not, in our view, a controversial request."

Captains' list: Michael Atherton, Alex Blackwell, Allan Border, Michael Breasley, Greg Chappell, Ian Chappell, Belinda Clark, Alastair Cook, Michael Gatting, Sunil Gavaskar, Lee Gernon, Adam Gilchrist, David Gower, Kim Hughes, Nasser Hussain, Clive Lloyd, Kapil Dev, Arjuna Ruwa, Andre Strauss, Dilip Vengsarkar, Steve Waugh, John Wright

SRI LANKA VS INDIA, SECOND TEST

Padikkal strengthens hold on No.3 spot with another ton

Left-hander's 117 and a half-century from Gill headline a dominant opening day for the visitors

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, August 23

BEFORE THE Sri Lanka tour, India had tried as many as seven batsmen at No.3 since June 2023. One of them was Devdutt Padikkal, who played at that position against Australia in Perth in 2024. In his second outing at Galle last week, he showed he had the tools for the role by making 167 and 44. On Day 1 of the second Test in Colombo, the 26-year-old showed Galle was no one-off, making 117 off 193 balls to further strengthen his claim to the No.3 spot and lead India to 300/5.

Padikkal's century in Galle was an innings of authority. He showed early intent, launching Prabhath Jayasuriya for six before settling into a knock built around early judgment of length and playing the ball late. He repeatedly used the depth of his crease, defended with soft hands and punished anything short, wide or on his pads. Even when he accelerated, he never looked rushed.

The innings in Colombo was different. He looked scratchy and uncertain early on Sunday and also got two reprieves, on 0 and 1.

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"I don't think that is a relevant question (On whether Kulkarni would have played if he was fully fit). Because if he is not fit, how will he think if he plays or not? And genuinely, he had a viral fever when we left Galle."

If the team needs an off-spinner and he doesn't play, there is no need to say he wasn't well. But when the guy is not in a position



Devidutt Padikkal followed up his century in Galle with another one in Colombo, scoring 117 off 193. CINEMAS

Jayasuriya varied his pace and trajectory. Padikkal's response was to look to survive against the duo. He played late and with soft hands, willing to defend rather than force the issue.

That patience eventually paid off. Once he settled, Padikkal began finding his range. He used the depth of the crease against the spinners, rocking back to cut shorter deliveries and getting forward when they overpitched. He lofted the ball over the offside and drove the full and wide deliveries. When the pacers pitched it short, he brought out the pull shot.

His half-century, reached with a crisp drive off Jayasuriya, was therefore markedly different from the one in Galle. There, his knock was defined by fluency. In Colombo, what stood out was his ability to adapt, survive an uncomfortable start and gradually turn a difficult passage into another big score.

The left-hander grew increasingly assured after tea. He cut and drove with authority,

handled Jayasuriya particularly well and brought up a second Test hundred with a single after consecutive boundaries off the left-arm spinner in the 70th over. On 117, though, he made his only error against spin, going back to Nuwantha when he should have been forward, and lost his off-stump.

Captain comes to party

Shubman Gill gave Padikkal good company with a patient half-century after his twin failures at Galle, where Jayasuriya had dismissed him in both innings. In Colombo, he brought a calmer approach.

The skipper trusted his defence, got forward to fuller deliveries and was happy to shoulder arms when the Sri Lankan bowlers drifted to defensive lines by bowling outside the leg-stump.

His first boundary off the left-arm spinner summed up his approach. Gill went deep inside the crease to a short ball and whipped it through mid-wicket. Later, when Jayasuriya

overpitched, he skipped down and drove cleanly over mid-off. In between came long passages of patient defence, soft hands and careful strike rotation as he refused to offer the spinner the chances he had in Galle.

Apart from Jayasuriya, against whom he scored 23 of his 50 runs, Gill also grew in confidence against Nuwantha, picking up 16 runs off the right-arm. He was equally assured against the seamers. He left well outside off, drove Asitha Fernando elegantly through the covers and flicked anything on his pads, gradually settling into an innings as the overs trickled down. His fifty came off 99 balls, but unlike Galle, it ended not with a lapse against spin but with a loose slash outside off against Fernando, edging behind after well-made 50 and ending a 120-run stand with Padikkal.

After Rishabh Pant retired hurt on 3 after getting hit on his left forearm by Kumara, India needed stability, as Ravindra Jadeja joined Padikkal in the

Scorecard

SRI LANKA vs INDIA	
COLOMBO	
Toss: India won, chose to bat	
INDIA	
Yashasvi Jaiswal b Fernando	45 (53b, 9x4)
KL Rahul c Dickwella b Kumara	18 (33b, 2x4, 1x6)
Devidutt Padikkal b Nuwantha	117 (193b, 12x4)
Shubman Gill c Dickwella b Fernando	50 (108b, 6x4)
Rishabh Pant retired hurt	3 (15b)
Ravindra Jadeja b Fernando	43 (83b, 4x4)
Dhruv Jurel not out	7 (21b, 1x4)
Saransh Jain not out	4 (5b, 1x4)
EXTRAS (b 4, lb 3, nb 1, w 5)	13
TOTAL (55 overs)	300/5
FW: 137 (KL Rahul 104 ov), 2 666 (Yashasvi Jaiswal 16.6 ov), 3 186 (Shubman Gill 51.5 ov), 3 207 (Rishabh Pant, retired not out), 4 281 (Devidutt Padikkal 76.2 ov), 5 296 (Ravindra Jadeja 84.1 ov)	
BOWLING: Asitha Fernando 16-5-46-3; Lahiru Kumara 14-3-38-1; Prabhath Jayasuriya 27-4-90-0; Keshara Nuwantha 22-0-93-1; Sonal Dinesha 1-0-0; Dhananjaya de Silva 2-0-6-0; Kamill Mishara 4-0-16-0	

middle. The veteran all-rounder gave good support to Padikkal, combining solid defence with drives and sweeps, but also needed treatment from the physio during his innings. However, just when it looked like he would see through the day, he was bowled by Fernando shouldering arms.

Before Padikkal and Gill steadied India's innings, Yashasvi Jaiswal's dismissal prompted some drama in the opening session. The left-hander scored a brisk 45 off 53 balls, including nine boundaries, before Fernando bowled him after the opener had struck three fours in the 17th over.

As Jaiswal walked back, he returned to confront Fernando, with the pair exchanging words before the batsman headbutted the bowler. Other players intervened quickly, separating them and preventing the incident from escalating further.

'Not relevant whether Kuldeep would have played if fit'

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 23

A MAJOR talking point in Colombo, even before a ball was bowled in the second Test, was the exclusion of Kuldeep Yadav from India's playing XI.

The left-arm wrist spinner was replaced by Saransh Jain, with the BCCI later confirming that Kuldeep had been ruled out after contracting a viral illness.

India batting coach Sitanshu Kotak clarified that Kuldeep's omission was purely due to illness and dismissed suggestions that there were any wider fitness concerns surrounding the spinner.

"I don't think that is a relevant question (On whether Kulkarni would have played if he was fully fit). Because if he is not fit, how will he think if he plays or not? And genuinely, he had a viral fever when we left Galle."

If the team needs an off-spinner and he doesn't play, there is no need to say he wasn't well. But when the guy is not in a position

to play, there is no point in thinking about whether he was fit or not. It would be very unfair to think that," he told reporters on Sunday.

Kotak added that although Kuldeep had recovered well since leaving Galle, his unavailability also affected India's team combination, with the visitors opting for an off-spinner against a Sri Lankan top order featuring four left-handers.

"When we left, he had a sore throat and then contracted viral fever. I think he has recovered reasonably well. He looked good when I met him in the evening, and so obviously he wasn't available for the match. So then it comes to whether we go with three fast bowlers or three spinners. And with them having four left-handers in the top order, it probably makes sense to play an off-spinner," he added.

Kotak was full of praise for Devdutt Padikkal, who registered his second successive Test hundred, saying that he had



Kuldeep Yadav was not available for the second Test against Sri Lanka in Colombo. CINEMAS

made the most of the chance that had come his way in Sai Sudharsan's absence.

"I think Devdutt again battled really well. Shown great

temperament. He made the most out of the opportunity he has got. So, really happy for him."

"For me, the intent is on, the temperament is on and with the pace he batted as well, he batted with a very good strike rate. So, the way he batted is a really, really good sign for us. And, like

SITANSHU KOTAK,
ON KULDEEP YADAV'S STATUS

"I said last time when I came as well, he has been waiting for his turn for the last year, year and a half, or maybe two years. I am so happy with the way he prepared when he got that opportunity because Sai had an injury, he made the most out of it. So, really happy for him," Kotak said.

On whether Padikkal had made the No.3 position his own, Kotak pointed to Sudharsan's impressive returns before injury ruled him out.

"I think he batted really well at number three. But I feel even Sai Sudharsan batted really well at number three. He got out on 90 and 85 or something like that. But Devdutt, obviously converted into hundreds. Both are young batters, and they batted well. So they can open; they can also go at three also. The way Devdutt bats, in the past he can bat at five also. So it's not — it's more promising for us, the way he approached the game and he delivered when the team needed him to play and score runs."

Kotian sends selectors reminder with 4 wkts

Venkata Krishna B
Bengaluru, August 23

IF THE choice had been left to Tanush Kotian, he would have bowled unchanged from one end. On the opening day of India's domestic season, the Mumbai all-rounder had no desire to part with the red ball. Playing for West Zone in their quarterfinal against North Zone, Kotian took four wickets and two sharp diving catches — one off his own bowling — as West restricted North to 251 at the BCCI Centre of Excellence. West were 31/2 at stumps, leaving the contest evenly poised.

There was a surprise as soon as North elected to bat at Ground 1. West captain Ruturaj Gaikwad opened the bowling with Kotian's off-spin. The turn he extracted immediately showed why. West had found the surface on the dry side before the game and expected it to grip, particularly with some moisture around. The live grass, they felt, was not going to deceive them; if anything, it was helping hold the surface together.

Kotian went wicketless in his first three-over spell, but Mumbai teammates Shardul Thakur and Tushar Deshpande made the early inroads. Deshpande, in particular, bowled with serious pace, consistently touching 150kph as he removed North's top order of Qasim Iqbal, Ayush Badoni and Abdul Samad.

Iqbal was bowled by a yorker, Badoni's attempted slash ended in the wicket-keeper's hands and Samad lost his stumps. Even as Deshpande provided the breakthroughs, Kotian kept tolling.

A consistent performer for Mumbai with bat and ball, Kotian had replaced R Ashwin in India's Test squad but has since slipped down the pecking order. Saransh Jain's Test debut in Colombo on Sunday, after he was preferred to Kotian during the India A series in Sri Lanka, was another indication of the selectors' favouritism.

Kotian, though, served notice that he is not going to make it easy for Jain. Gaikwad knew what he could offer, having seen him bowl in Sri Lanka, where Kotian was part of the India A squad. Despite having had little match practice in the off-season, he had bowled plenty of overs there and showed no signs of lacking rhythm.

On a surface offering turn, Kotian became Gaikwad's best option to attack and defend. He began with a short leg, leg slip and slip in place, and finished him at 47/2 from 20.5 overs, consistently finding drift, turn and control.

"I had that confidence because I was with the India team in Sri Lanka. I got to bowl a lot at the nets over there. In Mumbai, it was raining, so I couldn't get outdoor sessions. In Sri Lanka, I got those outdoor sessions and bowled to brilliant batsmen. It helped me accurately catch and get that bite and turn," Kotian said.

His off-season had also been spent working on the finer details of his bowling. During the IPL, he closely watched Ravindra Jadeja and worked with the American duo and the spinners' camp, he worked with Sunil Joshi at the Centre of



Tanush Kotian had figures of 4/72 in the quarterfinal against North Zone. PFI

Excellence before making further tweaks with Jatin Paranjape in Mumbai.

"I have improved a bit on my angles. I've changed a little bit in the run-up, especially running through the angles. And when there is wind, how to use the drift like here. I knew the wind was the main thing we had over here, so I was thinking of bowling with the drift and turn," he said.

When Badoni and Ayush Doesia were trying to build North's innings, Kotian was the bowler who consistently troubled them. Badoni did step out and hit him for a six over mid-wicket, but Kotian soon settled into a rhythm. Doesia, in particular, struggled to progress and survived a couple of close LBW appeals.

Just as the left-hander appeared to have weathered the spell and begun to look more comfortable against lefty left-arm spinner Shams Mulani, Kotian got another chance at him. Doesia was caught at silly point, giving Kotian his first wicket.

Once he had broken through, Kotian was into his stride. In his next over, he trapped North captain Kanhaiya Wadhawan before removing Anshul Kamboj for 60.

Kamboj's innings, off 52 balls and featuring a boundary and four sixes — all against Deshpande across two overs — had helped North recover. Without it, their total of 251 could have been considerably lower.

For Kotian, the four-wicket haul was an ideal way to begin a season in which he knows there is plenty at stake. His approach, however, remains simple: perform and leave the selection decisions to others.

"The mentality is to do well in each and every innings I get. In bowling and batting, I think of doing better. Selectors have their thing; if they have to select me, they will. I have to do my job — take wickets, score runs for my team and do better. Whatever opportunity comes, I have to grab it. On the score-board, getting four wickets or scoring a fifty or century is the thing. I've been doing it for Mumbai and I want to repeat it," he said.

BRIEF SCORES: Quarterfinals: North Zone 251 (Anshul Kamboj 60, Ayush Badoni 51, Ayush Doesia 42; Tushar Deshpande 4/57, Tanush Kotian 4/72) vs West Zone 31/2. East Zone 355/6 (Sudip Karmakar 146 not out, Shubaz Ahmed 100 not out, Kumar Kushagra 55; Pradham Jotin 3/53) vs North East Zone

BACK IN BUSINESS

Sinner out, Alcaraz back, battling Djokovic: US Open's three big storylines

Bhuvan Gupta
New Delhi, August 23

A LOT has changed in men's singles tennis since Carlos Alcaraz last competed.

The Spaniard, dethroned by Jannik Sinner from the topspot in April 2026, has now been dropped to world number three. The man who replaced him at No.2 — Alexander Zverev — has snapped a six-year losing streak at Grand Slam finals. Zverev's fellow French Open finalist Flavia Cobolli, meanwhile, has risen from 44th to sixth.

Cobolli was narrowly missed a top-four seeding at the upcoming US Open, and Novak Djokovic is the beneficiary as he won't have to face Alcaraz or Zverev before the semifinals at Flushing Meadows. With Sinner having withdrawn, the

39-year-old has a shot at avoiding the gruelling early-round five-setters that have repeatedly derailed his quest for a record 25th Major title.

Djokovic, Sinner and Alcaraz are lining up with 'body blows' in different ways. The Spaniard is battling wear and tear from 22 years on the circuit. The Italian numero uno is reeling from a right knee injury that has kept him away from Montreal, Cincinnati and now New York. Alcaraz is returning from a four-month layoff, caused by a condition clinically known as tenosynovitis. The fluid-filled protective layer (synovial membrane) around his wrist's tendon was inflamed during the Barcelona Open, making joint motion hard and painful. For someone possessing one of the best forehands in the game, not

being able to grip and swing the racket freely is possibly the worst nightmare and could take several match hours to overcome.

A fit-again Alcaraz is starting that journey with the US Open's mixed doubles showpiece. He has partnered Serena Williams, who is on a remarkable comeback road herself. The 39-time Grand Slam winner — 23 of them singles — has returned four years after "evolving away from tennis" post the 2022 edition of the American Major.

Williams has played three doubles matches, the most recent one with elder sister Venus, since June. Her only singles appearance so far has been at Wimbledon, where she lost in straight sets to Maya Joint in the first round and sustained a knee injury on top of



Carlos Alcaraz will aim to win his third US Open title. REUTERS

that. She will not be part of the singles line-up in Queens, as the last remaining wildcard was handed to 2020 Australian Open champion Sofia Kenin.

Glitzzy mixed doubles

The 44-year-old has found

memories at the US Open mixed doubles competition. Before claiming six singles titles at her home Slam, Williams had bagged a mixed doubles crown at the event back in 1998. She had teamed up with Max Mirnyi, who now

coaches women's singles No.1 Aryna Sabalenka.

Sabalenka is also part of the star-studded mixed doubles roster this year. She has paired with Djokovic, while Iga Swiatek has joined Casper Ruud, Jessica Pegula and Taylor Fritz. But Devdutt Padikkal and Kulkarni's Elina Svitolina has partnered husband Gael Monfils. It will be Monfils' last Major outing before he walks into the sunset. Pegula and Fritz joined forces after their previous partners, Jack Draper and Elena Rybakina, pulled out with injuries. Further, Diana Shnaider will have a chance to find a new partner after Daniil Medvedev withdrew.

Besides the six direct entrants picked on the basis of combined singles rankings, eight pairs have received wild

cards, including defending champions and doubles specialists Sara Errani and Andrea Vassori. Two others will emerge from an eight-team qualifying round, which will be played on Monday.

If in 2025, the two-day, 16-team contest is more of an exhibition event than the serious one it used to be. Matches comprise best-of-three sets up to four games, with a sudden-death decider at 40-40 and a 10-points tiebreak instead of a third set. In the final, sets will be played to six games instead of four, with no-ads scoring and tie-breaks at six-0.

Playing mixed doubles before he starts his singles title defence might just help Alcaraz ease into his ever-attracting 19th. The 23-year-old had circumspectly returned to

training in July, and was snapped hitting balls fluently at a training session in Spain on August 4, BBC reported. But Alcaraz decided to withdraw from the Cincinnati Open the next day, perhaps indicating the vulnerability that comes with an injury as potentially career-threatening as this.

The wrist is an integral part of Alcaraz's gameplay anyway, with the tremendous spin he imparts on his forehand groundstrokes standing testimony.

Whether he can revert to his free-flowing self who was the real-life challenger to Sinner's dominance will only be known once the singles main draw gets underway on August 30. Until then, it's time for the fun and games of mixed doubles alongside a bonafide legend.

BWF WORLD CHAMPIONSHIPS

Double delight in Delhi makes France badminton powerhouse

Lanier wins men's singles while Thom Giquel-Delphine Delrue take mixed doubles; Koreans also clinch two golds

Shivani Naik
New Delhi, August 23

THE FRENCH aren't really expecting a revolution; even though the imminent European powerhouse have struck two Badminton World Championship golds, the first in mixed doubles through Thom Giquel and Delphine Delrue and then in men's singles via Alex Lanier.

Unprecedented in the sport with too many protocols, the French came prepared with champagne bottles.

"I'll probably walk on the road in France and nobody will notice. But there could be a little storm for a few weeks," Lanier, who took 50 minutes to defeat Japanese compulsi-

retriever Kodai Naraoka, said.

The Frenchman, who was first identified by scouts from Normandy because he looked more muscular than others his age, used a flex to rattle Kodai too: the Popeye with sailor parents from rural seaside France ran in the eyeline of the Japanese and flaunted his abs. A21-11, 21-11 scoreline followed, and Kodai told the Japanese media he was intimidated already.

"It's genetics because my parents are sailors, but also my hard work in breaking limits of physicality has been important," Lanier says, having outrun the peak runner Kodai. "Frankly, I can play one more game."

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psychology.

Mixed doubles champ Giquel would speak of the Wankanda celebration he had promised his niece. Giquel-Delrue would inflict heartbreak on World No.1 Chinese, Feng Yan Zhe and Huang Dong Ping, winning 22-20, 19-21, 21-15.

The first big pair they ever scalped had been Yuta Watanabe and Higashino in a Super 100. But even as recently as last Sunday, Giquel-Delrue had said Danish pairs ranked higher than they were better. A world title will flip the self-perception. "No body would be waiting for us at airports. There's so many sports in France," Giquel would say.

The French travel with a multicultural support staff comprising French, Danish, Lithuanians and even Icelanders, and trained simulating the slow conditions. They are also cognizant about being a nascent powerhouse. "We focus on not overtraining. Because we are not China. Where if anyone rips an ACL, they can just get in another," French coach Kestus Naviklas said.

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France's Delphine Delrue and Thom Giquel (L) and men's singles champion Alex Lanier (R). ABHINAV SAHA



you?" Wang would ask An Se-young, who has an intimidating head-to-head against her. "You should work hard," the Korean would answer.

"Do you mean to say I don't work hard already?" Wang would retort as both burst into laughter as the ice was broken between the two rivals.

Earlier, An had lauded the Delhi crowd that screamed vociferously for the all-conquering World No.1. "Lot of people were supporting me which gave me energy," she would say, thanking returning coach Park Joo Bong with "It's an honour to be coached by a legend."

The Chinese were at a risk of returning without a title for the first time since 1983 after the first four finals were done. But men's doubles pair Wang Chang and Liang Wei-keng pulled one back. Wang was in terrific form prancing around the court, outdoing Aaron Chia and Soh Wooi Yik playing their last tournament together. The 21-17, 21-16 win gave the Chinese their first world title. "It's the

best day of my life," a pumped up Wang said. "Like a dream."

The Chinese, who failed to make singles finals, had also gone down in women's doubles, losing to Korean Baek Ha Na and Lee So Hee. It brought Korea the title they had lost won 31 years ago after defeating Liu Sheng Shu and Tan Ning 21-15, 21-15.

The Koreans defended until the moment they would pull out a kill. "The Chinese are so good at attack that we decided to fall back on defence and keep the shuttle inside the court," Baek would say. "We have been eating butter chicken and naan, and will celebrate later in the evening."

Treesa Jolly-Gayatri Gopichand, who received their bronze medals, vowed to find solutions to beating the Chinese. For the moment though, a celebration might take place in Hyderabad though Treasa enjoyed the breakthrough with a banana cookie ice-cream as the Worlds drew to a close with several unexpected medallists.

India Open 750 shifted to Guwahati for 2028 edition

THE INDIA Open Super 750 tournament will be shifted to Guwahati for the 2028 edition due to the tournament clashing with the Republic Day in New Delhi, Badminton Association of India secretary Sanjay confirmed on Sunday.

The tournament held at the IG Indoor Stadium in New Delhi, will move to the National Center of Excellence of Badminton in Guwahati for one season. "The 2027 India Open will happen in Delhi. But for 2028, we will shift it to Guwahati because around 28th January to 30th January clashes with the 26th January celebration," said Mishra after the conclusion of the World Championships in New Delhi. ENS

Australia women in semis while India's WC podium hopes end

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, August 23

ON THIS occasion, there was no magic.

Sjoerd Marjine and the Indian women's hockey team had been here before — Australia standing between them and a historic semi-final. The Tokyo Olympics. India, in the August of 2021, had defended valiantly for most of the game, and generated only one penalty corner as opposed to Australia's six. That was all that they needed.

Five Augusts later, India needed to replicate what they did at the Olympics. The Netherlands had done them a favour by beating China. With a win against Australia, India would have been in the women's hockey World Cup semifinals for the first time since 1974. For long stretches in Amstelveen, the echoes of Tokyo were unmistakable. Wave after wave of Australian pressure was absorbed by India's defensive resilience. Only this time, there was no goal, and no escape. With a 0-0 draw, Australia qualified for the semis on the basis of more goals scored.

The Hockeyroos only needed a draw. Prior to the game, coach Rhett Halkett was asked whether his team would play accordingly. He would have none of it. "It's not in Australia's nature to go out and play for a draw," he said.

What, then, is the Australian way of playing games where a draw would suffice? It took all but 73 seconds for Halkett's rejoinder to arrive. Grace Stewart found a way through, only for the goal to be chalked off by the TV umpire for dangerous play.

One could have borrowed the Coldplay lyricbook to summarise the first 10 minutes of the game — it was, indeed, all yellow. Australia had more than 60 percent of the possession, pinning India back and dictating the rhythm. Amy Lawton tried to break through in the 10th minute, but between her and the goal



The Indian women's team failed to breach Australia's defence. H

stood the goalkeeper who, before long, will become India's most capped women's hockey player — Savita Punia.

Australia resumed much as they had begun, earning a penalty corner just 87 seconds into the second quarter. But if there is one certainty about Marjine's India, it is that they know how to defend. They conceded only three goals in the first round, with only the Netherlands conceding fewer. Add to it Australia's underwhelming penalty corner conversion rate — 14.71 percent before this game, 13th among the 16 teams — and the result was along expected lines. No goal.

Missed opportunity

Trailing on nearly every metric, and having not generated a shot for 30 minutes, India earned their first penalty corner with 21 seconds remaining before half-time. Marjine, in more ways than one, reiterated in the build-up to the game that India must be clinical from penalty corners. On that attempt, they were anything but.

The coach's message to the team at half-time was to play freely, but freedom remained elusive. Only four minutes later, India needed Savita to play the saviour again. Had it not been for her save, Stephanie Kershaw would have scored her second goal of this World Cup. As it was

in the first two quarters, Australia fashioned the opening chance of the third. Grace Young's effort in the 34th minute was on target, but her precision was dwarfed by Savita's experience. Four minutes later, the veteran came to India's rescue again, denying Kershaw again.

But Kershaw kept knocking, and in the 40th minute, converted from a penalty corner. Or so she thought — until replays showed the ball had struck Shilpi Dabas' arm on the way in, and the TV umpire was India's best ally yet again.

For all of their territorial dominance, Australia had nothing to show on the scoreboard, but India nearly did in the dying stages of the third quarter. Baljeet Kaur burst down the right and, with the clock draining away, found Deepika in front of goal. The young forward swung at it, but her stick connected with nothing but air.

The starts to each quarter had belonged to Australia. In the fourth, they needed only 18 seconds to win yet another penalty corner. Once again, India's defence held. That, though, was not enough. As the evening drew to a close, Savita cut a desolate figure. The tears flowed freely. Her anguish impossible to conceal, impossible to console. She is 36. There might not be another August.

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